

My CEO Husband Gave Her My Corner Office

A Billionaire Marriage-in-Crisis Grovel Romance

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First Edition

Contents

Chapter 1 — Pip.....	5
Chapter 2 — Pip.....	12
Chapter 3 — Pip.....	21
Chapter 4 — Adam.....	29
Chapter 5 — Pip.....	36
Chapter 6 — Pip.....	43
Chapter 7 — Adam.....	49
Chapter 8 — Pip.....	57
Chapter 9 — Pip.....	64
Chapter 10 — Adam.....	71
Chapter 11 — Pip.....	78
Chapter 12 — Pip.....	85
Chapter 13 — Adam.....	92
Chapter 14 — Pip.....	99
Chapter 15 — Pip.....	104
Chapter 16 — Adam.....	113
Chapter 17 — Pip.....	120
Chapter 18 — Pip.....	127
Chapter 19 — Adam.....	135
Chapter 20 — Pip.....	142
Chapter 21 — Pip.....	149
Chapter 22 — Adam.....	156
Chapter 23 — Pip.....	161
Chapter 24 — Adam.....	168
Chapter 25 — Pip.....	174
Chapter 26 — Adam.....	181
Chapter 27 — Pip.....	187

Chapter 28 — Pip.....192

Chapter 29 — Pip.....201

Chapter 30 — Pip.....209

A Note to Readers.....216

Chapter 1 — Pip

My office is hanging in the sky over Monroe Avenue, turning a quarter inch at a time, and it has never looked better.

Walt Kasprzak has it on four chains off the hook of a hundred-ton crane that takes up both lanes and a bus stop. Snow is coming down sideways off the river, the small mean kind that gets into your collar and stays. Every streetlight on the block has a cone of it. In the middle of all that, ten feet by twelve of my own glass and cedar swings out of the fourth floor of the Lindqvist building like a drawer somebody finally opened.

“Lower,” I say into the radio. “Lower. Okay, stop, you’re kissing the mullion.”

“I’m not kissing anything,” Walt says. “I’m forty years married. I don’t kiss.”

“Your hook block is two inches off my glass.”

“Your glass is two inches off my hook block. It’s a matter of where you stand.”

Lolo is beside me on the sidewalk holding the tag line, both fists, leaning back like she’s got a marlin. She’s sixty-three, five foot one in her steel toes, and wearing a Clyde Park Lanes jacket with SPARE PARTS across the back in iron-on letters that have mostly given up. She came straight from second shift. She brought a thermos and drank all of it before the crane arrived, which I respect.

“Hon,” she says, not taking her eyes off the room, “if this thing comes down on a city bus I am telling everybody it was your idea.”

“It was my idea.”

“I know. That’s why it’ll stick.”

My key still worked when I let us in. Facilities moved the badge reader on Friday, but nobody moved the lock my father put in.

Up on four, Darnell is leaning out of the hole where the window bay used to be, one hand on the frame and the other giving Walt a thumbs-up he doesn’t need. The bay came out in eleven minutes. I designed it to come out in ten.

“What was the extra minute?” I ask him on the second radio.

“Somebody painted the bolts.” His voice comes down out of the sky and out of the radio half a second apart. “Facilities painted the bolts the same color as the wall. Who paints a bolt, Pip?”

“Somebody who thinks it’s never coming out.”

“Well, it’s out. I chipped them loose with your good chisel.”

“Not my good chisel.”

“You’ve got a lot of good chisels,” he says, and ducks back inside before I can ask which one.

The room clears the building. For a second it hangs there with nothing around it, the two glass walls meeting at the corner with no post between them, and the streetlight goes right through the corner and comes out the other side. No post. That corner took me three years and a burned eyebrow. I watch it with both hands pressed together under my chin, my kid walking out on a stage.

“Pretty,” Lolo says.

“Don’t.”

“I’m allowed to say pretty.”

“You’re holding a rope.”

Behind us, by the crane outrigger, the intern is filming. Tavi Okonkwo, twenty-three, two weeks into a six-month design internship, wearing a coat that was clearly purchased for a city with a gentler idea of January. He heard about this near midnight because he was still at his desk on four, and he asked if he could come, and I said yes because I couldn’t think of a reason fast enough to say no. He’s been filming for forty minutes with his phone held out in front of him, very steady, the way young people hold phones, like it’s a candle in a procession.

“You’re not posting that,” I tell him.

“No,” he says. “Definitely not, I would never.”

He keeps filming, holding the phone steadier than he’s holding his voice.

Elvin, the night guard from the Lindqvist lobby, comes out through the revolving door in his parka and stands on the step with his hands in his

armpits. He looks up at the room, then down at the bus stop the crane is parked on, then at me.

“Ms. Sobczak,” he says. “I’m going to need you to tell me this is fine.”

“It’s mine,” I say. “It’s always been mine. It’s on a lease to the company for a dollar a year, and I’m ending the lease.”

“Okay,” he says, and nods several times, as if the nodding is a form he has to fill out. “Is the dollar in there?”

“I’ll mail you the dollar, Elvin.”

“Mail it to Mr. Kerrigan,” he says, and goes back inside, and that’s the closest anybody comes all night to saying his name out loud.

The room comes down the last twenty feet like it’s being lowered onto a cake. Walt is the best crane man in West Michigan and he knows it and he makes you wait. The lowboy trailer is backed up against the curb with fresh cribbing laid across the deck, four stacks of six-by-sixes where the four lift points will sit.

“Lolo, walk it,” I say. “Ease it around. Corner to the cab.”

She walks it, leaning on the line, and the room turns its glass corner toward the truck cab as gently as you’d turn an old woman toward a better chair.

“Set,” says Walt, and it sets. The trailer takes the weight and sighs on its springs. The chains go slack and swing and clink against the cedar, and I’m across the sidewalk and up the trailer steps before Walt’s out of the cab, putting my hand flat on the glass by the corner. It’s cold enough to sting.

Inside, the room is empty except for my desk and my chair. I had Darnell carry everything else out before we unbolted it. Everything else means Simone Achterberg’s things. A ficus in a ceramic pot. A framed print of a lighthouse. A laptop dock. Two banker’s boxes she had unpacked halfway, so that her pens were already in my drawer and her stapler was already on my desk and a photo of a girl in a Michigan State sweatshirt was already looking out my window. We took all of it out. We stacked it all on the floor up on four, square, labels out, against the wall where my room used to be, with the ficus on top and the lighthouse leaning on the ficus. Darnell watered the ficus without anybody asking him to. That’s the kind of crew I have.

I want that noted somewhere. We didn't throw her things in the hall. We made a nice stack.

"Strap it," Walt says, coming around the trailer with his ratchet straps over his shoulder like a bandolier. "Then you can be emotional at it. And the pierogi."

"In my freezer by Thursday. Half's yours."

"Half of how many?"

"Walt."

"Half of how many, Pip. I'm standing in a bus stop at four in the morning."

"Four dozen."

He thinks about it with his jaw. "That's a fair half. Now strap it."

"I'm not emotional at it."

"You're touching the window."

I take my hand off the window. It leaves a print, five fingers and a palm, right at the joint.

There are three lines of pencil inside the door that I can just make out through the glass from here, writing on the birch ply in two different hands, and I don't look at them. I look at the straps. I check every ratchet myself, which Walt hates, and he lets me, which is why I hire him.

Near the end the snow lets up for a minute, like the weather wants to watch too. The crane's boom comes down in sections, groaning. Darnell comes out of the lobby with his hard hat under his arm and his face pink from the wind up on four.

"Bay's back in," he says. "Sealed. You'd never know."

"You'd know," Lolo says. "There's a hole in the floor where a room was."

"The floor's fine. It's four bolt plates."

"Four bolt plates and a lady's ficus."

"The ficus is watered," Darnell says, with dignity.

"He talked to it," Lolo says. "I could hear him from the stairwell."

"It's had a hard night," Darnell says, and puts his hard hat back on so he doesn't have to look at either of us.

Tavi is still filming, and now he's filming the bolt-plate conversation. I go over to him and he lowers the phone a quarter of an inch and not one inch more.

"How much of that do you have?"

"All of it," he says, and his voice cracks a little on it. "It's really good, Pip. The part where it comes out of the building and the streetlight goes through the corner? You can't buy that. People pay agencies to make videos like that and they look like videos. This looks like a crime."

"It isn't a crime."

"No. It looks like one. In a good way."

"Tavi."

"I'm not posting it." He holds the phone against his chest. "I'm just saying, if a person *were* going to post it, it would do numbers."

I think about the boardroom on six, and Ruth Baskin from Lakeshore Ventures, who once told me in front of the whole board that my corner was "a lovely little indulgence." Then about how the room looked from the street with the light going through it.

"Don't post it," I say. "Send it to me."

"Okay," he says, too fast.

"And go home and sleep. You have a review at ten."

"With who?"

I pause, because I don't actually know who his reviews are with. I don't know who anybody's reviews are with.

"With somebody," I say. "Be early, and buy a real coat."

He goes off down Monroe with his phone lit up in his hand, a small blue light moving away under the streetlights, and I watch him all the way to the parking ramp and do not think about the fact that I just handed my entire legal defense to a twenty-three-year-old in a fashion coat.

Walt has the straps tight. Lolo is sitting on the bumper of her Buick pouring the last nothing out of her thermos and looking at it with betrayal.

"You riding with me or him?" she asks.

"Him, if he'll have me."

“Figures, he’s got heat.” She screws the cap back on. “Clyde Park?”

“Clyde Park, in the yard. Put it on the pad by the fence where the old Eight used to sit.”

“And then what?”

That’s the question, and it’s been the question since yesterday morning when the elevator doors opened on four. Lolo asks it the way she asks everything, like she’s asking if I want ketchup.

“And then I go to work,” I say.

“In it?”

“Next to it.”

She chews the inside of her cheek and squints at me over the thermos.

“First shift clocks in at six,” she says. “What am I telling them when there’s a house on the pad?”

“Tell them not to touch it.”

“They’re going to touch it. Irene’s going to come out with the Windex before she’s got her coat off, you know she is.” She points the thermos at the glass, at the print my hand left by the corner. “She’ll wipe that right off, hon.”

“Let her.”

“Okay.” She doesn’t believe me, and she lets me see that she doesn’t. “You know what you look like right now?”

“Don’t.”

“Like your mother at a wedding when the band plays the wrong polka.”

“That’s a very specific face.”

“It’s a very specific situation, hon.”

I climb up into Walt’s cab. It smells like diesel and spearmint gum and the vanilla tree air freshener that’s been hanging off his mirror since Obama. He pulls out slow, the trailer creaking, the room riding behind us with its corner to the cab like it’s looking where we’re going. Monroe Avenue is empty except for a salt truck heading the other way. The driver honks twice and waves. Everybody in this town loves a wide load at four in the morning.

My phone, which has been in my coat pocket all night on silent, starts buzzing against my hip. I take it out and it says ADAM.

It's four twenty-six, and he's in Chicago at a hotel near O'Hare because he had a dinner last night with a man from Minneapolis. He should be asleep, but he's never been a good sleeper. He says he sleeps fast.

I let it ring while the screen lights my lap and Walt's dashboard and the little vanilla tree. I think about picking up and saying *Good morning, I moved my desk*. I think about the face he'd make. I know every face he makes. I've had eleven years to learn them, and I've been studying the back of his head for two.

It stops ringing and turns into MISSED CALL, and then a text comes in before I can put it away.

Simone just called me. Pip. Where is the room.

No question mark. Adam always uses a question mark. He's a question mark man. He ends statements with them on purpose so people feel invited.

Walt glances over at the screen and back at the road.

"That him?"

"That's him."

"Your mother know yet?"

"She'll know before her coffee's done," I say. "Somebody from the Falcons hall drives a salt truck."

"You want me to take the long way?"

I lay the phone face down on the dash, next to his gum.

"Take the longest way you know, Walt."

Chapter 2 — Pip

Twenty hours earlier, I'm standing in the elevator of the Lindqvist building with a box of donuts from Marge's, because it's the first Monday of the year and I'm the kind of co-founder who brings donuts on the first Monday of the year to a floor she's been on four times since September.

The elevator is the original freight car, cage doors and a brass lever nobody's allowed to touch anymore. It goes up like it's thinking about something else. Two women from accounts payable get on at two, see me, see the box, and say "Oh my God, Pip" in the voice you use for a cousin who flew in for a funeral. I let them take a cruller each.

"The new color on the Eight is so nice," the shorter one says through her cruller. "Everybody's saying so."

I didn't change the color on the Eight. Somebody changed the color on the Eight.

"It's very calming," says the taller one, whose name is Bridget.

"It's beige," I say.

"Oatmeal," says Bridget.

"Oatmeal's a breakfast," I say, and they both laugh like I'm doing a bit. I'm half doing a bit. "Who made it oatmeal?"

"It came down from the integration team," Bridget says, and then her friend elbows her, and Bridget gets very interested in the floor numbers. On three they get off. On four the doors open and I step out onto the floor with the donuts held up in front of me as a bribe, and I'm already saying "Happy New Year, you degenerates" when I look across the floor at the northwest corner.

There's a woman in my room.

Ninety people work up here, on a hundred feet of maple boards with the bolt holes still in them from the furniture presses. Sales on the east side, marketing in the middle, design under the skylights. And in the far northwest corner, where the two big windows meet over Monroe Avenue and the Sixth Street bridge, the first room I ever built, sitting on its four bolt plates like a cat that found the one sunny spot in the house.

Cedar siding gone silver, two glass walls meeting at the corner with no post, a birch door on the east side.

The door is propped open with a banker's box. There's a ficus on my desk.

Nobody is watching me. Ninety people who have all read the *Ledger* piece calling me half of *the billion-dollar couple*, which my mother clipped and put on her refrigerator under a pierogi-shaped magnet, are very busy not watching me. Monitors are being looked at with tremendous concentration. A man from sales is on the phone saying "Absolutely, absolutely" to what I would bet is a dial tone. Somebody in design has their headphones on and their eyes so wide open you'd think they just heard a noise in the attic.

I walk across the floor. I walk at a normal speed with the donuts.

The woman in my room is in her forties, tall, with gray-blond hair cut very straight at her jawline and reading glasses pushed up on her head, and she's lifting a framed picture of a lighthouse out of a box like it's a birthday cake. She's wearing a navy sweater that probably has a fabric content she could tell you. I know her: Simone Achterberg, Vice President of Operations since last May. We've been in six meetings together, maybe seven. She took notes in every one of them by hand, in a black notebook, in handwriting so small and level I once thought it was printed. In the third meeting she asked me a question about weld times on the knee frame that nobody in that company had asked me in years, and I answered it for twenty minutes, and she wrote down all twenty minutes.

She sees me in the doorway and puts the lighthouse down on my desk, face up.

"Pip," she says. "Good morning."

"You're in my room."

"I asked for it," she says. "He said yes before I finished the sentence."

She says it like the forecast for Grand Rapids in January: not friendly, not unfriendly, a thing that is true and has consequences for your commute. I'll give her that. I've had people take things from me with a smile on their face and I'd rather have it level.

I look at the ficus, and at her pens, which are in my drawer, and at the photo on the windowsill of a girl in a green sweatshirt with her arm around a dog.

“That your daughter?”

Simone glances at the photo, then back at me, a small adjustment behind the eyes, like she’s checking a measurement.

“Hannah,” she says. “She’s a sophomore at State.”

“What’s she taking?”

“Mechanical engineering. She wants to build bridges, or she did in October.”

“Good school for bridges.” I hold the box out. “Donut?”

She looks at the box for a second longer than a person normally looks at donuts. Then she takes a plain cake one, the least donut of all the donuts, and holds it without eating it.

“Thank you,” she says.

“You’re welcome.”

“I would have asked you,” Simone says. “If I had known it was yours. Personally yours.”

“Who did you think it belonged to?”

“The company. It’s on the asset register.” She sets the donut on a napkin and squares the napkin to the edge of my desk. “Line forty-one. Furniture and fixtures, founders’ office, one unit.”

“It’s on a lease.”

“Then the register is wrong.”

“The register’s been wrong since 2018.”

“Then I will fix it.” She picks a black notebook up off my desk and writes in it in that small, level hand. “Who holds the original lease?”

“I do.”

“I will need a copy for the file.”

“You need a lot of things for the file.”

“Yes,” Simone says, and she means it, and I believe her, which is the worst part of the morning so far.

That's when Adam comes around the end of the design studio with two coffees in a cardboard tray and his coat over his arm. He's moving fast, the way he always moves, as if every room he walks into is already a little late for him. He's wearing the blue suit he wears for flights. His hair is still wet at the back from the gym. When he sees me he doesn't stop walking, but something in his face slows down.

There are eleven years of Adam Kerrigan's faces in my head, catalogued and cross-referenced. This is the one he makes when he walks into a room and the room isn't the room he planned for. It lasts half a second. Then he puts the other face on, the one that sold three hundred million dollars of a company to people who'd never stood in a backyard in their lives.

"Pip," he says, and hands one of the coffees to Simone, over my shoulder, into my room.

Simone takes it. Somewhere in the last minute she picked the donut back up off its napkin, so now she stands there in my room with a donut in one hand and a coffee in the other, and none of us says anything.

"Adam," I say. "Why is Simone in my room?"

His eyes go to the room and come back to me over the lid, and he takes a sip of his coffee.

"You barely use it," he says.

Behind me, the man in sales says "Absolutely" one more time, softer, and hangs up on the dial tone.

You barely use it.

He doesn't say it mean. That's the thing I'll think about at three in the morning for the next week. He says it like a fact on a slide. Like the occupancy rate of a conference room. He says it in the same voice he'd use to tell you that the Eight is now oatmeal.

"That's interesting," I say.

Adam has been married to me for eleven years and he knows what "that's interesting" means. My mother says it to the parish council. My brother Marek said it to a referee in a church league game once, and the referee left the gym. I

watch Adam hear it. His thumb goes to the plastic lid of his coffee and presses the little tab down, presses it down again.

“Simone’s running integration,” he says. “She needs a door that closes. You’re at the plant five days out of five. You come up here for the board and the holiday party. The room sits empty, Pip. People walk past it all day and it’s dark. It looks like a museum.”

“Integration of what?”

He glances at Simone, a quick nothing of a glance, the kind you give the one person in the room who already knows the answer, to check that you’re both going to give the same one.

I’ve seen that glance before. I used to be the person who got it.

“It’s on the agenda for the Monday meeting,” he says. “Which is right now. Which you’d know if you came to the Monday meeting.”

“I’m here.”

“You’re here with donuts.”

“They’re from Marge’s.”

“I know where they’re from, I can see the box.” He breathes out through his nose. “Listen. We’ll get you something better. A real office up here, south side, under the skylights. Whatever you want. You can design it.”

“I designed this one.”

“I know you did.”

“I built this one.”

“Pip. I know.”

He says it gently, and there’s a version of me that hears the gentleness and wants to put the donuts down. There’s another version who stood at the back of an all-hands two years ago and found out about Nashville along with the receptionist, a whole plant in Tennessee, decided without me. I don’t know which one is going to talk until she does.

“Is that the plan for everything?” I ask. “You find out what I barely use, and then you give it to somebody who’ll use it more?”

That lands somewhere. I see it land. He sets the tray down on the corner of a desk that belongs to somebody in marketing, who rolls her chair two feet away from it as though it might go off.

“That’s not fair,” he says, quiet.

“Did you ask me?”

“I’m asking you now.”

“You’re telling me now, in front of sales. That’s a different verb.”

“Pip, it’s a room.”

“It’s a room,” I agree. “It’s ten by twelve with a door on the east side and a corner with no post in it. I know exactly what it is. Did you ask me?”

He doesn’t answer that. He looks at Simone instead, and that’s an answer.

“That’s interesting,” I say again, and now a couple of people actually look up.

Simone sets her coffee on my windowsill next to her daughter. She doesn’t set the donut down. She holds it like she’s going to be asked to account for it later.

“I can take the south side,” she says to Adam. “It isn’t important to me where I sit.”

“It’s done,” Adam says. “Facilities moved the badge access Friday.”

Friday. I was at the plant Friday until nine at night with Lolo and a jig that wouldn’t hold square. He didn’t call, because he doesn’t call on Fridays, he texts. *Late one, don’t wait.* I didn’t wait. I’ve gotten very good at not waiting. I made eggs and ate them over the sink and went to bed, and somewhere in the building where I used to have a door, a man from facilities was reprogramming a lock.

I look at the door. My father turned that pull on a lathe in our garage in 2014 out of a piece of brass rod from a bathroom fixture somebody threw out on Bridge Street. On the inside of the door, in carpenter’s pencil on the raw birch, there’s writing. Three lines, two different hands. You can’t see all of it from here. The banker’s box is leaning against the bottom of the door, holding it open, and it covers the top line.

I can see the bottom one. 3. *Coffee at seven*. That line is in my handwriting. Underneath it, an arrow, and (*not 7:15*) in his.

I married him in that room. June of 2015, in my father's garage, before it had a desk in it or a company around it. A judge from the Kent County court who bowled with my uncle, my mother in her church hat, my father in a clean shirt holding the door open with his foot because the closer wasn't hung yet. Ten minutes. Afterward we had pierogi on a sheet of plywood on two sawhorses, and Adam made a speech to four people as if it were four hundred, and my father laughed until he had to sit down on a bucket.

I don't say any of that. You can't say a thing like that on a Monday in front of ninety people and a ficus.

"Okay," I say.

Adam's shoulders come down a quarter inch. He thinks I mean *okay*. I let him think it. He picks up the coffee tray again, the meeting already pulling on him from across the floor, the glass conference room where I can see the Monday people gathering, Gordon Pyle sweating into a cardigan, somebody setting out a projector clicker like it's a gavel.

"Come to the meeting," he says. "Please. There's something we need to walk through, and I'd rather you heard it from me."

"From you and Simone."

"From me."

"I'll be in in a minute," I say. "I'm going to give these out."

I hold up the donuts.

His eyes go to the box, then to me, and for half a second there's a face I don't have catalogued, something that might be about to ask a question. Then his phone buzzes in his pocket and he takes it out and the face is gone.

"Chicago," he says to Simone, not to me. "The Harvard dinner's at seven. I'm on the noon flight."

"What's in Chicago?"

"A dinner." He's already half turned toward the glass room. "A man from Minneapolis. It's in the meeting, Pip, it's all in the meeting."

"I'll send you the deck tonight," Simone says.

“You’re the best.”

He says it the way you say it to a waiter. He says it the way he used to say it to me.

I go back across the floor and give out every donut in the box, cruller, glazed, bismarck, the long johns, the paczki Marge only makes in January because she has no willpower in January. I stop at every desk. I ask the woman in design whose headphones are on how her dad’s hip is doing, and she takes the headphones off and tells me, for some time.

The man in sales has a paczek in his hand before I’ve finished holding out the box. He’s young, in a quarter-zip with our logo on the chest, and he’s still pink from the dial tone.

“Can I ask you something?” he says. “Since you’re up here.”

“You can ask.”

“The Lite.” He lowers his voice like the Lite might be listening. “People call in from the website and ask is it the same corner as the Corner. I’ve been telling them it’s basically the same corner.”

“It has a post in it.”

“It’s a pretty small post.”

“It’s a steel post standing exactly where the glass is supposed to meet. That’s the whole room, the place where the glass meets.” I keep my voice down, because he’s twenty-five and he didn’t build the script. “Who told you to say basically?”

He looks over at the glass conference room, where the Monday people are sitting down, and then at his paczek.

“Next time somebody asks,” I say, “tell them to drive out to Clyde Park and put their hand on one of each. I’ll meet them in the yard myself. And next time you’re on the phone with nobody, call somebody real.”

“Yes, ma’am,” he says, and then, to my back, “Thanks for the donut.”

When the box is empty I fold it flat and put it in the recycling by the elevator. Simone is there before I’ve let go of it, her notebook under her arm and the plain cake donut folded in a napkin in her other hand, like she’s bringing it back to the store.

“The meeting has started,” she says.

“I heard.”

“He will not take the second item without you. He has said so twice.” She looks at the flat box and then at me. “I would like to say one more thing, and then I will go in.”

“Go ahead.”

“I did not ask for the room because it was yours. I asked for it because it is the only door on this floor that closes, and I have calls to make this month that the people on this floor should not hear.”

“What calls?”

“That is a question for Adam.”

“Adam’s in there. You’re out here.”

“And I am telling you it is his to answer.” She holds the napkin out to me. “I did not eat this. I did not want you to think that I ate your donut and took your room on the same morning.”

I take it, and it’s still warm from her hand.

“It’s a plain cake,” I say. “It barely counts as a donut.”

“Then I have taken nothing,” Simone says, and nods once, as if that closes an account, and goes into the glass room and sits down on Adam’s left with her notebook open.

I don’t go to the meeting. I go to the stairwell, the old iron one in the northwest corner that nobody uses because the elevator’s right there and the stairwell smells like pigeons and radiator paint. I go down one flight and stop on the landing at three where there’s a window, tall and narrow and filthy, looking straight down onto Monroe Avenue. I eat Simone’s donut there in four bites, which is how you eat a plain cake.

From here I can see the whole width of the street. Two lanes, a bus stop, a fire hydrant. The streetlight posts are the old kind, cast iron, set back from the curb.

Plenty of room, I think.

Then I go down the rest of the stairs to my truck.

Chapter 3 — Pip

The Clyde Park plant sounds like a kitchen the night before a wedding, if the kitchen were the size of a hockey rink and everybody in it were holding a welding torch.

It reaches me in the parking lot, the long rising whine of the panel saw, the press brake going *chunk*, the hiss and crackle from the knee line where four welders stand in a row under the yellow curtains making the hidden frames that let my corner stand up without a post. I park the truck by the dumpsters where I always park it and sit there with the engine running and listen for a while. Some people have a beach. I have this.

Inside, Irene Kwiatkowski looks up from the glazing table and lifts her chin at me.

“Film stays on the Ada unit till Thursday,” she says. “Don’t let anybody peel it.”

“Who’d peel it?”

“You would. You always want to see the glass.” She goes back to her bead of sealant without waiting for me to argue.

Benny Szymanski is running the forklift with a cigarette behind his ear that he will not light, because I’ll fire him, and he’ll pretend it’s because of the rule. He swings the forks around and idles up next to me.

“Boss. Thought you were downtown today.”

“I was downtown today.”

“Short day downtown.” He looks at my face and then at the forks. “You want me to move something heavy for you? I’m feeling strong.”

“Move the Traverse City unit to finishing, Benny.”

“That’s not what I meant.”

“I know what you meant.”

“The Traverse City guy called again.” He scratches under the band of his hard hat. “They still don’t know who gets the house, so he’s moving into the room. He wants to know can we put a lock on the inside of the door and also a lock on the outside.”

“Why both?”

“So they can lock each other out of it at the same time, I guess.” Benny shrugs. “I told him that sounds like a marriage, and he should call a lawyer.”

“Put a deadbolt on the inside and tell him the outside one’s extra.”

“How much extra?”

“A lot,” I say, and he swings the forks toward finishing, grinning like I’ve given him a raise.

Somebody’s radio on the glazing table is playing Fleetwood Mac, the song every radio in Michigan plays at least once an hour in case you’ve forgotten you’re sad.

I walk my morning loop of the floor, though today it’s afternoon, past the wall framing jigs and the roof cassette line and the finishing bay where three Corners sit in a row under work lights, nearly done, their glass still wearing the blue protective film. One of them is going to a retired dentist in Ada who wants to paint in it, mostly birds. I know because I read every order. Nobody else reads every order. Adam says reading every order doesn’t scale.

At my bench in the back corner, by the big rolling door to the yard, there’s a weld sample I was in the middle of cutting on Friday, a section of the knee frame clamped in a vise with its cross-section sawn clean so you can see the bead. I sit down and pick up my file. I can’t work, and the file goes back on the bench.

I get up and go out through the rolling door into the yard, where there’s a stack of pallets against the fence, and I kick one of them, and then I kick it again. I keep kicking it until it’s the pallet’s fault. I’ve done that since I was fourteen and my brothers told me girls can’t weld, which I’d have argued about more if I hadn’t been fourteen and holding a stick welder upside down. My oldest brother, Joe, found me kicking the garage door that night and stood there in his socks. Then he went inside and came back out with my father’s welding hood and put it on my head backwards so I couldn’t see, and said, “There. Now you look like a welder.”

The pallet has a crack in it now, and my toes hurt inside my boot, which helps.

Benny has followed me out. He's sitting on the forklift in the rolling door with the engine idling, looking at the pallet like it's a dog that got hit.

"That one owe you money?" he says.

"It was in the way."

"It was against the fence, boss. That's the opposite of in the way."

"Did you move the Traverse City unit?"

"Moved it." He puts the forklift in reverse. "I'm going to go tell Lolo, so it's not a secret."

"Benny, don't you dare."

"It's for your own good," he says, and backs away beeping.

My phone buzzes in my back pocket, and it's Adam.

Missed you in the meeting. We need to talk properly. Tonight? Back Tues AM w/ Kurt. Call me after 10.

We need to talk properly. He's the one who started talking improperly, as a policy, around the time the company passed two hundred employees and his calendar went from a calendar to a weather system. I shove the phone back in my pocket.

It buzzes again, an email this time, from Simone Achterberg. Subject line: *Project North: integration workstreams (CONFIDENTIAL, leadership only)*. There's an attachment called *North_Integration_v14.pdf*, and the preview line says *Pip, as discussed with Adam, sharing the full deck so you're*—and then it cuts off.

As discussed with Adam. Version fourteen.

I hold my thumb over it. I could open it and read the whole thing standing right here in the yard by my cracked pallet. I get a Monday deck from this company every week and I don't open them. I tell myself it's because they're written by people who say "learnings" and "socialize." The real reason is that every time I open one, something's in it I wasn't asked about. It's easier to know a thing is happening than to see the slide where it happens.

I swipe it into a folder called LATER. LATER has four hundred and some emails in it. LATER is my professional legacy.

Then I go back inside. Irene doesn't look up from the glazing table as I pass.

"Benny's gone to tell Lolo," she says.

"I know," I say, and keep walking.

"You want me to go stop him?"

"Could you?"

"No," Irene says, and runs her bead of sealant clean to the corner without a wobble.

I go up the iron steps to the little mezzanine office over the paint booth that I never use either, and open the file cabinet in the corner. In the second drawer down there's a hanging file labeled *UNIT 001* in my own handwriting, from when my handwriting was neater.

A receipt from the steel yard on Market Avenue for the original frame stock, made out to *P. Sobczak*. A receipt from Grand Rapids Glass, also *P. Sobczak*, for two pieces of insulated glass with a polished edge, with a note on it in the counterpane's handwriting: *good luck w/ the corner*. A photo of my father in his welding jacket with the room behind him on sawhorses, his face squinting into the sun like he's about to tell the photographer to move.

And the lease, two pages, stapled crooked, Philippa Sobczak to Twodesk, Inc., one dollar a year. I wrote it myself in 2018, on the kitchen table, the week before we craned the room into the Lindqvist building, because our lawyer at the time said we couldn't put my personal property on the company's insurance without one. Adam stood behind me reading it over my shoulder while I typed.

"Terminable at will by Lessor," he read. "That's a terrible lease."

"It's a great lease," I said.

"For you, it's a great lease."

"I'm the lessor, Adam."

"Nobody's ever going to read it," he said, and kissed the top of my head, and went to take a call.

I read it twice now, sitting on a folding chair over the paint booth with the smell of primer coming up through the floor. Terminable at will. Lessee to

return the premises in the condition received. *Premises* means the room. I put that word in there because I'd read it in somebody else's lease and liked how it sounded, like we were renting out a manor.

A little before three, Lolo comes up the steps with her lunch cooler. She stops at the top step and takes in the file in my lap, and she knows. I don't know how she knows. Lolo would've made a terrible poker player and a great priest.

"Benny says you kicked a pallet," she says.

"Benny should be driving the forklift."

"He was driving the forklift. He drove it over to tell me." She sets the cooler down on the desk. "What'd it do?"

"What did who do?"

"The pallet, hon."

"It was there," I say.

"Uh-huh," she says, and sits down across from me on the other folding chair, which complains. "Gina from the office called Darnell's wife, and Darnell's wife called Darnell, and Darnell told the whole knee line, so let's skip it. There's a woman in your room."

"There's a woman in my room."

"With a plant, I heard."

"A ficus."

"Is it a nice ficus?"

"It's a fine ficus, Lolo. It's not the ficus's fault."

She nods slowly and puts her reading glasses on, as if the ficus might be somewhere in the fine print.

"And Adam?"

"He said I barely use it."

Lolo makes the noise you'd make if somebody put ketchup on pierogi in front of your mother.

"Do you?" she says. "Use it?"

I look down at the lease instead of at her. "No."

"Why not?"

“Because I’m here,” I say.

Lolo has known me since I was a kid on an upturned bucket by the welders. She knows a short answer when she hears one, and she lets it go.

“I ever tell you I ran a line in that building?” she says. “When it was still Lindqvist Furniture?”

“About four hundred times.”

“Your dad trained me on the press brake on two, right by the freight car, in ninety-four. Only man in the place who never explained anything to me twice.” She takes a sandwich out of the cooler, unwraps it, looks at it, wraps it back up. “Thirty years I put into that building one way and another, and at your Christmas party a kid at the front desk asked me was I there about the copier.”

“What’d you tell him?”

“I told him yes, and I fixed the copier. It was a paper jam, it’s always a paper jam. I’m not proud of it.” She sets the sandwich on the desk. “So what do you want to do, hon? You want it out the window or out the door? ’Cause the door’s a no. That room doesn’t fit in the elevator, and I’m not carrying it down the stairs at my age.”

When I look up, she’s looking back at me, completely serious.

“The window,” I say. “The bay unbolts, I built it to unbolt.”

“I know you did, I was there, I held the bolts.” She jerks her chin at the phone on the desk. “So call Walt.”

“It’s Monday.”

“Walt doesn’t care what day it is. Walt cares if it’s raining.” She leans over, picks up my phone, and holds it out to me. “Call him before you think about it so long you turn into a person who doesn’t do things. You’re getting close. I can see it from here.”

I take the phone, and Walt Kasprzak picks up on the second ring, sounding like he’s eating. Walt always sounds like he’s eating, because Walt is always eating.

“Sobczak,” he says. “What fell over this time?”

“Nothing fell over. I need a pick.”

“Where at?”

“The Lindqvist building, fourth floor, the northwest bay.”

On the other end of the line, Walt stops chewing.

“Your room,” he says.

“My room.”

“The one we put in there in eighteen. On your—“ He stops. He was at the install, and at the party after, on the roof, the night we hung the sign and Adam talked for twenty minutes without a note. “Out?” he says.

“All the way out.”

“When?”

“Tonight, Walt.”

He goes quiet long enough that I check the screen to see if I’ve lost him. Then his chair creaks, which means Walt has put his sandwich down and leaned back, which means he’s going to do it and he wants me to know how much he’s going to charge me.

“Permit’s still good,” he says slowly. “The standing one for the building. I renewed it in October ’cause they wanted the rooftop units swapped in spring. Says Monroe Avenue, says night work, says Kasprzak Rigging. Doesn’t say what’s coming out the window. City’ll fine you if anybody squawks.”

“Let them fine me.”

“Wind’s supposed to drop after midnight, snow but light.” He breathes out through his teeth. “It’ll cost you, Pip.”

“Everything costs me.”

“Not like this. Overtime, the hundred-ton, a lowboy, a flagger, me. And I’m going to want pierogi. Your mother’s, not the store kind.”

“Done.”

“Who’s got the inside, on the bay bolts?”

I look over at Lolo, who is unwrapping her sandwich again and doesn’t look up.

“Darnell,” she says to the sandwich. “He’ll want to. He’s been bored since the holidays.” She already has her phone out in her other hand and is typing

with one thumb, slow, like every letter is a separate decision. It buzzes back before she's set it down. "He says is he allowed to use your good chisel."

"No."

She types. "I told him yes."

"Lolo."

"Let the man have a chisel, hon. He's had a long December."

"Darnell," I tell Walt.

"Adam know about this?" Walt says.

"Adam's in Chicago."

"That's not what I asked you."

"It's what I'm answering, Walt."

"And you're sure."

He doesn't make it a question. He's known me since I was in braces. He's watching me in his head, same as Lolo is watching me across the desk, from the corner of her eye, chewing, pretending she's somewhere else.

I think about the ficus, and the lighthouse face up on my desk, and the banker's box against the door covering the first line, and Adam handing Simone her coffee over my shoulder. *You barely use it*, said in the voice for a conference room. Version fourteen.

Coffee at seven. We haven't had coffee at seven in two years. After Nashville I stopped going up at seven, and he stopped asking where I was.

"I'm sure, Walt."

"What time?"

Outside the little office window, down on the floor, second shift is coming in, Lolo's people, stamping snow off their boots, punching the clock one after another with the sound of a small gun going off very politely. The radio has moved on from Fleetwood Mac to Bob Seger. Somebody laughs over by the knee line, a big laugh, and somebody else tells them to shut up.

"Three in the morning," I say. "I'll bring the bolts."

Chapter 4 — Adam

“Tell me it’s a prank,” I say. “Tell me Darnell’s got it behind the building on a forklift and he’s going to bring it back around and everybody’s going to laugh.”

“It is not behind the building,” Simone says. “I walked around the building.”

It’s just after six in the morning at gate C17 at O’Hare, and I’m standing at the window in my coat with my roller bag between my feet, watching a de-icing truck spray a regional jet orange. On the other end of the line, a hundred and eighty miles away, Simone Achterberg is standing in the northwest corner of the fourth floor of the Lindqvist building, where there is no longer a room. She has been there since five. She’s told me this calmly, in order, as if she’s reading out the manifest of a ship that sank.

“Describe it,” I say.

“There are four steel bolt plates in the floor, and they have been cleaned. There is no debris. The window bay has been reinstalled and sealed, and you would not know from outside.” A pause. “My boxes are stacked against the wall with the labels facing out. The ficus is on top.”

“On top,” I say.

“And someone watered it.”

I laugh before I can stop it, a single bark at gate C17 in front of a family from Ohio in matching Buckeyes sweatshirts, and the dad turns around to see what’s funny about the de-icing truck.

“I’m not laughing,” I tell her.

“You laughed.”

“I’m laughing at the ficus. The ficus is a nice touch. You have to admit the ficus is a nice touch.”

“I do not have to admit that,” Simone says, but there’s something in her voice that might be a smile if you held it up to a light.

Here’s the thing about me. I can sell anything to anybody, which is how I know the exact sound of a room deciding not to buy. I sold a backyard shed to a Canadian teachers’ pension fund as the future of work, which, to be fair, it is.

When a room decides against you it makes a kind of soft settling, like snow sliding off a roof, and I have learned that the first thing you do when a deal goes sideways is find out what's still true.

"What's still true?" I ask.

"Kurt Lindahl is on your flight. You drive him from the airport, and he tours the building at eleven. His diligence team has your founders' room on page nine of their brand assessment, with a photo, under the heading *Heritage Assets*." She lets that sit. "Gordon has called me twice. Ruth Baskin has not called yet. Elvin from the lobby says Pip told him she would mail you a dollar."

"She's mailing me a dollar?"

"For the lease, he said. He was not clear on the details, and he seemed to enjoy it."

I close my eyes. Behind them is the lease, two pages on the kitchen table in 2018, Pip typing with two fingers and her tongue between her teeth and me reading over her shoulder. *Terminable at will by Lessor*. I told her it was a terrible lease. I told her nobody would ever read it.

I've read a thousand leases in my life, and I never read hers.

"Is there video?" I ask.

"There is a video, forty seconds, filmed from a moving vehicle. It is on a Facebook group called *Grand Rapids Uncensored*. It has nine thousand views and a comment that says, I am quoting, *this city is so back*."

"Who posted it?"

"A man who drives a salt truck for Kent County. His profile picture is a walleye."

"Of course it's a walleye. Can we get it taken down?"

"It is a man's video of a public street at four in the morning. You could ask the walleye."

"Find out who he is."

"I know who he is. His name is on his profile." Her pen taps something, twice. "I will not call a salt truck driver before sunrise and ask him to delete the best thing that has happened to him all winter."

She stops, and then she says, “Adam.”

Simone almost never says my name on the phone. She says it now in a particular tone, the tone she used in August walking me through the Nashville numbers at one in the morning, when I couldn’t sleep and she couldn’t either and she was the only person I knew who’d pick up.

“I know,” I say.

“Halvard bought a story. The story has two founders and a garage and a room. You are going to walk their CEO onto a floor where one of the founders has removed the room with a crane in the night.”

“I know, Simone.”

“What do you want me to do?”

They’re calling boarding, group one. A guy in a fleece vest pushes past me with the face of a man who has never let anyone board in front of him in his life.

What do I want her to do. That’s the question I’ve been asking Simone for eight months, one way or another, and she always has an answer, in order, with numbers. I like that about her. I’m good with people and bad with silence, and Simone is good with numbers and fine with silence. She can sit in the glass conference room for an hour at the end of a long day with her notebook closed, not checking her phone. I can’t do that. Pip can sit at a workbench for six hours and never say a word. I used to sit next to her while she did it, back in her father’s garage, and talk the whole time, and she’d let me.

“Get facilities to cover the bolt plates,” I say. “Put a rug down. Move your things into the glass room so it looks like a staging area. I’ll tell Kurt it’s being refurbished.”

“Refurbished,” Simone says, slowly, as if it’s a word in a language she doesn’t speak.

“Scheduled refurbishment, heritage asset maintenance, it’s on page nine. He’ll love it. He’ll think we’re taking care of our heritage.”

“And when he sees the video?”

“He’s not going to see a video with nine thousand views on a Facebook group with a walleye.”

“It had six thousand when I picked up the phone,” Simone says.

On the plane, Kurt Lindahl has the window, of course. He folds himself into it, long and lean, and hands his camel coat up to the flight attendant without looking, as though somebody has always been there to take it. The man across the aisle asks him what Halvard makes. “Eleven furniture brands you’ve heard of,” Kurt tells him, “and nine you’ve sat on without knowing it.” He’s charming the way I’m charming, which is to say on purpose, and we both know it, and that makes us get along like two magicians at a party.

“Big day,” he says, when I sit down. “I’m excited to see the room. Your deck on that room is my favorite deck in the deal. Two kids, a garage, a dream. It’s going to test through the roof.”

“It’s a special room,” I say.

“I want to stand in it. My comms team wants a photo of you and me standing in it, shaking hands. We’ll hold the photo till close, obviously.”

“Obviously.”

“Is Pip going to be there?”

There it is. Kurt has asked about Pip in every meeting since October, sincerely, which is worse than slyly, because Pip owns thirty-three percent of my company and the deal needs seventy-five, and I haven’t told her there’s a deal. I’ve told her there’s a *process*. I’ve sent her the Monday decks. She doesn’t open the Monday decks. I know she doesn’t, because the deck software tells me who opens what, and since the spring before last her name has sat in the *not viewed* column like a headstone.

That last part is a pitch. Strike it.

I haven’t told her because if I tell her, she’ll say no, and if she says no, I have to tell her why we need to sell, and if I tell her why we need to sell, it’s real.

“Pip’s at the plant today,” I say. “Pip’s always at the plant. She’s our heart. She’s the hands.”

“I’d love to meet the hands,” Kurt says.

“You will. Absolutely. She’s going to love you.”

He nods and takes a folder out of his bag, an actual paper folder, which I respect in a man his age. “Help me with Nashville while I have you. My ops people say your Tennessee line can’t build the corner.”

“Nashville builds the Lite.”

“The one with the post.”

“A small post,” I say. It’s the line we give the phones.

“Don’t apologize for the post, Adam. The post is the plan.” He taps the folder with one finger. “The room with no post is what we put in the ads. The room with the post is what we put in the backyards. Every brand I own works that way, and every one of them makes money.”

I laugh, because he wants me to, and look out past him at the wing so he can’t tell whether I mean it.

Somewhere over Lake Michigan, the flight attendant comes by with the coffee cart, and Kurt asks for hot water with lemon, and I ask for coffee, black, and I drink it and look at my phone in airplane mode where I can’t get any messages, and I think: this is the last quiet I’m going to have today.

The last good meetings Pip and I had in that room were coffee at seven, which was less a meeting than a rule, written on the inside of the door, number three, in her handwriting. For six years in the Lindqvist building, every working day I was in town, we sat in that room at seven in the morning, her at her desk and me in the other chair with my feet on the radiator, and we decided the day, just us, before anybody else came up the elevator and the company woke up.

I don’t think about how it ended. I’m a forward-looking guy. It’s in my bio.

We land a couple of minutes early in blowing snow. My phone comes back on in the jet bridge and won’t stop buzzing: Gordon, three times, and Ruth Baskin, once, a voicemail I won’t be listening to in front of Kurt. Simone, a text: *Rug down. Staging area done. Video at 41k. It has been shared by the Grand Rapids Ledger.* And under that, a minute later: *Second*

video now, from the street, a different angle and much better quality. It is very beautiful.

Very beautiful. Simone doesn't use adjectives she can't defend.

I put Kurt in the car with the heat on full and tell him I need two minutes to call the office about the tour. I stand outside the car in the snow with my back to him, and I don't call the office. I open the second video.

It's from the sidewalk, low and steady, Monroe Avenue at night with the snow coming down through the streetlights. And there, coming out of the fourth floor of the Lindqvist building, slow, turning a little, ten by twelve, is our room. Her room. It swings out into the air, and for a second it hangs there by itself, and the light from the streetlight goes straight through the glass corner where there's no post and comes out the other side, and somebody off-camera says, very quietly, *pretty*, and somebody else says *don't*.

I know that second voice. I'd know it in a stadium.

I play it three times. I'm standing in the snow at the Gerald R. Ford International Airport in my travel suit with Kurt Lindahl waiting in a warm car, and I play my wife's room flying out of my building three times, and the third time, for no reason I can explain to anyone, I have to put my hand on the roof of the car.

Then I get in and tell Kurt we're going to swing by the plant first.

"The plant?" he says, delighted. "Love it. The hands."

"The hands," I say.

I call Simone from the highway, on speaker, while Kurt pretends to read email.

"The rug," I say. "At the bolt plates. Take it up."

"You told me to put it down."

"I know I did. Take it up and leave the plates."

There's a pause long enough for her to write something down. I can hear the pen.

"Why?" she says.

I don't have an answer I can say with Kurt Lindahl two feet away pretending to read email. The true one is something like *because I don't want*

anybody standing there, which isn't a business reason, and which I didn't know was true until I said *take it up*.

"Heritage," I say. "Let them see it. It's part of the story."

"That is not why," Simone says, and hangs up.

Kurt doesn't look up from his phone. "Rug situation?"

"Rug situation."

"I had a rug situation in Milwaukee once," he says. "We bought the company anyway." He goes back to his email with a little smile, as if he's already read the last page of this one.

The Clyde Park plant is twenty minutes from the airport if you drive the way I drive. I drive the way I drive. Kurt holds the handle above his window and keeps saying *love it* at intervals, and means about half of them. We go down Clyde Park Avenue past the tire place and the taqueria and the Reformed church with the sign that says *GOD ANSWERS KNEE-MAIL*, and I turn in at our gate, and I see it.

It's sitting in the yard by the fence on a gravel pad, up on cribbing, the snow already settling on its roof, exactly where the old Eight prototype used to sit before we scrapped it. The light's on inside.

My wife is sitting in it at her desk, with a welding sample in the vise in front of her.

She's filing it like it's any Tuesday in the world.

Chapter 5 — Pip

He knocks on the glass. On my glass, on my room, in my yard, my husband stands in the snow in his travel suit and knocks on the corner with one knuckle like he's at a drive-through.

I let him knock twice before I get up and open the door.

The cold comes in with him, and the smell of airplane and the cedar soap he's used since 2013, and he stands just inside the door on the mat my mother braided out of old bread bags and looks around: at my desk, which is mine again, at the empty space along the wall where Simone's boxes would be if I hadn't stacked them on four, at the vise and the weld sample and the file, and last of all at me.

"Hi," he says, and I say it back, and then he says, "You moved your office."

"I took my office. It's different."

"Pip." He does a thing with his hand, opening it, as if he's going to set something down on the desk between us and then realizes there's nothing in it. "There's a man from Minneapolis in my car."

"I know, he waved at me through the windshield."

"He's the CEO of Halvard."

"I know who Kurt Lindahl is, Adam. He was on the cover of *Furnishings Weekly* in a turtleneck."

"He's here to see the room."

"Well, here it is," I say, and hold my arms out to the walls.

He almost laughs. It comes up in him and gets pushed back down, which is new. Adam used to laugh at everything I said, even when it wasn't funny, especially when it wasn't funny, like a man throwing money at a street musician to make sure she stays on the corner.

"Why is the CEO of Halvard here to see my room?" I say.

"It was in the Monday deck."

"Which one?"

"All of them, since October. Pip, I sent you every single one. I *sent* them to you."

“I don’t open them.”

“I know you don’t open them!” It comes out louder than he means. He glances over his shoulder at the car and brings it back down. “I know you don’t, the software tells me, every week. Philippa Sobczak, not viewed. I see your name every Monday in a little gray box.”

That stops me for a second, the idea of him at his desk on a Monday finding my name in a little gray box. I don’t know what to do with that, so I take my phone out of my back pocket and open the folder called LATER and scroll down past four hundred emails to the one from Simone yesterday morning, and I open *North_Integration_v14.pdf*, standing in my own room with my husband dripping on my mother’s rug.

Slide one is *Project North*, over a nice photo of the Lindqvist building at sunset that somebody paid for.

Slide two, *Transaction overview: Acquisition of 100% of Twodesk, Inc. by Halvard Group*, and under it a number, *\$1.1B*, one point one billion dollars in a font somebody chose because it looked confident.

Slide three is a table of approvals. *Board: obtained (Dec); shareholders: 75% special approval; founders: Kerrigan (34%), committed, Sobczak (33%), pending.*

Pending. I’m on a slide, in a table, with the word *pending* next to my name in a gray box.

Slide eleven, because I keep scrolling, because I can’t stop: *Manufacturing integration. Phase 1 (months 0–6): retain Clyde Park, Nashville. Phase 2 (months 6–18): consolidate production into Halvard facilities (Holland, MI; Monterrey, MX).* And a little footnote, in eight-point type, the kind of type people use when they’d like you to be in a hurry: *Corner product line to transition to Lite architecture (posted corner) to align with Halvard cost structure.*

The phone is cold in my hand, and I set it face down on the desk next to the vise.

“You’re selling my company,” I say.

“Our company.”

“To a furniture conglomerate that’s going to close my plant and put a post in my corner.”

“That’s phase two, that’s eighteen months out, those are planning assumptions, they’re not—“

“There’s a slide, Adam.”

“There’s a slide for everything. There’s a slide for the holiday party.”

“Is there a slide for when you were going to tell me?”

That’s the one, the question I’ll be asking the ceiling for the next while, and he doesn’t answer it. He stands there with snow melting off his shoulders onto the bread-bag rug, and out past the corner Kurt Lindahl is getting out of the car and putting on a pair of leather gloves and looking at the yard like he’s going to buy it.

“I needed seventy-five,” Adam says finally, quietly. “I’ve got sixty-seven, with the board and Ruth. I needed you.”

“Then you’ve got sixty-seven,” I say. “I’m a no.”

He closes his eyes and opens them again.

“You can’t just be a no,” he says. “You haven’t even read it. You opened it thirty seconds ago.”

“I can just be a no. That’s what the seventy-five is for. It’s so somebody can just be a no.” I fold my arms. “I wrote that clause too. You stood behind me while I typed it. You said nobody would ever read it.”

“Pip, listen to me.”

I hold up the phone. “Who else has read version fourteen?”

“The board, Ruth, Gordon.” He counts them off on his fingers and stops for exactly as long as it takes to decide not to lie. “Simone built it.”

“Of course she did.”

“She built it because I asked her to build it. Don’t put that on her, Pip.”

“I’m not putting anything on anybody. I’m reading a slide. *Simone’s running integration*,” I say, in his Monday voice. “Integration of us.”

“That’s what integration is, Pip. You don’t understand what’s—“

“Explain it, then.”

And there it is again, a door opening in his face and him closing it. He decides not to tell me something, right there in front of me. He's done that a hundred times since Nashville and I've never caught what's behind it. I'm good at reading where a thing is going to crack, in a weld or in a person, and I've never been able to read the inside of that particular door.

"It's a good deal," he says instead, and his voice changes, it gets that warm, round, luncheon-speaker thing it gets. "It's a great deal, Pip. It's a life-changing number for both of us, for everybody with options, for Gordon, for the crew."

"Don't pitch me."

"I'm not pitching you."

"You're pitching me. Your voice went up into your nose. You do the nose voice for Rotary."

"I do not talk through my nose." He stops, because he does, and we both heard it. "Fine. Then here's the other thing, and you know it already. You can't sell either. The lock-up runs twenty-four months from the D. You can't walk out with your third, you can't sell it to anybody without the board, and the board wants the deal. So you can be a no all you want, but you can't leave, and I can't sell without you." He spreads his hands. "Congratulations. We're married."

It's a good line, the best one he's said to me since the spring before last. I hate that it is, and I keep my hands flat on the desk.

"Get your man out of the snow," I say. "He's going to freeze to the yard."

Kurt Lindahl ducks under the header when he comes in, though he doesn't need to. Tall men do that in my rooms. I build them seven-foot-two inside, but tall men walk into a small building and assume it's going to hit them on the head, and when it doesn't, they get generous about it.

He looks the rug over before he gets around to my face. "Is this handmade?"

"My mother made it out of bread bags."

"We own a textiles brand in Wisconsin, recycled fibers. She should talk to our people."

“She’d want to know what you pay.”

“Everybody wants to know what we pay,” Kurt says, pleased, as if I’ve passed a test I didn’t sign up for. He peels off a glove to shake my hand. His hand is warm, which means he’s been keeping it in his pocket in the car especially. “Kurt. It’s such an honor, Pip. I’ve wanted to meet you since October. Your corner is the single most elegant detail in residential product I’ve seen in ten years. I mean that.”

“Thank you,” I say, and he’s already pointing past me. “May I?”

He means the glass. He walks over to the corner without waiting for me to answer and puts his bare hand flat on the joint where the two panes meet, exactly where I put mine at four in the morning on the trailer. Irene wiped mine off first thing this morning with the Windex, the way Lolo said she would. He looks up at the roof where there’s no post holding anything, and down at the floor, and shakes his head slowly, smiling.

“How?” he says.

“There’s a moment frame in the walls,” I say. “Welded steel, buried in the stud cavity, both sides, meeting at a knee under the floor. It carries the roof around the corner. The crew calls it the knee.”

“The knee,” he says, and his whole face lights up. “And it’s welded by hand?”

“By four people, here, under those yellow curtains.” I nod toward the plant. “They’re the best in Michigan, maybe the country. It takes about eleven hours a unit.”

“Eleven hours.” His face does something small and quick, a calculator under the charm. “And in a high-volume environment—“

“You’d put a post in it.”

He laughs, delighted, caught. “I’d look at the cost architecture holistically.”

“You’d put a post in it,” I say again, and next to me Adam makes a sound through his nose that I haven’t heard since about 2022, which is the sound he makes when he’s trying not to laugh in a meeting. When I turn my head, he’s studying the ceiling.

Kurt takes his hand off the glass and leaves a print. I'll get it later.

"I love this," he says, to the room. "I love the story, two founders and a garage, and now this, moving the room out of HQ overnight and back to the plant floor. It's a hell of a statement. It's very authentic. Did you know it's on the *Grand Rapids Ledger* website?"

"I posted it," I say.

Adam's head comes around.

"At six fifty-two," I tell him, "from my account. The kid's footage, the good one."

"You *posted*—"

"It's my room and it's my video," I say. "It's a beautiful video, Adam. You should read the comments. Somebody wants to know if we deliver to Ohio."

I didn't know I was going to say that until I said it. That's not true. I knew a minute before I posted it, sitting on the trailer steps with Tavi's file open on my phone and the sun not up yet and my room coming out of the building on a three-inch screen. I knew that if I didn't post it, somebody would cover the bolt plates with a rug and tell a man from Minneapolis it was being refurbished.

Kurt looks from me to Adam and back again, and then he smiles wider, which is how you know a man like Kurt has decided something.

"Well," he says, "it's certainly brand-positive."

"Careful," I tell him. "Around him, I mean." I tip my head at my husband. "He'd sell you your own chair."

"I've heard," Kurt says. "I've been looking forward to it." He pulls his glove back on, finger by finger. "Walk me down your knee line sometime? Not today. Sometime."

"Sometime," I say, the way my mother says it to the Jehovah's Witnesses.

They leave for the eleven o'clock tour of a building with no room in it. Adam lets Kurt go ahead to the car and stops in the door, one hand on the frame, the snow blowing in past him onto the rug.

"The city's going to fine you for the permit," he says.

“Walt says the permit’s good.”

“The permit’s for rooftop units.”

“Then they’ll fine me, and I’ll pay it.”

“Gordon’s going to have a stroke.”

“Gordon has a stroke every quarter. He’s very healthy.”

“Ruth’s going to want to know who paid for the crane.”

“I paid for the crane. Walt takes pierogi.”

He almost smiles, and catches it, and puts it away. His eyes go over the desk, the vise, my phone, and then to the inside of the door, where the writing is, the three lines in carpenter’s pencil in two handwritings, and his face goes still in a way I don’t have a name for.

“Come to the board on the nineteenth, Pip,” he says. “Ruth’s putting you on the agenda.”

“For what?”

“Censure,” he says, and he says it like he’s sorry, and then he’s gone across the yard through the snow to the warm car, and the man from Minneapolis waves to me through the windshield like we’re all on the same team.

I close the door and sit down at my desk and pick up the file.

Through the glass corner, Kurt Lindahl’s handprint is still on the window, five fingers and a palm, right at the joint.

“He loves it,” I tell the knee frame in the vise. “We’re in so much trouble.”

Chapter 6 — Pip

We have two coffee makers.

Mine is a stovetop moka pot, aluminum, eight-sided, dented on one shoulder from the time my brother Marek threw it at my brother Joe in 1999. My mother gave it to me when I moved into my first apartment, along with a crucifix and a can of Raid. His is an Italian espresso machine the size of a small car engine, with a little brass eagle on top, which a man from his old fraternity sent him when we closed the Series C. It makes very good coffee, and I've used it twice.

They sit at opposite ends of the kitchen counter in our house on Heritage Hill, like two cats who've agreed to share a house but not a room.

Near eleven that night I'm standing at my end, washing a pan, when his headlights come up the drive.

The house is an 1890s brick Italianate on College Avenue with radiators that knock like they want to be let in. There's a room on the second floor we call the room with the ladder, because there's been a ladder in it since 2020. Adam still says we'll get to it.

He comes in through the back with his bag and the cold, and stands in the kitchen doorway in his coat.

"Hi," he says, and I say hi back to the pan.

"Did you eat?" he asks, pulling his gloves off by the fingertips.

"Yes," I say. I had half a sleeve of saltines in the truck, which is the food of the sick and the righteous.

"I didn't," he says, and puts the bag down by the door. "Is there—"

"There's pierogi in the freezer, my mother's, and Walt gets half."

"Why does Walt get half?"

"Because Walt sent an invoice, and my mother read it."

He opens the freezer and stands there in the light of it, looking at the bags labeled in my mother's handwriting, *ruskie* and *kapusta* and *śliwki*: *FOR PIP ONLY*. He takes a bag of *ruskie*. Eleven years married, he still knows which ones are mine.

“Is the *only* legally binding?” he says, and taps the plum bag with one finger.

“She wrote it in Sharpie. In this family that’s notarized.”

He shuts the freezer and puts water on to boil at his end, and the two of us stand at our two ends of the counter with the whole length of it between us, like bowlers waiting on the ball return.

“Gordon called me six times today,” he says to the pot.

“How’s his stroke coming along?”

“Ongoing,” he says, and opens the bag. “The site went down after lunch from too much traffic.”

“I heard. Tavi called me from the men’s room to tell me.”

“Do you want to know how many?” he says.

“How many of what?”

“Deposits,” he says to the water. “Since noon, people going to the site, clicking *reserve*, putting down ten percent.”

“No.”

“Four hundred and eleven.”

I dry my hands very carefully, every finger, like I’m going to be asked to show them to a nun.

“For which one?” I ask the towel.

“For the Corner,” he says, and drops the pierogi in one at a time, gentle, the way my mother does it. “Your Corner, the real one, not the Lite. They’re writing in the notes field. *The one from the video. The one with no post.* Somebody in Duluth wrote *the one that can leave.*”

The pierogi rise to the top one by one and float there, and I keep my eyes on them.

“When do they want them?” I ask the pot, because the pot is easier than his face.

“By spring, every one of them. Everybody in Duluth wants a room before the mosquitoes.”

“Clyde Park can’t build four hundred Corners by spring. And Nashville can’t build one. Nashville can’t weld the knee, Adam, you were at the meeting where they said so.”

“I *know* what Nashville can’t do.” He pokes at a pierogi that’s stuck to the bottom of the pot and it comes loose and spins. “Kurt says it’s a capacity question.”

“Kurt has a plant in Monterrey with nobody in it who’s ever run a bead on a moment frame.”

“He calls the deposits a demand signal.”

“Kurt would call a house fire a demand signal.”

“He’s thrilled, and he wants to get you in the photo.”

“I’m not getting in the photo, Adam. I’m going to be a no in the photo.”

“I *know*, Pip,” he says, and turns around. In the kitchen light he looks tired the way he looked tired when we were thirty and slept on the floor of the garage two nights a week, except then we were tired together. “Ruth called tonight. The nineteenth is on, and you’re agenda item four.”

“What are items one through three?”

“Minutes, then the Q4 numbers, then Halvard.”

“So I’m right after Halvard. That’s a good spot, everybody’ll be awake.”

He scoops the pierogi onto a plate with a slotted spoon and doesn’t sit down. We have a table and six chairs, and on four of them are boxes of samples and a pile of mail and a bicycle helmet nobody wears. He eats standing up at his end. I lean on mine with my arms crossed.

“Sit down, you’re making my feet hurt,” I say.

He picks up the bicycle helmet, and because he’s holding a plate in the other hand, he puts the helmet on his head and doesn’t buckle it. It sits on top of his good haircut like a mixing bowl. Then he lifts the box off the nearest chair with his free hand.

“Not on its side,” I say. “Those are the hinge samples for the Long.”

“So where do they go, then?”

“On a chair, where they were before you touched them.”

He puts the box down on the next chair, on top of the mail, and the mail slides off onto the floor in a long fan of catalogs and something from the county.

He sits down in the chair he's cleared, in his coat, in the helmet, and eats a pierogi off his fork.

"You're standing over there like it's a picket line," he says.

"It's my end, I've got squatter's rights."

"I know whose end it is." He takes the helmet off and sets it on the table next to his plate, upside down, like he's going to collect money in it. "You did a good job on the lift last night. Walt said you checked every ratchet."

"Since when does Walt talk to you?"

"Walt sent me an invoice with a note on it," he says, and eats another one. "It said *she checked every ratchet*. And it said he wants pierogi, twice, underlined the second time. I told him I'd pay for it, the crane and the crew and the overtime."

"I'm paying for that myself, Adam."

"Pip, the city's going to fine the company—"

"The company's not paying for it, *I* am, because it's my room."

"I know it's your room!"

He puts his fork down and gets up, and the chair stays out from the table at an angle, empty. We look at each other across twelve feet of quartz counter that we picked out together in 2019 at a stone yard in Wyoming, arguing for two hours about veining. I wanted the one with no veining. He wanted the one that looked like a river. We got the river.

"I'm going to bed," I say.

"Okay," he says to the empty chair.

"There's sour cream in the door of the fridge, behind the pickles."

"Goodnight, Pip," he says, and doesn't move toward the fridge. Then, when I'm already at the hall door: "Thank your mother for the pierogi."

"Thank her yourself. She'd tell the whole Rosary Society."

I go up the good stairs, past the room with the ladder, to our bedroom at the back of the house, which is my bedroom. He sleeps in the room across the hall.

He's slept there since the spring before last, because of the flights. That's what we said. He gets in late, he leaves at five, he doesn't want to wake me. My mother says *at least he's considerate* in the voice she uses for *at least the car still runs*.

I get into bed and lie on my back in the dark with the radiator ticking, looking up at a water stain shaped a bit like Lake Michigan, if Lake Michigan had been in a bar fight.

Just before one, he comes up: the creak on the ninth step, the door across the hall, the shower running and stopping.

A little after one, his voice comes through the wall. It's low, through two layers of plaster and a closet full of my winter coats, and I can't make out words, only the long easy run of a man telling a story to somebody who wants to hear it. He used to tell me stories like that in the cab of the truck on the way to Kalamazoo, whole stories with voices, and I'd fall asleep in the middle and he'd keep going.

Then he laughs, the real laugh, the one that comes out of him like a dog getting out of a car, and it's been so long since I heard it in this house that for a second I think it's the radio.

I don't know for certain who's on the other end. I lie there and do the arithmetic instead, which is the only thing I've ever been any good at. If he laughs like that with her at one in the morning, and he hasn't laughed like that with me since Nashville, then the number of people he laughs like that with is one, and it isn't me.

You barely use it, I think. And I think, *neither do you*.

The voice stops after a while, and a minute later the light under his door goes out.

I get up and take my pillow and the afghan my grandmother crocheted out of every color of yarn she could find at Goodwill in 1981, and I go down the good stairs. In the kitchen the chair he cleared is still out from the table, and the helmet is still upside down beside his plate, and I don't push either of them back.

The couch in the front room has the thickest wall in the house. I lie down on it and put the pillow over my head.

Chapter 7 — Adam

Simone has moved into the glass conference room, which is like moving into an aquarium.

It's the one in the middle of the fourth floor, the one we built in 2019 when a consultant told us transparency was a value. Four walls of glass, a long white table, twelve chairs, a screen. Everybody on the floor can see in. Simone has set up at the far end of the table with her laptop and her black notebook and her pens, which she retrieved from Pip's tidy stack by the wall Tuesday morning and lined up again in a row, smallest to largest. The ficus is on the credenza behind her. The lighthouse is leaning against the wall, face out, because she hasn't found a hook.

"You could hang that," I say Wednesday morning, from the door.

"I could, yes."

"Facilities has hooks."

"Facilities is busy," Simone says, without looking up. "Facilities spent yesterday answering questions from the *Grand Rapids Ledger* about whether our building is structurally sound."

"And is it?"

"It has been standing since 1922. It has survived a great deal." She turns a page. "Sit down. We have eleven things."

I sit down, and we have eleven things. Simone always has a number of things, and the number is always exact, and she always writes it at the top of a fresh page and circles it. She has a way of making a day look like it has edges.

"One," she says, "is deposits."

"How many are we at?"

"One thousand eight hundred and six, as of seven a.m. Tavi has a dashboard that refreshes every ninety seconds. The marketing team has been watching it like it is a horse race."

"Is it still going up?"

"It is going up." She tips her head and studies me over her reading glasses, as if I'm a supplier's invoice. "Every one of them is for the original Corner.

Not one for the Lite. People are writing in the notes field. Would you like to hear some?"

"No, I would not."

"*The one from the video. The one with no post. The one that can leave.*" She says them flatly, like a list of part numbers. "There is one from a woman in Kalamazoo that says, *I want the room she took.*"

I rub my eyes and say, "Two."

"Two is Halvard, who emailed before dawn. Kurt is, his word, *energized*. He wants to accelerate. He would like the founders' approvals by the end of the month."

"He knows we don't have Pip."

"He believes we will." She makes a small mark. "He believes the video is a sign of founder passion that will translate into founder alignment. He used the phrase *passion asset*."

"God help us all."

"Three is Ruth."

She doesn't have to say anything else about three, because my phone is lighting up on the table between us with RUTH BASKIN – LAKESHORE, and Simone slides it toward me with one finger like it's a check at a restaurant.

I pick up and put it on speaker. Simone and I do that now. I'm not sure when we started.

Ruth sounds like she's on a treadmill, which she probably is. Ruth runs four miles every morning at six in a gym in Ann Arbor and takes calls the whole time, breathing evenly, at peace with the idea of being chased.

"We love the energy," she says, instead of hello. "We'd love it more in a different building."

"Good morning to you too, Ruth."

"I've watched it, and everybody's watched it. My daughter sent it to me. My *daughter*. She's at Oberlin. She doesn't know what I do." A breath. "It's a beautiful piece of film. It's also your co-founder removing a heritage asset from the premises in the middle of the night without notice, during a live transaction, with a city permit for HVAC units."

“It’s her room, Ruth. It’s on a lease, and she owns it.”

“I know. Diane read me the lease. Diane laughed. Diane is our general counsel and I have never heard her laugh.” Treadmill, treadmill. “The board meets on the nineteenth. Pip is on the agenda, item four, and the motion is censure.”

“Ruth, I don’t think that’s going to—“

“It’s a word, Adam. It’s a symbolic word. It goes in the minutes and it tells Halvard this board is functional. You and I both know the deal is the only item on that agenda that matters. I need her yes by the end of the month, and I need it without any more cranes.”

“She won’t say yes to Halvard.”

“Then you need to find out what she’ll say yes to,” Ruth says. “That’s your job. You’re the closer, so close.”

She hangs up. Ruth always hangs up first. I think it’s in the Lakeshore Ventures employee handbook.

Simone has written something down, and I lean over to read it. It says 4. *Censure (symbolic)*, and next to it, very small, a question mark.

“Four,” she says, “is Gordon.”

Gordon Pyle comes in a little after nine with his laptop held against his chest the way you’d hold a baby in a burning building. His cardigan is buttoned one hole off. “My mother saw the crane on the news in Holland,” he says from the doorway, “and she called to ask if we’re solvent.” Our CFO wears a cardigan in all seasons and sweats in all of them, and he’s a good man, and he’s the only person in the company who knows the actual number, and the number has been wearing him down since the summer like water on a step.

He sits and opens the laptop. His eyes go to me, then to Simone, then to the door, which is glass, which everybody on the floor can see through.

“Can we pull the blinds?” he says.

“There are no blinds,” says Simone. “It is a transparency room.”

Gordon closes his eyes for a moment. Then he turns the laptop around.

It's the cash report. I know what it says. I've known what it says since August. But Gordon makes me look at it every Wednesday anyway, like a dentist putting the X-ray up on the light box.

"Eleven weeks," he says. "At current burn. Nashville is costing us four hundred and twenty thousand a week. Clyde Park is cash positive on the Corner and negative on everything else. And the deposits," he says, and scrolls, "are in escrow."

"All of them, Gordon?"

"Every dollar of them."

"Why?"

Gordon gives me the face you'd give a man who asked why the sun comes up.

"Because of the door, Adam."

Rule two. *Never spend a customer's money before you've cut their steel.* Pip's rule. She wrote it on the inside of the door in 2014 with a carpenter's pencil, after a guy we bought lumber from in Holland went under owing forty families their deposits. It's in the bylaws now. It's in the terms of sale. Eighteen hundred people have sent us ten percent of a backyard room in the last two days and we can't touch a penny of it until somebody at Clyde Park cuts the first piece of steel for their unit.

Which is the right thing. It's the most Pip thing in the whole company, and it's why people trust us. And in eleven weeks it's going to sit there in a bank in Cleveland and watch us run out of money.

"And Northgate," Gordon says. He says *Northgate* like the name of a disease in his family.

"What about Northgate?"

"They called. Somebody at Northgate watched the video. They'd like to know if the," he reads off a sticky note, "*founder dispute is material to the covenant.*"

Simone doesn't lift her eyes from the notebook. She knows about Northgate, and she's the only one besides Gordon who does.

On paper I'm worth about four hundred million dollars. A business magazine did a list of Midwest founders under forty-five last spring and put Pip and me on it together, *the billion-dollar couple*, with a photo of us on the roof of the Lindqvist building that my mother has framed in Sarasota next to the scissor lift. In my checking account, as of this morning, I have eleven thousand dollars.

Here's what nobody else knows. In October, when we were three weeks from missing the first payroll this company ever missed, I borrowed nine million dollars from Northgate Capital in Chicago. Personally. Me, Adam Kerrigan, with my own name on it. I put up my shares as collateral, all thirty-four percent of them, and I lent the money to the company, and the company made payroll, and two hundred and ninety people got paid on a Friday and never knew why the Friday before it I didn't sleep.

The loan has a covenant. If the company's cash falls below six million on the test date in March, Northgate can call the loan. If I can't pay it, Northgate takes my shares.

I didn't tell Pip.

That's a pitch, the way I just said that. I didn't tell Pip, like it's a fact about the weather. Strike it. Here's the true version. I sat at the kitchen counter at two in the morning in October with the Northgate papers in front of me and the pen in my hand, and Pip was asleep upstairs, across the hall, and I thought: if I go up those stairs and wake her up and tell her, then she'll know. She'll know the thing I've been carrying since August, that the company I sold to everybody as the future of work is three weeks from not making payroll, and that I opened Nashville, and Nashville is eating us. And then it'll be real. And she'll give me the face she gave me the morning after Nashville, and then no face at all.

So I signed it at the counter. And then I picked up my phone and called the one person I knew would be awake, who had the numbers already, who wouldn't make any face at all.

“What do I tell them?” Gordon says, peeling the sticky note off his finger and sticking it to the laptop lid. “They want it in writing by Friday. On letterhead.”

“Tell Northgate the founders are aligned,” I say.

“Are they aligned?”

“They will be by the nineteenth.”

Gordon writes it down on the sticky note, and he doesn’t believe it either. He closes his laptop and holds it against his chest again and goes out through the glass door, and the whole floor tracks him to the elevator, and nobody pretends otherwise.

Before the elevator doors close on him, Tavi comes down the aisle from marketing at a jog with a sheet of printer paper and presses it flat against the glass wall beside my head. He’s written on it in orange marker, big enough to read from Monroe Avenue: *1,900!!* Two exclamation points. He gives me a thumbs-up through the glass with his other hand.

Simone lifts one finger off her pen and waves him on without turning around, and he goes, delighted, to show somebody else.

“He does that every hundred,” she says.

“It’s a good number.”

“It is a number we cannot spend, written on a wall everybody can see through,” she says, and makes another mark. “Five is the Lite test protocol. Clyde Park runs the rack test on Monday. I need a signature from product architecture.”

“Product architecture is Pip.”

“I am aware of who it is.”

“Mail it to her, then.”

“I will drive it out to her on Monday.”

“She’ll feed it to the press brake in front of you.”

“Then I will learn whether she reads it first.” She turns to a clean page.

“Can we skip to eleven?”

“Eleven is lunch.” She puts her pen down. She almost never puts her pen down. “Adam. How do you get her to yes?”

“I don’t know.”

It comes out of my mouth before I can stop it. *I don’t know*. I don’t say that. I don’t say it in meetings, I don’t say it to investors, I don’t say it to my mother on the phone in Sarasota when she asks if I’m happy. Simone catches it too. Her eyebrows go up a sixteenth of an inch and stay there while she decides what to do with it.

“You could ask her,” she says.

“I asked her.”

“You told her. Through a door, with a slide.” She lines the pen up with the edge of the notebook, square. “I was in the room Monday. You did not ask her anything. You told her she barely uses it.”

“She doesn’t use it.”

“Neither do you.”

There’s no expression on her face when she says it. It’s just another item, five or six, a part number. She picks her pen back up.

“You say yes to me before I finish the sentence,” she says, writing. “You have done it since May. I ask for a budget line and you say yes. I ask for headcount and you say yes. I asked for the corner office as a joke, Adam, I asked because it was empty and I was tired of taking calls in the stairwell, and you said yes before I got to the word *office*.” She underlines something. “I did not think about why until Monday. I think you say yes to me so fast because nothing I ask for costs you anything.”

She rubs the bridge of her nose with two fingers, and for a moment she looks younger and more tired, and for half a second I see her as I’d see her if we’d met at a trade show in Chicago with no rings on anybody’s hands and a hotel bar that stayed open late. I don’t let the thought finish. I’ve been not finishing it since August, at one in the morning, with her voice in my ear and my wife on the other side of a wall. Not finishing a thought every night for five months is its own kind of answer, and I know it, and I look away.

I look past her through the glass wall at the northwest corner of the floor, where there’s nothing now but brick and two big windows over Monroe

Avenue and four steel bolt plates in the maple floor, bright and clean, where somebody's set a little orange safety cone so nobody trips.

Somebody put a cone there. I didn't ask for a cone.

"Six," says Simone.

I keep my eyes on the cone. I'm thinking about the room, the room and not the video. The way the light came in at seven in the morning in winter, low over the river, and lay across her desk in a long gold bar, and she'd have her feet up on the radiator in her wool socks and a cup of moka-pot coffee that tasted like a tire fire, and I'd come off the elevator just before seven with my espresso and say *Okay, boss, what are we doing today?* and she'd tell me.

When was the last time I went up there at seven?

After Nashville. She stopped coming up at seven, and I stopped asking, and we let the room go dark and called it a schedule.

"Six," Simone says again, gently.

"What's six?" I say.

Chapter 8 — Pip

By Thursday the intern has moved into my plant.

He shows up just after seven in a new coat, an actual Carhartt, brown duck, so stiff it stands up when he takes it off, with the price sticker still on the sleeve. He carries his laptop under his arm. He asks Irene at the glazing table where I am, and Irene points with her chin, and he comes across the floor through the noise toward my bench with the face of a man walking into a church he wasn't raised in.

"Morning," I say. "That's a nice coat you've got."

"Lolo took me to Farm and Fleet." He sets the laptop on my bench, next to the vise. "She said if I was going to keep coming out here I couldn't dress like a European."

"And are you going to keep coming out here?"

"Marketing doesn't need me," he says, opening the laptop. "Marketing has a war room now. They have a whiteboard that says *VIRAL MOMENT, CAPITALIZE*. Somebody drew a crane on it, and the crane is bad, and I'd rather be here." He turns the screen toward me. "Also I built this, and I wanted you to see it before anybody made it into a slide."

It's a dashboard, a map of the United States in gray, with little orange dots on it. There are a lot of orange dots. There are so many orange dots around Grand Rapids and Chicago and Minneapolis and Detroit that they've run together into orange puddles. There's one in Juneau, and one in Key West, and one, absurdly, in the middle of Nevada where I'm pretty sure there isn't anything but a bomb range and a very good diner.

Down in the corner it says 2,247. While I'm reading it, it says 2,251.

"Each dot's a deposit," Tavi says. "For a Corner, the real one. It refreshes every ninety seconds."

"I know what a dot is, Tavi."

"Sorry," he says, and doesn't sound sorry. He sounds like a kid who built a train set. "You can click them and read the notes."

I don't want to click them. I click one, in Nevada.

Bought this for my wife. She's been saying for twenty years she needs a room of her own. I watched the video and thought, she's right, she does. Please don't put a post in it.

I click one in Kalamazoo.

I want the room she took.

I close the laptop, not hard, just closed.

"Thank you," I say, and mean it. "That's beautiful work."

"I can make you a version that just shows the number."

"Make me a version that doesn't exist."

He thinks about that seriously, nodding. Then he goes off to find Lolo, who's not even on shift yet, because apparently Lolo is his person now. That happens to people around Lolo. She adopts them by insulting their clothes.

The crew knows about the dots by nine. By ten they know the number, and by eleven it's a game. Every time somebody walks past the break room where Tavi's set the laptop up on the microwave cart, they call out the count. Two thousand three hundred. Two thousand three hundred forty. Darnell writes it on the whiteboard by the time clock where we usually write safety days.

DAYS SINCE LOST-TIME INJURY: 211

ROOMS SOLD SINCE PIP STOLE ONE: 2,388

"Erase *stole*," I tell him.

"It's accurate, boss," Darnell says, capping the marker. "It was on Channel 6, and they had a graphic."

"I didn't steal anything, it's on a lease, and I'm the landlord."

"So what do you want, *evicted*?"

"Darnell, Tavi photographs everything in this building, so write something nicer."

Irene comes over from glazing, pulling off her cut gloves one finger at a time, and reads the board with her head tilted, the way she reads a pane for ripple. "*Relocated*, that's what we'd put on a work order," she says.

"*Relocated* is boring," Darnell says. "Nobody's going to make a video about *relocated*."

"Nobody's supposed to make a video about any of it," I say.

He erases *stole* with the side of his fist and writes *liberated*. I let that one go.

Irene doesn't go back to the glazing table. She stands there with her gloves in one hand, looking at the number, and her mouth moves a little while she does the math.

"My glass guy called from Holland," she says. "He saw it on the news like everybody. He wants to know does he hold float time for us."

"How much float time is he talking about?"

"He didn't say how much. He said the line books up by March, and if he doesn't hold it for us he's selling it to the people who make shower doors in Ohio." She folds the gloves over. "I told him I'd ask you first."

Two thousand three hundred and ninety-something rooms, each with two glass walls and no post. I know what a float line is. I know what it means when a man in Holland calls a glazier directly instead of calling purchasing, and it means he's heard something purchasing hasn't.

"Tell him to hold it," I say. "Tell him to hold it and not to send a bill."

"He's going to ask who's paying."

"Then tell him to call me, and I'll tell him about my mother's pierogi until he forgets the question."

Irene gives me a long flat look, the one she gives a pane with a bubble in it, and goes back to the glazing table to call Holland.

At lunch Benny finds me at my bench. He's got his sandwich in one hand and his earplugs hanging around his neck on their orange cord.

"Boss, got a question for you," he says.

I tell him to go ahead.

"Are we getting sold?"

I put my file down.

Benny doesn't sit. He stands at the end of my bench holding the sandwich the way he held parts up to the light on the Lindqvist line, next to my father and Lolo, before Lindqvist moved the line to North Carolina and then moved North Carolina to Vietnam. "I got a kid at Grand Valley," he says, "and a wife

who does your mother's hair, so I'm asking." He doesn't ask questions he doesn't need the answer to.

"Who told you that?" I ask, and keep my hand on the file.

"Darnell's wife's sister cleans offices downtown, Lindqvist building, nights. There's a word on a whiteboard up on four that says *North*." He takes a bite of sandwich. "Nobody calls a project *North* unless it's going to Minneapolis."

I think about slide eleven. Phase two, months six to eighteen. Holland, Michigan, and Monterrey, Mexico. The footnote in eight-point type.

I could tell him; he's standing right there. I could say: *There's an offer. I'm the no. As long as I'm the no, it doesn't happen.* That's true, all of it.

And then he'd ask how long I can be the no, and I wouldn't know, and he'd go back out on the floor with that, and by afternoon break the whole line would have it, and by Friday half of them would be on Indeed.

"Nobody's selling this plant, Benny," I say.

He keeps his eyes on me, chewing. Benny knew me when I was eleven, sitting on a bucket by my father's welder, eating his potato chips.

"Okay," he says finally, wiping mustard off his thumb. "Your dad used to say a thing about the plant."

"Which thing?"

"*If you hear it in the break room, it's already true somewhere.*"

"My dad said a lot of things."

"He did," Benny says, and goes back to the forklift, chewing.

In the middle of the afternoon a woman named Carla Ruiz from Channel 6 calls my cell. I don't know how she got my cell. She's very nice about it. She's done a story on the video for the evening news, and she says into the phone that she'd love a follow-up, live, in the yard, by the room, the human angle, a founder and her—

"No," I say.

"Just five minutes. You wouldn't have to say anything about the company, just the room, and what it means to you."

"It's a room, Ms. Ruiz."

“Two point one million people watched it come out of a building,” Carla Ruiz says, warmly. “I don’t think it’s just a room, Ms. Sobczak.”

“Call Adam Kerrigan, he loves a camera,” I say.

“I called him first, and he said to call you.”

That stops me, and I don’t know why it stops me. I tell her no again and hang up and sit there with the phone in my hand, thinking about Adam, who has never in his life turned down a camera, telling a reporter to call me.

Saturday morning my father comes to the yard.

He drives himself, in the 2004 Buick LeSabre he refuses to replace, with the vinyl roof peeling off in strips like the bark of a birch, and he parks it crooked across two spaces by the fence because he’s seventy-four and can no longer be bothered with lines. He gets out slow, one leg and then the other. Stan Sobczak was a tool-and-die man for forty-one years, and his hands look it, big and nicked and gray at the knuckles, and his back looks it too, a little bent forward, like he’s always about to look at something closer.

He’s wearing his Lindqvist jacket and carrying a white paper bag from Marge’s.

“Dzień dobry,” he says, and then, “You stole your room.”

“I took my room, Tato.”

“Your mother says you stole it. Your mother says it was on the television.” He walks past me to the room on its cribbing and stands in front of it with his hands in his pockets, looking up at it with the face he used to make at a part that came off the press perfect, the face of a man in church who’s decided God’s doing okay. “Huh.”

“What’s that *huh* supposed to mean?”

“It held up,” he says.

“Of course it held up, you welded it.”

“You designed it,” he says, and goes around to the corner, the glass corner, and crouches down slowly to look at the joint at the base, where the knee frame goes under the floor. He puts his finger on it. “That was a bitch to weld.”

“I know it was. I held the light for you.”

“Three tries, it took us.”

"It took four, and you know it took four."

"Four," he agrees. "You burned your eyebrow on the third one."

"I remember, Tato, I was there."

"I'm just saying," he says, and straightens up, one hand on his knee. "I'm saying it held up."

He doesn't go in yet. He stands with his finger still on the corner, and then he turns and squints across the yard at the plant, at the rolling door, at the sound of the line coming out of it.

"Who's welding your knees now?"

"The same four as always, Tato."

"Four," he says, and holds up his hand and looks at it like it belongs to somebody he used to work with. "I got one more good knee in me."

"Tato, you shake when you sign a birthday card."

"So I don't sign the card. I hold the stinger," he says, lowering the hand. "Your mother would kill me. She'd kill me and then she'd come out here and kill you for letting me."

"So you're telling me that's a no."

"That's a no from your mother," he says. "From me it's a maybe."

We go inside, and he sits down in the other chair, the radiator chair, the one where nobody sits, and opens the bag, and takes out two paczki and hands me one on a napkin, and eats his in about four bites, the powdered sugar going all down the front of the Lindqvist jacket. He chews and takes in the room, the desk, the cedar, and then the inside of the door.

At the door he stops chewing.

"Ha," he says.

"What's so funny about my door?"

"*Nobody decides alone*," he says, pointing with the last of his paczek. "That one was mine."

"That one was all of ours."

"No, no. That was mine. I said that in the garage. You wrote it down like the Ten Commandments." He shakes his head, delighted with himself. "I meant your mother and the thermostat. Your mother would turn it to sixty-two

and I'd turn it to sixty-eight and we'd do that all winter, back and forth, like a war. *Nobody decides alone*. I said it about the thermostat, and you two kids put it on a door."

"It's still a good rule."

"It's a great rule for a thermostat." He brushes sugar off his front, and it doesn't come off. "Him, his writing's the third one?"

"His is the note under it, *Not seven-fifteen*."

He laughs at that, one bark. "He was always late."

"He was early, for a while."

My father turns from the door to me. He has my eyes, or I have his, gray and small and set deep, like they're staying out of the weather. For a second I think he's going to ask, and I don't know what I'll say if he does. My father and I don't talk about things. We talk about welds. We've had our whole relationship about welds. When I was nine he told me I was a good girl by handing me a rod of 6011 and letting me run a bead on a piece of scrap, and that was better than any hug I ever got in my life.

"You two used to have coffee in here," he says. "Your mother told me, every morning at seven o'clock."

"That was ages ago, Tato."

"Two years isn't ages."

"How do you know how long it's been?"

He shrugs, and his eyes go back to the door and stay there.

"Your mother knows everything," he says. "She just doesn't say it to you. She says it to me, in the car, on the way home from church. She talks the whole way. I'm a captive audience."

"So what does she say, in the car?"

He thinks about it, and then he reaches over and takes the rest of my paczek out of my hand, the half I haven't eaten, and eats it.

"She says you should eat," he says, with his mouth full.

Chapter 9 — Pip

Simone Achterberg arrives at the plant on Monday a little after eight in a gray Volvo with a ski rack and no skis, parks it between the lines, straight, and walks across the yard in a pair of lined rubber boots that are exactly right for the yard. I'll give her the boots. Nobody from downtown ever wears the right boots out here. They come out in loafers and stand in the slush with their faces getting longer and longer, like men being slowly lowered into a lake.

I'm at the test rig on the far side of the yard, outside the rolling door, with Irene and Darnell. The rig is a steel frame the size of a garage door, painted yellow, with a hydraulic ram on one side and a big analog gauge on a stand. Bolted into it is somebody else's corner, a Lite, two short sections of wall meeting at a square steel post, four inches by four, painted the oatmeal color that came down from the integration team.

Darnell's working the pump and Irene's got the clipboard. I'm standing with my arms crossed, keeping my eyes on the post, because a post is a thing I can't stop looking at, like somebody chewing with their mouth open.

Simone walks up to the gauge. She doesn't say good morning. She leans in close to the dial with her hands behind her back, like a woman at a museum who's been told not to touch, and then she taps the glass with one fingernail anyway.

"Your zero's drifted," she says. "You're reading high, about two percent."

Darnell stops pumping and wipes his hands down his jeans. Irene's eyes go to the gauge, then to Simone, then to me.

"How do you know that?" Darnell asks her, not unfriendly.

"The needle's resting a hair past the pin, and you've got no load on it yet." She steps back. "It will make the Lite look stiffer than it is. Which I would prefer it not do, because I would like to know how stiff it is."

I bend down to the gauge. She's right. I hate that she's right, and I uncross my arms so nobody can tell. It's the kind of thing I'd catch if I weren't busy glaring at a post.

"Darnell," I say, "re-zero it."

He does it with a jeweler's screwdriver he keeps in his breast pocket. The needle drops back onto the pin with a tiny click, like it's embarrassed.

Simone turns to me. "Good morning, Pip."

"You drove out here to fix my gauge?"

"I drove out here to ask you to sign off on the Lite test protocol. The gauge was a bonus." She has a folder under her arm. Of course she has a folder. "I have the protocol, the load schedule, and the acceptance criteria. Irene has already reviewed them, and Irene has notes."

Irene shrugs one shoulder at me, which means *she's not wrong about the notes*.

"Inside," I say. "It's cold out here."

We go into the room. Simone wipes her boots on my mother's bread-bag rug, both feet, twice, which my mother would like. She stops just inside and looks around the way people look around a church in a town they're passing through, polite, a little curious about what everybody's praying for. Her eyes go to the desk, and to the glass corner, and to the radiator chair, and then to the inside of the door.

She reads it all the way through, the way she reads everything, and then she reads it again, slower.

"Rule two," she says.

"What about rule two?"

"*Never spend a customer's money before you've cut their steel.*" She turns from the door. "Gordon showed me the escrow balance on Friday. It's nine point two million dollars. It's the most money this company has had in one place since the Series D, and nobody can touch it."

"That's the idea."

"It is the most expensive sentence in this company."

"It's the cheapest one," I say. "It just bills us at the wrong time."

She presses her lips together and looks down at the rug for a second, and I don't know her well enough to read it. It might be a smile. It might be a woman doing the arithmetic on a sentence.

I take the folder and sit down at the desk. She doesn't sit in the other chair. She stays standing by the door with her hands folded in front of her, like a witness who's been told she can sit and has decided not to.

The protocol is good. It's very good: load schedules, deflection limits, cycle counts, and a section on how the posted corner behaves under snow load that's honestly better than the one I wrote for the original in 2014. Irene's notes are in red pen down the margins, in her square capitals: *GOOD. GOOD. NO, RACKING NEEDS 3 CYCLES NOT 2. GOOD.* At the bottom of the last page there's a line for my signature, under the words *Product architecture approval (Founder, Design).*

"Irene says racking needs three cycles," I say.

"Irene is correct. I wrote two because two is what Halvard's lab runs."

"Halvard's lab is in Minneapolis. Nothing racks in Minneapolis, they're too polite."

She holds her hand out. I give her the page. She takes the pen out of her coat, draws one straight line through the 2, writes 3 above it, and initials it, small, S.A., and hands it back.

"You're just changing it?"

"It was wrong," she says. "Now it is not."

I read the rest. It doesn't take long.

"No," I say.

"You have not read page six."

"I don't need to read page six. It's a good test, a better test than mine, and I'm not signing it."

"Why not?"

"Because you'll use it to build a room with a post in it."

"That is what the Lite is."

"I know what the Lite is, Simone."

"Pip." She says it carefully, as if my name might bite. "I have spent four months trying to take the post out of the Lite. Four months. I had two consultants. I had a structural engineer from Purdue. I had Darnell on weekends." She nods out the window, toward the rig, where Darnell is

pumping again and glaring at the needle like it owes him money. “I cannot do it at that price. Nobody can. The only way to get a corner with no post is your knee, and your knee is eleven hours of welding by four of the best people in Michigan, and Halvard’s cost model allows four.”

“So don’t sell it to Halvard.”

“That is not my decision.”

“It’s not *mine* either, apparently. It’s on a slide.”

She doesn’t flinch. Most people flinch when I do that voice. Even Adam flinches.

“Most customers will not notice the post,” she says.

“Two thousand four hundred people noticed there isn’t one.”

“Two thousand six hundred and twelve, as of this morning.” She glances at her watch, which is an actual watch, with hands. “Tavi messages me the number. I did not ask him to. He seems to need someone to tell.”

I put the folder down on the desk with my hand flat on it, and look out at the yard past the place where the post would be, at the fence and the snow and the line of maples along Clyde Park that somebody planted in the seventies and then forgot about, so they grew up crooked and huge and full of crows.

“You know why the corner has no post?” I ask her, still looking out.

“Load path. The moment frame—“

“No. I mean why.”

She waits. She’s good at waiting. That’s two things I’ll give her now, and I’m starting to resent the count.

“Because when you sit in a small room,” I say, “the corner’s where your eye goes. Everybody. Kids, old people, everybody. You sit down in a little room, you look out the corner. It’s the farthest point. It’s where the room opens. And if there’s a post there, then every time you look out, the first thing you see is a post.” I tap the folder. “People buy these to get out of their houses. Their marriages. Their kids. They go out to the backyard and sit in a little room so they can look at something that isn’t the thing they’re stuck in. I wasn’t going to make them look at a post.”

Simone doesn't answer right away. Out in the yard the ram hisses, and the needle climbs, and Darnell calls out a number to Irene.

"I did not know that," she says finally.

"It's not in the protocol."

"It should be." She holds her hand out for the folder again, and I give it back to her. She opens it to page one and writes something across the top in her small, level handwriting, and I lean over to read it.

Design intent: the eye goes to the corner.

"I'm still not signing it," I say.

"I did not expect you to." She closes the folder. "I expected to learn why. I have learned why."

That's not what I thought she'd say. I've had Simone Achterberg in my head for a week as a woman in a navy sweater putting a ficus on my desk, and I didn't make room for a woman who'd drive out to Clyde Park in the right boots to learn why.

She doesn't leave. She stands there with the folder against her chest, and I can tell she's deciding something.

"Lolo told me you were married in this room," she says.

"Lolo talks, that's her whole job."

"Lolo was standing at the gate when I parked. She asked me if I was the one with the ficus. I said yes. She said, and I am quoting, *You know they got married in that thing, hon? In her daddy's garage. Ten minutes. I made the pierogi.*" Simone's voice doesn't change at all doing Lolo, which somehow makes it funnier. "If I had known, I would not have asked for it."

"You'd have asked for something else."

"I would have asked for a door that closes. That is what I wanted." She turns her head toward the door, the birch one with the writing on the inside. "I was taking calls in the stairwell. It smells like pigeons."

"It smells like pigeons and radiator paint."

"Since 1922, apparently."

"There's the copy room on three," I say. "That has a door that closes."

“It closes on the copier. The copier is in there with you, the whole time, breathing.”

“Where’d you get the boots?”

“Farm and Fleet, on Saturday. I asked the intern where Lolo had taken him.” She glances down at them. “He said she told him he could not dress like a European out here. I did not want to be told.”

“Lolo would have told you anyway.”

“She did. At the gate, she looked at my feet and said *those’ll do, hon*. I have decided to take it as a review.”

We stand there on either side of my desk. It’s strange. It’s like looking at somebody across a fence you put up yourself.

“Can I ask you something?” I say, before she can go.

“Yes, you can.”

“The calls at one in the morning.”

It lands. She decides whether to pretend she doesn’t know what I mean, and decides not to. Her hands tighten on the folder, just a little, the knuckles going pale along the edge.

“He cannot sleep,” she says. “I cannot sleep. My daughter is in East Lansing and my ex-husband is in Phoenix with a dental hygienist named Courtney, and I live in a rented condo on Ionia Avenue with eleven boxes I have not unpacked since May. When it is late, and neither of us is asleep, he calls and we go over the numbers. Then we talk about other things. He tells me stories. He’s very funny that late.”

“I know he is.”

“I know you know.” She says it gently. “I have not touched him, and he has not touched me. I am telling you that plainly, because you are entitled to it. What else I feel at that hour, I have not decided is any of your business.” She turns the folder a quarter turn against her chest. “He is the only person awake.”

“He’s not the only person awake,” I say.

It comes out of me before I can stop it. It comes out in my mother’s voice, and Simone catches it. She keeps her eyes on me, and something in her face shifts, and she looks at me a second time, more carefully.

“No,” she says. “I suppose he isn’t.”

Outside, Darnell yells something, and Irene yells something back, and the ram goes quiet. Simone turns to look through the glass. The needle on the gauge has stopped. The oatmeal-colored post is standing there in the yellow frame, holding its corner up, steady as a fence post, doing its job. It passes. I can tell from Darnell’s face that it passes.

“It’s a good post,” I say. “It’s not a bad post. It’s just a post.”

Simone puts the folder under her arm and opens the door, and the cold comes in. She stops on the step, half in and half out, and turns back to the gauge across the yard.

“Have them re-zero it after every run,” she says. “Your zero’s going to keep drifting. It’s the cold.”

Chapter 10 — Adam

Kurt Lindahl orders the bone-in ribeye, medium rare, and then asks the waiter, a kid named Tyler with a neck tattoo of a compass, whether the beef is from Michigan.

“I think it’s from a cow, sir,” says Tyler.

Kurt laughs so hard he has to put his napkin to his mouth. I laugh too, a beat behind him, the laugh you do at the table with the man who’s writing the check. Tyler doesn’t laugh, because Tyler has said a true thing and doesn’t understand why it’s funny, and he goes away to find out about the cow.

We’re at Moretti’s on Ottawa, in the back room with the red leather booths and the photos of Gerald Ford shaking hands with people who are all dead now. I booked the back room because it’s quiet. Kurt likes quiet when he’s about to say a number.

“So,” he says, and folds his own on the tablecloth. “The hands.”

“The hands,” I say, and I already don’t like how it sounds in here.

“I’ve been thinking about her all week.” He spreads butter on a roll with great care, all the way to the edges. “I watched the video eleven times. My wife watched it with me. My wife said, *That woman isn’t for sale, Kurt*. My wife is very perceptive.”

“Your wife sounds right to me.”

“Everybody’s for sale, Adam. You and I both know that. Not for money, necessarily. For the right thing.” He sets the knife down. “So what’s the right thing?”

That’s the question I’ve been asking myself since she said *I’m a no* in a room in a yard with snow melting off my coat. I’m a closer: I find out what people want and I give it to them in a shape they can say yes to. I’ve done it with pension funds, with a Saudi family office, with a woman in Holland who owned the only lot zoned for our first showroom and wanted us to name the parking lot after her late poodle. We did. It’s called Biscuit Lot, and there’s a plaque.

I don’t know what Pip wants. I used to know what she wanted before she did.

“Clyde Park, Kurt,” I tell him. “She wants the plant.”

“Done,” Kurt says, without even blinking. “Three years, we’ll put it in the agreement. No consolidation of Clyde Park for thirty-six months post-close.”

“Thirty-six months is phase two plus eighteen.”

“It’s a long time in manufacturing.”

“It’s not long to Benny Szymanski.”

“I don’t know who that is.”

“He drives the forklift at Clyde Park. Fifty-eight, with a daughter at Grand Valley.”

Kurt smiles at me like I’ve made a lovely point at a dinner party. “We’ll make it thirty-six months and a retention pool, a generous one. And for Pip,” he says, and leans in over the bread, “Chief Design Officer, Halvard Residential. All eleven brands. Her own studio, anywhere she wants. Grand Rapids, Minneapolis, Milan. Whatever she wants it to look like. She can design it.”

She can design it. I said that to her. A week ago, on four, with a coffee tray in my hands. *We’ll get you something better. You can design it.* The sentence comes back across the table to me in another man’s mouth, and now I know how it sounds, which is like handing someone a coloring book after you’ve taken their house.

“She’ll say no,” I say.

“Make it sound like yes.”

“I don’t know how.”

He tilts his head at me. I’ve said it twice now in a week. *I don’t know.* It’s like a cough I can’t get rid of.

“Then let me help you with that.” He takes his phone out of his jacket and turns it around on the tablecloth so it faces me, and slides it past the bread basket. “Our studio put this together this afternoon for the spring catalog, very rough.”

It’s a render of the Corner, my wife’s Corner, set in a backyard that doesn’t exist, all blue sky and tasteful mulch, with a Halvard wordmark in the bottom right and under it, smaller, *by Twodesk*. The glass walls are right and

the roof line is right, and at the joint where the two walls meet, a post, slim, brushed bronze, the color of a nice faucet.

“There’s a post,” I say.

“There’s a very elegant post. Our engineers say you can’t see it from the house.”

“You can see it from inside the room.”

“Adam,” he says, and takes the phone back and puts it face up beside his plate, where it lights up twice while we talk and he doesn’t look at it. “I’ll build her original for every deposit on the books. Every one of those people gets the room from the video, and Ruth knows that. After that it’s a catalog, and catalogs have posts. Nobody in Phoenix is going to sit in the yard and cry about a post.”

“Somebody in Duluth will cry about it.”

“Then I’ll sell Duluth the Long.” He picks his knife back up. “I don’t need her signature tonight. I need yours. My board meets on the twenty-first. I can tell them I have a CEO in Grand Rapids who can deliver his co-founder, or I can tell them I have a very nice video. Which one do I tell them?”

The waiter’s coming with the plates. Kurt doesn’t look at the waiter. He sits there with his knife in his hand, pleasant, waiting, the way a room waits after you’ve asked it for money.

“Tell them the first one,” I say.

I say it before the waiter gets to the table. It comes out that fast, and I pick up my water glass so I have something to do with my hand.

“Good,” Kurt says, warmly. “You sold me a garage in Grand Rapids for one point one billion dollars. You’ll figure it out, and afterward you’ll be a very rich man, Adam, in the bank and not just on paper.”

I have eleven thousand dollars in the bank. I smile at him over the water glass like a man with four hundred million.

The ribeye comes on a wooden board. It’s from a farm in Ionia County, Tyler reports. The cow’s name is unavailable.

I get home at five to midnight. The house is dark except for the kitchen, where the light over the stove is on, and when I come in through the back she’s

sitting at the counter at her end in my old Grand Valley sweatshirt and her wool socks, with the moka pot on the stove going *blup* and a mug in front of her and a pad of graph paper covered in drawings.

She doesn't look up from the paper.

"You're up late," I say, from the door.

"I'm up, and so are you."

"It's midnight, and you're making coffee."

"I'm making coffee at midnight, write it down."

I put my keys down. I take my coat off and hang it on the hook by the door, the one she put up in 2019 by drilling straight into the brick, and I stand there at my end.

The drawings are of the knee. I know it from across the room. I've watched her draw the knee a thousand times: on napkins, on whiteboards, on the back of a Costco receipt in the truck at a red light. She draws it like other people doodle a cat. This one is different though. There are numbers all down the side in her blocky little handwriting, and arrows, and a box around something that says *CP 2ND SHIFT?* and another one that says *6 DAYS?*

I nod at the pad. "What's that you're drawing?"

"Arithmetic."

"And what's the arithmetic for?"

She turns the page over.

Okay, that's fair, that's a fair move. I've been turning pages over on her since the spring before last and calling it strategy.

"How was dinner?" she asks.

"The ribeye was from Ionia."

"Good for the ribeye."

"Kurt wants to meet you again."

"He met me, and he put his hand on my window."

"He wants to meet you properly, over dinner. He has an offer, Pip, and it's —" It's happening. My voice is climbing up into the place she calls the nose voice, the voice I used on the poodle lady, and I can't get it back down. "It's a real offer. He'll put Clyde Park in the agreement. Thirty-six months, no

consolidation, in writing. There's a retention pool for the crew. And for you, Chief Design Officer, Halvard Residential, all eleven brands, your own studio, wherever you want, you can design—“

“Adam.”

“Design it from the ground up, Milan if you want, you always said you wanted to see—“

“You're pitching me.”

I stop, and the moka pot gurgles. She gets up and turns off the burner and pours the coffee into her mug, slowly, the black sludge of it, and sits back down and doesn't drink it.

“Strike that,” I say. “Sorry, strike all of it.”

“You keep saying that,” she says.

“Saying what?”

“*Strike that*, under your breath. You've been doing it for a year. You say a thing and then you mutter *strike that* like you're in a courtroom.” She wraps both hands around the mug. “Who are you talking to?”

Nobody's ever asked me that. I didn't know anybody could hear it.

“I'm talking to me,” I say.

“What do you say back?”

“Usually I say *try again*.”

She lifts her eyes from the mug. She's tired, and there are lines by her eyes that weren't there when we met at twenty-five in the back of a bar on Bridge Street where she was explaining to a man who designed office chairs that his chair was wrong. She has a smudge of graphite on her cheekbone. She has always had a smudge of graphite somewhere. I used to find it on her neck, in bed, and lick my thumb and get it off, and she'd say *leave it, it's structural*.

“Try again, then,” she says.

I stand there with my hands on the counter.

The true thing is sitting in my chest, the shape of a stone you swallowed as a kid that your mother swore would come out on its own. It has to do with the room, and why I said yes to Simone before she finished the sentence, and what

I couldn't stand to walk past. I can't get it up my throat. Not in a kitchen at midnight with my coat still damp on the hook.

"I miss you," I say instead.

It's true. It's just not the true thing.

She takes that in without doing anything with her face. Pip's face, when she doesn't want you to read it, is like the side of a building.

"I'm in the next room," she says.

"I know which room you're in."

"I've been in the next room for two years, Adam."

"I *know*."

"Then you don't miss me. You just haven't come in."

She picks up the graph paper, keeping it turned over, and her mug, and she goes past me at the end of the counter, close, so close I can smell the cedar from the room on her sweater, my sweater, and the graphite and the coffee. She stops for a second at the door to the hall. I think she's going to say something else.

"Kurt can't have the corner," she says. "Tell him that, it's not for sale. It's not a corner if you put a post in it, it's a wall that gave up."

I think of a brushed-bronze post the color of a nice faucet, on a phone face up beside a plate. I don't tell her about it.

Then she goes up the good stairs, and the ninth one creaks.

I stand in the kitchen while the stove light hums and the radiator knocks, and the moka pot cools on the stove with an inch still in it.

At one o'clock I'm sitting on the edge of the bed in the room across the hall from her, in the dark, with my phone in my hand. Simone will be up, Simone is always up. I could call and we'd go over the Kurt numbers and I'd tell her about the cow, and she'd say *that is not funny* in the way that means it's a little funny, and I'd feel better.

I keep the phone in my hand. Through the wall, two layers of plaster and a closet full of winter coats, there's no sound at all.

I put the phone face down on the nightstand and lie back on the bed in my clothes.

Chapter 11 — Pip

Ruth Baskin drinks an oat milk cortado with an extra shot, standing up, at a tall table by the window of a coffee place on Fulton Street that used to be a bank. The vault door is still there in the back, propped open, with a bookshelf inside it. Everything downtown used to be something else. That's the whole economy now, my brother Marek says: you take a building that did one thing and you make it do a cuter thing.

"Pip." She puts her hand out across the table. "Thank you for coming in."

"You drove from Ann Arbor for this?"

"I drive from Ann Arbor every week. It's an hour and ten if you don't respect the speed limit." She shakes my hand, firm, once, like she's testing a railing. "I listen to audiobooks about the Roman Empire on the way. I'm on the fall, and it's very relaxing."

Ruth's small and wiry, in a quilted vest and running shoes that cost more than my boots, and while she talks she keeps one heel going on the rung of her stool, steady, as if she's still out on the river trail and this is a stoplight. She's been on our board since the Series B. She's smart and she isn't mean. She's what my father would call a person who's never had to lift the heavy end of anything, which isn't the same as mean but rhymes with it.

I go up to the counter and order a regular coffee. The girl asks what size and I say *coffee size*, and she stares like I've spoken Latin at her, and then she rings me up for a large that costs six dollars and comes in a cardboard sleeve that says *Hello, Neighbor*.

"I'll get to it," Ruth says when I come back. "You don't like being warmed up. I've read the file."

"There's a file on me?"

"There's always a file, Pip." She sips. "I want you to vote yes on Halvard."

"I know you do."

"I'd like to tell you why, and then I'd like you to tell me why not, and then I'd like us to see if there's a version where we both get a little of what we want. That's what I do all day. That's the job."

"Go ahead, then."

She tells me why, and she does it well. She has a voice like a public radio host, and she doesn't use slides, and she doesn't pitch. The multiple is good and the market is soft. A company in Denver that did backyard studios got bought by somebody bigger, who shut it down in a year and kept the logo. Founders always think they're the exception, she says, and an offer like this doesn't come twice, and she has a fiduciary duty, and so do I.

"I know I do," I say. "To the company."

"To the shareholders, Pip."

"The company's the shareholders."

"The company's a lot of things." She smiles a little and counts them off on the table with one fingertip. "Your crew, your customers, two thousand-odd people with their deposits in escrow in Cleveland. Me, you, Adam."

"Halvard will close my plant."

"In eighteen months, yes."

"Kurt told Adam thirty-six."

Ruth tilts her head. That's news to her, and I watch her file it somewhere behind her eyes.

"In writing?" she says.

"I don't know. I get told things in kitchens at midnight."

"Well," Ruth says, "thirty-six is better than eighteen."

"Zero's better than thirty-six."

"Zero's not on the table, Pip."

"Then I'm a no."

She doesn't get angry; she lays one hand flat on the table next to her cup, and that's the thing about Ruth. She takes the no and holds it up to the light, turning it over, looking for the soft spot.

"You know the arithmetic," she says. "Adam and Lakeshore together are sixty-seven. A sale needs seventy-five. Without you it doesn't happen, and everybody at that table on the nineteenth knows it, which is why I'm buying you coffee."

"You didn't buy me coffee. I bought my coffee."

“Then I owe you six dollars.” She doesn’t reach for her wallet. “Do you know what my phone looked like the morning after your video? My limited partners called me thirty-one times. Every one of them asked if the founders were getting divorced. Nobody asked about the room.”

“What did you tell them?”

“That we’d take it offline.” She lifts her eyes over the rim of her cup. “Are you?”

“I just put a better heater in my office,” I say.

Ruth waits a second to see if there’s more, and there isn’t, and she nods like I’ve answered her. “Tell me your why not.”

“Here’s my why not,” I say. “The corner. You can’t build it with a post. If you put a post in it you’ve got the Lite, and the Lite’s a good room, Simone’s done good work on it, but it isn’t what three thousand people just put money down on. They put money down on a room you can sit in and look out the corner. Halvard’s going to take their money and give them a post. That’s my why not.”

“Three thousand?”

“Three thousand one hundred and forty, as of nine o’clock.” I check my phone, and Tavi’s newest text is already higher. “More by now.”

Ruth looks at the phone in my hand. Then she turns to the window, where a bus goes by on Fulton with an ad on the side for a personal injury lawyer whose face is on every bus in West Michigan, smiling, with his thumbs up, like a man who can’t believe you got hurt either.

“Pip,” she says. “I’m going to say something to you, and then I’m going to finish my cortado, and then I’m going to drive back to Ann Arbor and listen to the Visigoths sack Rome.”

“Okay,” I say. “Say it.”

“There are things about the company’s current position that you’d want to understand before the nineteenth. Things that would make Halvard look different to you. I didn’t say better.”

The coffee in my cup is too hot to drink and I hold it anyway, because my hands want something to do. Then I put it down on the table between us. “What things?”

Ruth drinks the rest of her cortado. She puts the little glass down on the table and lines it up with the edge, the way Simone squared her napkin, as people do when they’re about to leave a room on purpose.

“Ask your husband,” she says.

She puts on her coat, a long black puffer that makes her look like a very determined sleeping bag, and shakes my hand again, once, the railing test.

“I like you,” she says. “I liked the video. My daughter sent it to me from Oberlin, and my daughter has never sent me anything about my work in her life. She asked me if you were hiring.” She pulls her gloves on. “She’s a philosophy major.”

“Tell her we need welders.”

“I’ll tell her. She’ll think you’re being metaphorical.” Ruth picks up her bag. “I’ll see you on the nineteenth.”

She goes out into the cold, and I sit there at the tall table by the window of the bank that isn’t a bank anymore, holding a cup I can’t drink.

Ask your husband.

I could call him right now. He’s on four, in the glass room. If I lean I can almost make out the top of the Lindqvist building two blocks down over the roofs, with its water tower and its painted sign. I could call and say *Ruth says there are things*, and he’d pick up, he always picks up, and he’d say *what things*, and I’d know from the half second before *what things* whether there were things.

I take my phone out and look at his name: ADAM, with the photo I put on his contact in 2016 of him asleep in the truck at a rest stop outside Toledo, mouth open, a bag of pretzels on his chest.

I text Tavi instead. *How many now*. He answers in four seconds with a bigger number and a little crane.

I tell myself it’s because Adam will pitch me. That he’ll get on the phone and do the voice and I’ll lose an hour of a Wednesday listening to the donor-

dinner version of whatever this is. That if there are things, they'll be on the agenda on the nineteenth, in a gray box, and I can read them there like everybody else.

That's not the reason. The reason is that if I ask him and he tells me, then it's a thing we know together, and I've gotten very used to not knowing things together.

I put my phone in my coat and drive to Clyde Park.

Lolo's on early because Darnell's at the hospital with his wife for her second false alarm this week. She's in the break room with Irene and a box of Marge's, standing at the whiteboard by the time clock where Darnell keeps the count. *ROOMS SOLD SINCE PIP LIBERATED ONE*, and under it a number that's been rubbed out and rewritten so many times the board's gone gray. Next to that, somebody's drawn a little crane, worse than the marketing one.

"Hon," Lolo says when she sees me. "Irene and me did some math."

"Since when do you do math?"

"Since you started sitting in a room in the yard drawing on graph paper and not telling anybody why." She uncaps a marker and holds it out sideways without looking. "Irene."

Irene steps up and takes it. Irene's fifty, from Bay City, a glazing lead for nine years, and she talks maybe twelve sentences a day, eleven of them about glass. She writes on the whiteboard in her square capitals.

1 SHIFT: 1,800/YR.

2 SHIFTS: 3,400.

2 SHIFTS + SAT: 4,100.

She underlines the last one twice and hands the marker back to Lolo.

"That's knee capacity," Lolo says. "That's how many knees we can weld if everybody works Saturdays. Darnell figured the paint booth can keep up if we run it two shifts. Benny says the forklift can keep up if Benny gets a raise."

"Benny always says that."

"Benny's always right." Lolo caps the marker. "So you've got three thousand people wanting a room with no post in it, and you've got a plant that

can make four thousand a year if you ask nice. That's what's on your graph paper."

Irene turns around from the board with her arms folded. "Saturdays I go to my sister's," she says. "I'll go Sundays. She won't like it. She'll live."

"Write that down, hon," Lolo says to me. "Irene just gave up a sister for you."

"I'll put it in the plan," I say. "Line item, one sister, Bay City."

"Put it above the steel," says Irene, and turns back to the board, which is more sentences than I've heard from her since Thanksgiving.

I look at the board. Irene's number beats the one on my graph paper, because Irene knows the glass line better than I do.

"It's not enough by itself," I say. "You need steel up front, and glass. You need money before the money."

"So get money."

"From where, Lolo?"

"I don't know, hon. You're the unicorn." She slides the marker into her hair over one ear. "I'm a second shift lead. I make knees. You tell me how many knees."

The door from the floor bangs open and Benny comes in for coffee, peeling off one glove with his teeth. He stops in front of the whiteboard and reads it with his chin up, the way he reads a pick ticket.

"Four thousand rooms," he says. "Where are you putting them? The pad holds twelve, and one of them's her office."

"We ship faster," I say.

"Then the forklift goes faster." He takes a Marge's out of the box and holds it up at me like evidence. "Which means the forklift driver needs a raise."

"Told you," says Lolo.

I hold my phone up and photograph the whiteboard, and Benny leans into the frame with his donut, so I take it again.

"Nobody erases that," Lolo tells the room, which is Irene and Benny and a vending machine. "Anybody erases that board, they answer to me."

I stand there and look at the board, at Irene's numbers and Darnell's paint booth and Benny's forklift, at the crew already doing my arithmetic in the break room on their own, because they saw me drawing on graph paper and figured whatever I was drawing, they'd better be in on it.

Nobody decides alone.

Okay, Tato.

"I'm taking it to the board on the nineteenth," I say. "A plan. We build them here, every one of them."

Irene nods once, like that's settled, and goes back to the glazing line. Lolo pulls the marker out of her hair and points it at me.

"About time," she says. "Now go tell your husband."

Chapter 12 — Pip

At ten past eleven on Friday night somebody knocks on my glass with one knuckle, and I don't even have to look up.

"It's open," I say.

The door opens, the cold comes in, and then Adam does, in his long gray coat with the collar up and a Clyde Park Lanes ball cap on his head that I have never seen in my life.

I stare at the hat. He stands there and lets me.

"Lolo," he says, as if that covers it.

"Lolo gave you a hat?"

"Lolo texted me tonight. She said *your wife's in the yard*. Then she said *wear a hat, it's eleven degrees*. Then she met me at the gate with this." He takes it off and turns it over in his hands. SPARE PARTS, it says on the back, in iron-on letters, half gone. "She also asked me my average. I think I'm on the team now."

"You can't bowl."

"I bowled a one-forty at the Christmas party."

"In 2019, with bumpers."

"Nobody said bumpers were cheating."

"Everybody said bumpers were cheating, Adam. Gordon cried."

He laughs the real laugh, short, surprised out of him, the one I used to hear through the wall, nothing like the one he does for investors. He stands there inside the door on my mother's rug with the hat in his hand, laughing in my room, and something in my chest goes very still, the way a room goes still when the furnace shuts off and you realize how loud it was.

"Sit down," I say. "You're letting the heat out."

He considers the other chair, the one by the radiator, for a long second, with his hat still in his hand.

Then he sits down in it. He puts his feet up on the radiator, crossed at the ankle, in his good leather shoes with the salt lines on them, and leans back, and the chair makes the same small creak it's made since 2014, and the whole room settles a quarter of an inch, like it's been waiting for a weight.

Neither of us talks. Outside the glass the yard light makes a white circle on the snow, and the maples along Clyde Park stand up black against an orange sky. Grand Rapids at night is always orange, sodium lights and snow.

"It's warm in here," he says, and undoes the top button of his coat but leaves it on.

"I put in a better heater."

"When?"

"Tuesday, with Darnell, before his wife started having false alarms."

The heater kicks on under the desk with a thunk, and my desk lamp dims to brown and comes back. Adam tips his head at the lamp.

"Your heater's fighting your lamp," he says.

"The heater's winning. Everything in here's on one circuit. Darnell says it's fine."

"Darnell's at the hospital."

"Darnell says it's fine from the hospital," I say. "There's coffee, if you want it. It's from the break room and it's been on the burner since four."

He wants it. I pour it into the Spare Parts mug Lolo left on my shelf, and he holds it in both hands and drinks, and winces all the way down to his good shoes.

"This is terrible."

"Second shift likes it that way. It keeps them up."

"Lolo wants me Monday night." He turns the hat around on his knee so the iron-on letters face me. "Darnell's wife is due any minute. I told her I'm busy Monday, and she said that's what they all say."

"That is what they all say. She'll find somebody."

"She said if she has to she'll take the intern."

"You've been out here since Tuesday?"

"Most of the time. The plant's right there." I tip my head at the rolling door, which is down now, second shift gone home, the building dark except for the exit signs. "I can see the knee line from my desk. I like it."

"You can see the knee line from the mezzanine."

"The mezzanine smells like primer."

“So does this room, Pip.”

“That’s my sweater,” I say, “and that’s me.”

He gives me a long look over the mug. He used to look at me like that across rooms when we were raising the A, at pitch dinners, me in the one black dress I owned and him working the table, and he’d catch my eye over somebody’s shoulder and hold it a second too long, so I’d know the deal was done before the investor did.

I look away first and pick up the graph paper. It’s been lying upside down on my desk since Wednesday.

“Lolo told you to tell me something,” he says.

“Lolo tells me a lot of things.”

“She said you had a plan, and she said if you didn’t show it to me she’d show me herself. She said she’d draw it on my car.”

“She would, too, she’s got a whole box of markers.”

“So show me, then.” He sets the mug on the radiator and holds his hand out.

I don’t, for a second. I sit there holding the paper against my chest.

Then I turn it over and hand it across the desk.

He takes his feet down off the radiator and leans forward and puts the paper in the light from my desk lamp, and he reads it. Adam usually reads the way he walks into rooms, like the page is already a little late for him, but he reads this slow. He reads Irene’s numbers, which I copied onto the bottom in my own hand, and Darnell’s paint booth math, and my arrows, and the box that says *CP 2ND SHIFT + SAT*, and the box that says *STEEL / GLASS UP FRONT: \$?* with three question marks, and a fourth one I added on Wednesday after Ruth.

He turns it over to see if there’s anything on the back, and there isn’t.

“Four thousand a year,” he says.

“Four thousand one hundred, Irene says, and Irene’s never wrong about glass.”

“Who else has seen this?”

“Lolo and Irene, and Benny, and the vending machine in the break room, which hasn’t weighed in.”

He keeps his eyes on the paper. “So the crew saw it before I did.”

“The crew did half the math, Adam.”

For a second he doesn’t move. Then he nods at the paper, once. “Okay,” he says to it. “That’s fair. What does Simone say?”

“Simone hasn’t seen it.”

“Simone’s going to want a model.”

“Simone can have a model when there’s money for one,” I say. “Keep reading.”

He reads, and stops at the margin. “You put Benny’s raise in the plan.”

“Benny put Benny’s raise in the plan. That’s his handwriting, not mine.”

He reads on, slower. “And the deposits release at steel-cut.”

“That’s rule two, on the door since 2014.”

“So as you build, the escrow pays you.” He’s talking to himself now. I can see the deck building behind his eyes, the slides lining up. “Ten percent at cut, the balance at delivery. You’re cash-flow positive per unit from the day the knee’s welded. It’s—Pip, it’s clean, it’s very clean.”

“It isn’t clean,” I say. “Look at the box.”

“I see the box. Three of the question marks are pencil and one’s pen.”

“The pen one’s from Wednesday. Money before the money.” I put my finger on it. “Steel and glass, six weeks of it, before the first escrow comes loose. Overtime. And the second shift’s a hiring problem. I need thirty people who can weld the knee, and there aren’t thirty people in Michigan who can weld the knee, so I’d have to train them, and that’s months.”

“So you stagger it.”

“So I stagger it, and I need money for the stagger.”

“If I were pitching this,” he says, “I’d lead with the three thousand orders.”

“You’re not pitching it.”

“If I were. You lead with the demand, and then you show them the plant can meet it.”

“Lead with the knee,” I say. “The knee is why there’s demand.”

“Nobody buys a knee, Pip.”

“Three thousand people just did. They just don’t know what it’s called.”

He stays on the box with the question marks. His thumb goes to the edge of the paper and rubs it, back and forth, the way he did with the coffee lid that morning on four.

“How much?” he says.

“I don’t know yet. Six million, maybe eight, depending on steel.”

His face does the thing, the door, and I watch it close. Something goes across his eyes that’s heavier than the arithmetic, and he puts it away somewhere I can’t follow, and I think, *ask him*. Ruth said ask him. I could ask him right now. *Are we in trouble*. Four words. I’ve welded harder things than four words.

“You’d sell me my own room,” he says instead.

It takes me a second, and then I laugh. I don’t mean to. It starts somewhere under my ribs, a long way down, a bark like his at the airport, and I put my hand over my mouth. I said that. I said it about him, to Kurt, standing right where he’s sitting: *He’d sell you your own chair*. He heard it, of course he heard it, and he’s been carrying it around all week, turning it over, and now he’s handed it back to me in a room on a Friday near midnight with a bowling hat on his knee.

“That’s mine,” I say through my hand. “That’s my line.”

“It’s a good line. I improved it.”

“You didn’t improve it, you *stole* it.”

“I liberated it,” he says, and that does it, I’m gone, I’m laughing so hard I have to put my head down on the desk on top of the graph paper, and he’s laughing too, the real one, the dog-out-of-a-car one, and the radiator ticks, and the room holds both of us, ten feet by twelve, like it was built to.

When I lift my head he’s closer. He’s leaned forward with his elbows on his knees, the chair tipped up on its front legs, and his face is about a foot from mine across the corner of the desk. His eyes are red at the edges. Mine probably are too. We’re both too old to laugh like that at midnight without paying for it.

He's looking at my cheekbone, and I know what's there, because I've been drawing all day.

"You've got graphite on your face," he says.

"Leave it."

"I know," he says, very low. "It's structural."

He doesn't reach for it. His hand is right there on his knee, a foot from my face, and it doesn't move, and I don't move, and the room is so quiet I can hear the yard light humming outside in the cold.

His phone buzzes in the breast pocket of his coat, against his chest. It buzzes once and then again, and he doesn't move. On the third one he takes it out, slow, and the screen lights up his face from underneath, blue, and lights my desk and the graph paper, and I can read it upside down because I've been reading things upside down across desks my whole life.

SIMONE.

It's a minute past midnight. She's early tonight.

I watch him look at it while it buzzes a fourth time in his hand.

Then he presses the side button, and the screen goes black, and he puts the phone face down on my desk, on top of my graph paper, on top of the box with the four question marks.

He doesn't say *strike that* or *it's work* or *sorry*. He just takes his hand away from it, like it's something hot he put down on a counter.

The moment's gone anyway, the foot of air between us closed up like water, and we both know it. He sits back, and the chair comes down on all four legs with its little creak. I sit back too and look at his phone lying dark on my plan.

"You should go home," I say.

"Pip—"

"It's late. You've got Nashville Monday."

"How do you know I've got Nashville Monday?"

"I opened the Monday deck," I say.

He holds my eyes for a second. Then he nods, slowly, and picks up the phone, and puts it back in his breast pocket without turning it over, and stands

up and puts on the bowling hat, which looks ridiculous on him, so ridiculous I have to look at the floor.

“Wear it in Nashville,” I say to the floor.

“Odell will think I’ve been demoted.”

“Tell him it’s a promotion. Lolo doesn’t give out hats to just anybody.”

At the door he stops.

“It’s a good plan,” he says. “The money before the money. I’ll think about it.”

“Don’t think about it alone.”

He holds still for half a second, one hand on the brass pull my father turned. Then he goes out into the cold.

The chair by the radiator is still warm. I don’t sit in it.

Chapter 13 — Adam

The Nashville plant is the cleanest building I've ever paid for.

It sits on forty acres off Interstate 24 in La Vergne, Tennessee, between a mattress distribution center and a company that makes the plastic clamshells strawberries come in. White steel walls, a polished concrete floor you could do surgery on, skylights the length of a football field, so the light comes down on the line soft and even, like a museum. When we cut the ribbon fourteen months ago I stood up on a scissor lift in a hard hat with a pair of giant scissors and told three hundred people from Rutherford County that this was what the future of work looked like. The local paper ran a photo of me on the lift with my arms out. My mother had it framed, and it hangs in her condo in Sarasota, over the TV.

On Monday morning the line is running at forty percent.

"We've got three Lites on the floor," says Odell Haynes, walking me down the center aisle with his hands behind his back. "Two more in finishing. That's the week. That was last week too."

Odell's my plant manager. Halfway down the aisle he bends, without breaking stride, to pick a zip tie off the floor, and tells a kid at station four that his mother called the front office and it isn't an emergency, she just wants her casserole dish back. He hired every one of the sixty people working here and knows their kids' names and which ones are trying to quit smoking. He drives in from Murfreesboro every morning in a Twodesk polo tucked into creased khakis, which is more than I do.

"What happened to the order book?" I ask.

Odell stops walking and turns around, and gives me a kind of mild pity.

"You happened to it, boss," he says. "Or your wife did. That video."

"I saw the video, Odell."

"Everybody saw the video. My mama saw the video. My mama called me and said, *Odell, does your plant make the ones with no post?* And I said, no, Mama, we make the ones with the post, and she said, *well, what for?*" He shrugs, slowly. "Since the video, Lite orders are down eighty-one percent. People want the room that can leave. They don't want ours."

Down the line there are sixty people, give or take, in gray T-shirts with the company logo, at stations with good lighting and ergonomic mats and torque wrenches that talk to an iPad. I designed this line with a consultant from Detroit who'd done three car plants. It's beautiful, and it can build twenty-two Lites a day.

It can't weld the knee. We never set it up to. The knee takes eleven hours and four of Pip's people, and the whole point of Nashville was not to need Pip's people. That was my pitch to the board, in the glass conference room: volume, a second plant that doesn't depend on four welders in Wyoming, Michigan, who are the best in the country and can't be cloned, a posted corner, a lower price, a bigger market. The future.

Pip didn't come to that meeting. I didn't ask her to. I told everyone at the all-hands the next morning, from the stage, with a slide.

"Show me Kiana," I say.

Kiana's on wall framing, station six: twenty-four, from Smyrna, a single mother with a five-year-old named Jaylen who wants to be a tornado when he grows up. When I hired Odell she was working the drive-through at a Wendy's off Old Nashville Highway. Now she reads blueprints, which she learned on Tuesday nights in the training room at the back from a guy Odell brought in from the community college.

She sees me coming and lifts her nail gun in a little salute. "Morning, Mr. Kerrigan."

"Kiana, how's Jaylen?"

"Still wants to be a tornado." She grins. "Now he wants to be the tornado that picks up a little room and carries it away. He watched that video forty times."

"So did my whole building."

"Is it true she just stole it? Out the window?"

"She didn't steal it. It was hers."

Kiana nods slowly, like that's the most interesting thing anybody's said to her all week. "Good for her," she says. Then she remembers who she's talking to. "I mean—"

“No,” I tell her. “Good for her.”

She wipes her hand on her jeans and takes her phone out of her back pocket and shows me a framing drawing, zoomed in, a wall section with her pencil marks all over it. “I read that one myself last Tuesday,” she says. “Whole wall. Odell didn’t help.”

“That’s a Lite wall.”

“I know what it is.” She puts the phone away. “Someday I’m reading the other one.”

I walk the rest of the line with Odell. I shake every hand and ask about every kid. I know about half the names without help, and Odell murmurs the other half to me as we walk, the way a good chief of staff does at a funeral. Everybody’s polite and everybody’s glad to see me, and everybody keeps glancing at the order board on the wall by the break room, a big screen with the week’s builds, and the week’s builds are three.

“I tried turning that board off last week,” Odell says, low, as we pass it. “Kiana’s crew turned it back on. They said they’d rather know.”

In his office, a glass box over the floor with a view of the whole line, he closes the door and sits down and doesn’t offer me coffee.

“I’m going to say something,” he says. “You’re not going to like it.”

“Go ahead, Odell.”

“You need to decide about this place.”

“I’ve decided. It stays.”

“It’s costing you four hundred grand a week and building three rooms.” He says it gently. “I’ve been in plants that ran like this. A truck plant in eighty-nine. A parts plant in oh-eight. You know what happens? Nothing. Nothing happens for months. And then everything happens on a Friday, and the people find out from the parking lot.”

“That’s not going to happen here.”

“Then tell me what’s going to happen here.”

I sit there in his good chair, in his good glass box over my beautiful empty line, and I don’t know. That’s three times now. I’m going to have to start keeping count.

“You want to know what they ask me at the time clock?” Odell says. “They ask me if the lady with the crane is coming for us next.”

“What do you tell them?”

“I tell them I don’t know.” He spreads his hands flat on the desk. “I’m a plant manager. I’m allowed to say it. You’re the one who isn’t.”

I don’t argue with him. Arguing with Odell is like arguing with the scoreboard in the fourth quarter, when you’re down twenty.

My phone buzzes. It’s Gordon. I put it on speaker because Odell’s earned it.

“Nine weeks,” Gordon says, without hello. “It was eleven, now it’s nine. The Lite inventory’s not moving and Nashville payroll hit Friday and the steel deposit for Q1 cleared. Nine weeks, Adam.”

“I heard you the first time, Gordon.”

“Northgate called again. They want the minutes from tomorrow’s board, all of them, the day they’re signed. They used the phrase *material adverse*.” Gordon breathes. He sounds like he’s in a stairwell. “I’m putting the cash on the agenda for the nineteenth. I have to, and Ruth agrees with me.”

“Make it one line,” I say. “*Cash position, discussion*. I’ll walk them through it myself.”

“One line is how we got here, Adam.” He’s almost whispering. “I’m sorry, it’s my job. I can’t put Halvard on the agenda without putting the reason for Halvard on the agenda. My father was an accountant for the Christian Reformed Church for thirty years, I won’t—” He stops himself. “It’s going on the agenda.”

He hangs up. Odell waits with his hands folded on the desk.

“Who’s Northgate?” he asks.

I tell him. I couldn’t tell you why. Maybe because he’s sixty people’s plant manager in a glass box in Tennessee and they’re going to find out from a parking lot otherwise, and I’ve just heard him say that’s the worst way. I tell him about October, and the payroll, and nine million dollars borrowed in my own name with my shares on the line, and the covenant in March. I don’t pitch

it. It arrives in the wrong order, with the important part in the middle, the way true things do.

Odell listens to the whole thing. When I'm done he sits back and lets his chair creak, and looks out at the line.

"Does your wife know?" he says.

"No."

"Why not?"

I don't know is the honest answer, and it isn't the answer. The answer is that she told me Nashville was wrong. Not to my face; she never got the chance. She told Gordon, and Gordon told me, and I stood on a stage the next morning anyway. If I tell her about Northgate, I'm telling her she was right, and that every dollar of it went into the hole I dug while she was saying so. I'd rather owe Chicago nine million dollars than owe her that sentence.

"Because I'm an idiot, Odell," I say.

"Uh-huh." He swivels back to me. "Well. My wife's been married to an idiot for thirty-one years. I'll tell you what I learned. She doesn't mind the idiot so much. She minds finding out from the parking lot."

"What would you tell her?"

"Me? I'd tell her before the board does." He gets up and opens the door for me. "And then I'd tell my people, because they're next. What do I say at the time clock tomorrow, boss?"

"Tell them I was here."

"They know you were here. They shook your hand." He holds the door. "I'll tell them you're thinking. That one's free."

I fly home on the late flight out of BNA, a regional jet with two seats on one side and one on the other, and I take the one. The guy across the aisle is watching the video on his phone, the room coming out of the building, the streetlight going through the corner. He watches it twice and then shows it to the woman next to him, and she watches it, and says *oh, that's lovely*, and he says *she just took it, I guess, the wife*, and the woman says *good for her*.

He catches me looking. "You seen this?"

"Once or twice."

“My wife wants one. The no-post one. I told her that’s thirty-eight grand for a shed.”

“It isn’t a shed,” I say, before I can stop myself.

He gives me a long look over the phone. “Buddy,” he says, “you sound just like her.”

Everybody keeps saying *good for her*.

Over Kentucky I take out a legal pad, because I can’t do this on a screen, and I write down what’s still true. It doesn’t fill a page. There are nine weeks of cash, and a Northgate covenant in March that will come sooner now. There’s Halvard at one point one billion, which needs Pip, and Pip’s no. There’s Pip’s plan, four thousand one hundred rooms a year, which needs six to eight million up front that I can’t touch, because everything I own is thirty-four percent of a company and Northgate is holding it. At the bottom I write what Nashville costs a week, four hundred and twenty thousand, and I stare at that line until the flight attendant asks me twice if I want pretzels.

Under it I write *Tell her*.

I underline it twice. Then I sit there over Kentucky with the pen in my hand and do the thing I always do, which is plan the conversation. I plan where we’ll be and what I’ll say first. I plan the slide in my head, God help me, I can see the slide, it has a title.

Then I put the pen down and look out the window at the dark. In my head I cross out the slide, and the kitchen at midnight, and the yard with a bowling hat on my knee.

Seven o’clock tomorrow, in the room, before the board, with a coffee for each of us. I’ll get there at five to, like I used to. I’ll sit in the radiator chair, and when she comes in I’ll tell her all of it before she takes her coat off, in the wrong order, the true way.

Past midnight, back in the room across the hall from her, I’m still awake when my phone lights up on the nightstand with a text.

You haven’t called in three nights. Are you all right? — Simone.

I hold the phone over my face in the dark, the screen dimming and coming back when I touch it.

Fine, I type. Sleeping.

It's the first lie I've told Simone since May. I tell it in the dark with my eyes open, and set an alarm for five-thirty.

Chapter 14 — Pip

Clyde Park Lanes has twenty-four lanes, a bar called the Gutter that serves Stroh's in a can, and carpet so old the pattern has worn down to a theory. On Monday nights it belongs to the West Michigan Industrial League: tool-and-die shops, a commercial bakery, a team of ER nurses from Blodgett who call themselves the Bedpans and are terrifying, and on lane seventeen, the Spare Parts.

Lolo's been captain since 2003. Right now it's Lolo, Irene, Benny, Darnell when his wife lets him, and me when I can't think of a reason not to. Tonight Darnell can't come because his wife had the baby at four in the afternoon, so we've got a fifth.

"You're up, European," Lolo says.

Tavi stands at the top of the approach in a pair of rented shoes, red and blue, holding a ten-pound ball the color of a grape Popsicle with both hands against his chest, like it's a baby someone's handed him at a christening.

"I've never done this before," he says.

"We know, hon," says Lolo. "We can tell from here."

"Like you're mad at it," says Benny, from the scorer's table, where he has a can of Stroh's and a basket of fries. "Like it owes you money."

Tavi walks up to the line, very serious, and lets go of the ball at the top of the swing, so that it goes up instead of forward and comes down with a sound like a dropped dresser, and rolls, with great deliberation, into the left gutter.

The Bedpans on lane sixteen applaud.

"That's okay," says Irene, who almost never says anything at bowling. She bowls like she glazes, every throw the same, a one-sixty-five average for nine years. "That was good form."

"It went in the gutter."

"The form was good. The ball made a decision."

Tavi sits down next to me on the molded plastic bench, pink to the ears. He hasn't touched his phone since we got here, and Tavi checks his phone the way other people blink.

“Lolo says she asked Adam first,” he says, retying a rented lace that doesn’t need it. “She says the CEO turned her down, so tonight I’m the CEO.”

“You’re the intern,” Lolo says without looking up. “Bowl like one.”

“Three thousand eight hundred and two,” he says to me, low. “I checked in the bathroom.” He gives me a sideways look. “Are you nervous about tomorrow?”

“I’m never nervous.”

“You’re holding your shoe.”

I look down, and I’m holding my bowling shoe in my lap in both hands, like he held the ball. I put it on.

“I’m presenting a plan to the board,” I say. “That’s all it is.”

“Does Adam know about the plan?”

Lolo, who’s been writing *Tavi: 0* on the score sheet with the satisfaction of a woman carving a headstone, looks up.

“Answer the kid,” she says.

“Adam’s seen the plan.”

“Seen it or been asked about it?”

“He saw it Friday, in the room. He said it was clean.”

“Did you tell him you were taking it to the board?”

I don’t answer. I tie my shoe in a double knot, the way my father taught me before we went out on the floor at Lindqvist, because a loose lace by a press brake will take your foot.

“Hon,” Lolo says, and waits.

“I’ll tell him at the meeting.”

“That’s not telling him. That’s an ambush with a PowerPoint.”

“I don’t have a PowerPoint. I have a whiteboard photo.”

“It’s an ambush with a whiteboard photo,” Lolo says, and hands Irene the ball, and Irene goes up and throws her seven and a two, same as always, and Lolo points at me with her pencil. “You’re up. Throw it like you’re mad at it.”

I’m mad at it, so I throw a strike. Lolo marks it on the sheet with an X so hard the pencil goes through. None of it helps.

When I come back Benny holds his can up at me. "Tomorrow," he says. "You gonna say my raise out loud in front of the suits?"

"It's on the paper, Benny."

"In my handwriting." He looks pleased about that, and then he doesn't. "What if they say no to the paper?"

"Then it's Halvard, probably."

He eats a fry and looks down the lane. "I'm fifty-eight," he says. "You know where a fifty-eight-year-old forklift driver goes when the plant closes? Meijer, nights, stocking cat food." He tips the can at me. "When you say no in there tomorrow, there's a lot of people standing behind it who didn't get to say it."

"Then come say it yourself," I say. "Tomorrow. Sit in the back."

Benny laughs so hard he has to put the can down. "In the boardroom? Pip, they'd give me a sticker with my name on it. I'm on the forklift at six tomorrow, same as always. You go. Take my handwriting."

We bowl three games. Benny bowls a two-ten and tells us about the two-eighty. In the second game Irene gets up without a word and stands behind Tavi at the line and moves his elbow about the width of a pencil.

"Don't think," she tells him. "Glass doesn't like thinking."

On his next ball he gets the ten pin, alone, wobbling, and when it falls over he turns around with both arms in the air, and the Bedpans on sixteen give him a standing ovation.

Between the second and third game, Benny goes to the Gutter for another round, Irene goes out to the lobby to call her sister in Bay City, and Tavi goes to the bathroom to check his phone again, and it's just Lolo and me on the plastic bench at lane seventeen.

"Darnell's baby's a girl," Lolo says. "Seven pounds four. They named her Nevaeh, which is heaven backwards." She takes a long drink of her Stroh's and points the can at me. "Your face, though. Your face is like your mother when the band plays the wrong polka."

"My face is fine."

She sets the can down on the scorer's table, takes her glasses off and lets them drop on their chain. "Can I ask you something?"

"You're going to anyway."

"This plan of yours. Saturdays, second shift, everybody learning the knee. How long you figure it runs?"

"Twelve weeks to get ahead of the orders. A year to be safe."

"A year." Lolo nods slowly, like she's measuring a board she already knows is short. "I'm sixty-three, hon. My hands go numb at night. I wake up at three and I can't feel my thumbs, and I lie there and wait for them to come back like a dog that got out." She turns the pencil over on the score sheet. "I got a sister in Port Charlotte with a spare room and a ceiling fan. I've been thinking about Florida since your dad's retirement party. Before your video. Before your husband and his slide."

"You never said."

"Nobody asks the second-shift lead what she thinks about at three in the morning. They ask her how many knees." She says it without any heat at all, which is worse. "I'm not saying no to your plan. I'm saying don't build it on me like I'm part of the building. I'm not the building. I'm a lady with a sister and a bad pair of hands."

There's a sound in my ears like the moment between a pin wobbling and falling over.

I've had a whiteboard full of Lolo's numbers for a week. Four thousand one hundred knees a year, two shifts and Saturdays, and every one of those numbers has her standing in the middle of it, training kids, running second shift, holding the whole line together, as she has since 1994. I never asked her if she wanted to be standing there. I put her on the board like a machine I owned.

Benny comes back from the Gutter with four cans of Stroh's pressed together in his hands and a fresh basket of fries balanced on top, and squints at the two of us.

"What'd I miss?" he says.

“Nothing,” says Lolo, and licks the pencil and gives Tavi his ten pin on the score sheet, a game late. “Pip’s up.”

I pick up my ball, a fourteen-pound black one my brothers bought me for my thirtieth birthday as a joke. I walk to the line and stand there with the ball against my chest the way Tavi held his, and I look down the lane at the ten white pins under the lights, and my hands are shaking.

My hands don’t shake. I’ve welded upside down in a crawlspace in Holland in August. My hands don’t shake.

I throw it, and it goes straight into the right gutter.

Behind me, very quietly, Tavi says, “Good form.”

Chapter 15 — Pip

There's a thermos on my desk.

It's seven twenty-six on Tuesday morning, and I've just come across the yard from the truck with my coat open and my hair still wet because I slept through two alarms after bowling, and I open the door of my room and stop on my mother's rug. It's a tall green steel thermos with a dent in the bottom, the one that lives in the cupboard over our refrigerator at home behind the cake pans nobody uses. Next to it there's a paper cup from the espresso machine, the little brass eagle stamped on the sleeve, with a plastic lid. The chair by the radiator is pushed back from the desk at an angle, like somebody got up out of it fast.

I put my hand on the paper cup, and it's cold. The rim of the lid is bitten flat in one spot, which is what he does to lids on planes when the landing is bad.

When I unscrew the thermos, steam comes up out of it, and the smell. It's moka-pot coffee, my coffee, the tire fire. Somebody made it at home in my dented pot on my side of the counter and brought it here in a thermos from behind the cake pans and sat in that chair and waited.

I stand there holding the lid. Across the yard the plant's rolling door is up and first shift is going, and I can hear the press brake from here. *Chunk*.

Benny's on the forklift by the steel rack. I go out and wave him down. "Was Adam here?"

Benny idles the forklift and gives me a look of mild interest and lets the engine tick.

"Little before seven," he says. "Parked by the fence and walked in with a thermos and one of them fancy cups. Went in your room and sat."

"Did he say anything to you?"

"Said good morning. Said *is she in yet*. I said not yet, she was bowling." Benny shifts his cigarette from one ear to the other. "He asked how you bowled. I said one strike and one gutter, back to back, and he said that sounded about right. Then he stood inside your door with his coat on and read that writing on the back of it, the whole thing, like it was the specials."

“Did he order anything?”

“He brought his own, Pip.” Benny says it slowly, for my benefit. “Then he sat there till twenty-five after. His phone rang, and he talked on it for a minute, and he left in a hurry. Didn’t drink his coffee.”

“Who called him?”

“I’m a forklift driver, Pip, not the CIA.” He puts it in gear. “Looked like bad news, though. He did that thing with his face.”

He backs away, beeping, and swings the forks around toward the steel rack.

I go back into the room and sit down at my desk. I pour the moka-pot coffee into the thermos lid and drink it, and it’s terrible, it’s perfect, it tastes exactly like every morning from 2018 to the morning after Nashville, and my eyes sting, and I tell myself it’s because I didn’t sleep.

Is she in yet.

Seven o’clock. He came at seven o’clock.

There’s nothing from him on my phone, no text, no missed call. There’s just Tavi, in capitals: *SIX THOUSAND*. And then, a second later: *a morning show in new york ran the video again, the site is on fire*.

I type *you came* to Adam, and delete it. I type *I was late*, and delete that too. I screw the lid back on the thermos, tight, so it’ll stay hot for nobody. Then I take the *UNIT 001* file out of my desk drawer, where it’s been since the morning I brought it down from the mezzanine, and drive downtown with the file on the passenger seat and the thermos in the cup holder, where it rolls against the gearshift at every light.

The boardroom is on six at the Lindqvist, the old executive floor of the furniture company, where men in vests used to sit around a table made from a single slab of Michigan black walnut and decide what everybody in Grand Rapids would sit on for the next fifty years. We kept the table, and the portraits on the paneled walls, old Lindqvists in oil, one after another, getting balder down the line. The windows look west over the river and the bridges and the glass towers that went up downtown in the last ten years, where everybody’s hoping to sell something to somebody.

I'm the last one in. I'm always the last one in.

They're all at the walnut table. Ruth at the head, in a black blazer instead of the vest, which is how you know she means it. Next to her Nadia Farouk, her partner from Lakeshore, who never says anything in meetings and writes everything down on an iPad with a stylus like a court reporter. Del Ortiz across from Nadia, seventy, our independent director, who ran the Chevy stamping plant in Wyoming for twenty years before GM closed it and still wears his small gold UAW pin on his lapel to every board meeting, so you know where he's from. Gordon at the far end with his laptop open and his cardigan on and his face the color of a radiator. Diane Holm, our general counsel, and Simone at a side table, Diane with a legal pad and Simone with her black notebook and her pens in their row.

And there's Adam, halfway down on the window side, in the blue travel suit, with his back to the river and a cup of espresso in front of him that I can tell from here he hasn't touched.

He lifts his head when I come in. Our eyes meet, and he doesn't look away.

There's an empty chair across the table from him, my chair, and I sit in it, and for a second it's just the two of us across a slab of black walnut with the whole board around us, and I think about the thermos rolling in my cup holder, and the words *I was late* are right there in my mouth, and I don't say them, because Ruth is saying "Good morning, everyone, let's begin," in her public radio voice, and the meeting has started, and once the meeting has started you can't say anything that matters, that's what meetings are for.

Item one is the minutes, and they pass.

Item two is the quarter. Gordon goes through it in a monotone, his eyes on the laptop, the way people read names at a memorial: revenue up, margin down, Nashville down, Clyde Park up. Customer deposits, he says, have increased by a significant amount in the last two weeks, and he turns to the side table, and Simone says:

"Six thousand and forty-one, as of nine this morning. All of them for the original Corner." She says it without looking at me. "None for the Lite."

Del Ortiz lets out a long low whistle through his teeth.

Item three is Halvard.

Ruth touches her tablet, and the big screen at the end of the room lights up, and there he is, Kurt Lindahl, on a video call from what looks like a glass box in Minneapolis, in a turtleneck, smiling, with the Halvard logo on the wall behind him in brushed steel.

“Good morning, Grand Rapids,” he says. “Thank you for having me for this item. I’ll be brief, and I’ll say up front that we’re thrilled, we’re very energized. I know the founders are still aligning, and I want to say I respect that process enormously.” He smiles at me through the screen. “Pip, it’s wonderful to see you.”

“Kurt,” I say, and leave it there.

“Our diligence team has a handful of open items. Most of them are for Diane, they’re boring, I’ll spare you. But there’s one I wanted to ask in the room, because our IP counsel asked me to and because, honestly, I’m curious.” He glances down at something. “It’s for the patent schedule. The frame on the corner, the moment frame, what your people call the knee. Who’s the inventor of record?”

Ruth turns to Adam, and so does everybody else. That’s what happens in this company when somebody asks who: they turn to Adam. He’s the voice. He’s the one in the photo on the scissor lift with his arms out.

Adam opens his mouth.

I put the file on the walnut before anything comes out of it. It’s a plain manila hanging file with the hook still on, *UNIT 001* on the tab in my old handwriting, and it makes a small flat sound on the wood that everybody hears. I open it and turn it around so the camera on the end of the table can see.

“A receipt from the steel yard on Market Avenue,” I say, “for the frame stock for the first knee, made out to P. Sobczak. A receipt from Grand Rapids Glass for two lights with a polished edge, P. Sobczak. The counterman wrote *good luck w/ the corner* on it, you can read that yourself. A photo of the first room on sawhorses in my father’s garage, and that’s my father. And a lease. This company has rented that corner from me for a dollar a year since 2018.”

The room goes still. It was already quiet; this is something else, the way the shop floor goes still for half a second when somebody drops a sheet of glass and everybody waits to hear if it broke.

On the wall, the old Lindqvists look down out of their oil paint.

Kurt leans toward his camera. "Can you hold the first one up?"

Ruth picks up the steel receipt by its corner and holds it to the lens, and Kurt reads it off his screen in Minneapolis, slowly, the way you read a name on a cake. "P. Sobczak." He writes something down. "All right."

"You don't have all of it yet," I say.

Kurt looks up from his notes. Down the table, Nadia's stylus stops.

"The knee, the corner, the lift points," I say. "The crane bay in this building, which every engineer on the job told me was vanity. The escrow rule your lawyers keep asking about. The name, too. I named the company in a garage on Garfield Avenue while he was outside on the phone with a bank, because we had two desks and nothing else." I keep my hands flat on the walnut. "Put it in your schedule, Kurt. If you're going to try to buy it, you should know whose it is."

Ruth doesn't say anything. Del Ortiz sits back in his chair and folds his hands on his stomach, like a man at a ball game whose team just did something he paid to see.

"Noted," Kurt says, and smiles, and writes it down.

I sit there with my hands flat on the black walnut on either side of the file, and I can feel the grain under my palms. I've been waiting since the spring before last for somebody in this building to say it out loud in a room with a table in it. Nobody was going to. So it's my voice, and a steel receipt held up to a camera, and a man in a turtleneck in Minneapolis who wants to buy it writing it down, and it doesn't feel like anything I thought it would. It feels like paying a bill.

Adam's eyes are on me. I don't look over to see what's in them.

"Gordon," Ruth says, "before we go on, I think the board needs the full cash picture. Including the facility."

Gordon closes his eyes for a second. Then he opens them and turns the laptop around, toward the table, which is pointless, because nobody can read a laptop screen from eight feet away. It's a gesture, a man showing you his hands.

"We have nine weeks of cash," he says, "at current burn."

The table waits.

"The deposits," Gordon goes on, "are held in escrow under the terms of sale. They're released to the company when steel is cut for the customer's unit. We can't use them for operations or for working capital. To start building the six thousand units in the order book, we would need to buy steel, glass and insulated panel in advance, and fund additional labor, for approximately six to eight weeks before the first escrow releases. The estimated requirement," and he swallows, "is seven point four million dollars."

"Which the company doesn't have," says Ruth.

"Which the company does not have."

"And the facility, Gordon."

He turns down the table to Adam. Adam nods, once, very small.

"In October," Gordon says, reading it off the screen carefully, like he's afraid he'll get it wrong in front of God, "to make payroll, Mr. Kerrigan borrowed nine million dollars personally from Northgate Capital in Chicago and lent it to the company, against all thirty-four percent of his shares. If our cash falls below six million on the test date, Northgate can call it and take them."

There's a sound in the room. I think it's me.

I'm not looking at Gordon. I'm looking at Adam, across the walnut, with the river behind him and the morning light coming in over his shoulders so his face is half in shadow. He doesn't look away. Whatever's on my face right now, he sits there and takes it, with his hands folded on the table in front of him and his espresso going cold.

October. In October we were in the kitchen. In October I made eggs and ate them over the sink. In October he came home in the middle of the night and went up the good stairs to the room across the hall, and he'd just borrowed

nine million dollars with his whole life on the line, and he didn't knock on my door.

He called somebody, though. I know who he called. She's sitting at the side table with a black notebook, not looking at me, writing nothing.

"So the board understands the picture," Ruth says. Her voice is very calm, the voice for the end of a long run. "Halvard will fund the build. Halvard will fund working capital from signing, buy out the Northgate facility at close, and assume the payroll. Every one of those six thousand people gets their room. Six thousand rooms with no post, Pip. Kurt has agreed in principle to build the original for the existing order book." She lets that sit. "After that, they'll do what they'll do."

"They'll close Clyde Park," I say. My voice comes out of me low and level, and I don't know where it's coming from. "And put a post in it."

"In thirty-six months, in writing. I asked." Ruth folds her hands on the walnut. "Without Halvard, the company doesn't have the money to build the orders your video created. Without your vote, there's no Halvard. Without either, in nine weeks we stop making payroll, and Northgate takes Adam's shares, and a fund in Chicago gets a third of this company and a vote on what happens to it." She finds me down the length of the table. "You understand that your veto doesn't protect the plant anymore. It's starving it."

Six thousand orange dots on a gray map. *The one with no post. The one that can leave. I want the room she took.* Every one of them came in because I stood on Monroe Avenue in the dark with my hand on the glass. Every one of them is sitting in a bank in Cleveland, waiting for me to cut steel I can't pay for.

I made them, and I'm the reason they can't get built.

"Pip," Ruth says, not unkindly. "It's your call."

My phone is in my coat pocket with the whiteboard photo on it: Irene's numbers, four thousand one hundred a year, Darnell's paint booth, Benny's forklift, a box with four question marks, Benny's raise in Benny's handwriting. *Money before the money.* I was going to stand up and show it to them. I was going to show it to him first, at seven, in the room, and I was late.

"I want thirty days," I say.

"For what, Pip?"

"To find the money before the money."

"From where?"

"I don't know yet."

Ruth holds my eyes. Next to her, Nadia writes something on her iPad with her stylus, tiny, tidy.

"Harvard's exclusivity runs to the end of February," Ruth says slowly. "Kurt?"

"We can live with thirty days," says Kurt from the screen, smiling. "We're very patient people in Minnesota."

"Thirty days," says Ruth. "Del?"

"Thirty days," says Del Ortiz, and peers at me over his glasses, and taps his UAW pin once, absently, with one finger, like he's touching wood.

"Thirty days," says Adam, to me.

Ruth nods and makes a note. Then she turns a page on her tablet. "Item four," she says, "the motion to censure."

I'd forgotten. I'd honestly forgotten I was item four.

"Moved by me," Ruth says, "seconded by Nadia. Any discussion? No. All in favor."

Ruth raises her hand, and Nadia raises hers.

"Opposed."

Del Ortiz raises his hand.

Then Adam raises his.

I watch him do it. He does it slowly, without any face at all, his hand coming up off the walnut and stopping at about the height of his ear, as if he's asking a teacher a question he already knows the answer to. Ruth turns her head and stares at him. He doesn't look at Ruth. He looks at me.

"Two in favor, two opposed," says Ruth, after a moment, very evenly. "Pip, you're recused, so the motion fails." She turns to the screen. "Thank you, Kurt. We'll be in touch."

The screen goes dark.

I sit in my chair and look at the black walnut between my hands. Thirty days. Seven point four million dollars. A thermos rolling in the cup holder of my truck. *Is she in yet.*

“Thirty days,” I say again, to the table, to nobody, and stand up, and go.

Chapter 16 — Adam

Ruth catches me in the hall outside the boardroom before I can get to the stairs.

“A word,” she says, and steers me by the elbow into the little kitchenette on six where the old Lindqvists kept their sherry and we keep a Keurig nobody cleans. She shuts the door with her heel. She’s shorter than me by a foot and runs four miles a day, and she backs me up against the counter like a border collie with one sheep.

“What was that?” she says.

“What was what?” I say, though I know.

“You voted against the censure.”

“It failed, if that helps.”

“I know it failed, Adam, I was there, I counted two-two, and you were the two.” She doesn’t raise her voice; Ruth never raises her voice. She lowers it, which is worse, like a car downshifting before it passes you. “Kurt Lindahl watched the CEO of the company he’s buying vote with the founder who’s blocking the deal, on camera, and he wrote something down. Did you see him write something down?”

“I saw him write it down.”

“He writes things down when he’s recalculating.”

“Then let him recalculate, it’s good for his heart.”

“It’s my fund you’re joking about, Adam.” For a second something shows under the public-radio voice, something tired and older than fifty-eight. “Lakeshore has a hundred and forty million dollars in this company. I have pension money in this company, teachers, firefighters in Toledo. I have to go back to Ann Arbor and tell my partners that the CEO, who has borrowed nine million dollars against his own stock in a covenant that’s going to trip in March, just voted to protect his wife from a symbolic word in the minutes.”

She takes her phone out of her blazer pocket and turns the screen toward me. It’s a text from Kurt, sent while the rest of us were still pushing our chairs back from the walnut: *Is he going to be a problem?*

“He wants an answer by tonight,” Ruth says. “So do I. Which side are you on?”

I look past her at the Keurig, which has a sticky note on it in Gordon’s handwriting that says *PLEASE DESCALE ME*.

“I’m on hers,” I say.

Ruth stares at me, and then she nods slowly, as if she’s been told the price of something and is deciding whether to pay it.

“And what do I tell Kurt?”

“Tell him I’m a problem.”

“I’m going to tell him you’re tired.” She types it with one thumb, fast, and puts the phone back in her blazer. “And you’d better help her find seven point four million dollars in thirty days, because I can’t keep calling you tired.”

She opens the door. On her way out she jabs the Keurig’s brew button with one knuckle, and the machine groans like something in a cellar and produces nothing at all.

Pip isn’t in the stairwell, and she isn’t on four, and she isn’t at her truck in the lot behind the building where she always parks, because her truck isn’t in the lot. Simone, coming down the hall toward me from the glass room with her notebook pressed to her chest, opens her mouth to say something, and I put a hand up and she closes it, and I go down the stairs two at a time, the old iron stairs that smell like pigeons and radiator paint, all the way to the ramp.

I find her on level three of the Monroe Avenue ramp, standing next to my car.

It’s my black Audi she’s leaning on, the one with the Grand Valley sticker in the back window that she gave me as a joke when we got married, because I didn’t go to Grand Valley, I went to Western, and she said I needed to be loyal to something local. She’s got her arms crossed and her coat open and her face closed for business, and the ramp is cold and gray and smells like exhaust and somebody’s old french fries, and a woman getting out of a Subaru two spaces down takes one look at us and gets back into the Subaru.

“You moved your truck,” I say.

“It’s up on four. I parked it there and walked down.”

“How’d you know which car was mine?”

“I put a sticker on it eleven years ago so I’d always know.” She doesn’t uncross her arms. “I wanted to be where you’d have to walk up to me, instead of the other way around.”

So I walk up to her and stop about four feet away, which is the distance I’d stop from a horse I didn’t know.

“You pledged your shares,” she says.

“Yes.”

“All of them, in October?”

“October eighth, it was a Thursday,” I say, like I’m reading it off a receipt.

“I know what day of the week it was, Adam, I was in the house.” Her voice is so level I can hear what it’s costing her to keep it there. “I made eggs and ate them over the sink, and you came in at one, and I heard you in the kitchen for an hour, and then you went upstairs. You’d just put your whole life on a piece of paper in Chicago and you went *upstairs*.”

“I didn’t want you scared.”

“You didn’t want me in the room.”

“That’s not—“

“Then what?” She uncrosses her arms and puts her hands flat against the car door behind her, like she’s holding herself up, or holding the car down. “Tell me what, because I’ve been sitting at that walnut table for an hour doing the arithmetic and I keep getting the same answer. You decided we needed nine million dollars, and you decided where to get it, and you decided what to put up, and you decided not to tell me. That’s four decisions, and you made all four alone.”

“Not alone,” I say, and I hear it as I say it, and I’d give a great deal to have it back.

She goes very still against the car and says, “Who knew?”

“Gordon, because he had to, he’s the CFO.”

“Who else?”

I could lie; I’ve been lying since October in small ways I told myself were scheduling. I could say *nobody*, and she’d believe it for about a week.

“Simone,” I say.

Pip doesn’t move or make a sound, and nothing in her face changes, and that’s what’s terrible. I’ve seen Pip angry. I’ve seen her throw a framing square across a shop and stick it in a wall, and I’ve seen her cry exactly twice, but I’ve never seen her do nothing like this, nothing at all, as if somebody had turned her off at the wall.

“She had the numbers,” I say. “She does operations, Pip, she was there in August when Nashville started bleeding, she built the model, she—“

“Did she call you, or did you call her?”

“What?” I say, which buys me nothing.

“In October, on the eighth, a Thursday. You signed the papers at the kitchen counter, I’m guessing, because that’s where you sign things, at my end, because it’s got the better light, and then you called someone.” She tilts her head at me. “Did you call her at one in the morning?”

I don’t answer, and somewhere down on level two a car alarm starts and stops.

“That’s interesting,” Pip says, very quietly.

The woman in the Subaru starts her car and backs out very slowly, looking straight ahead, and drives down the ramp to level two with the care of a woman leaving a crime scene.

“I came at seven,” I say.

It comes out of me wrong, like an excuse, and I didn’t mean it as one. I meant it as the only true thing I’ve got in my pocket.

“I know, Benny told me,” Pip says. “The thermos was on my desk.”

“I was going to tell you all of it, Northgate, the covenant, everything, before the board. I was going to sit in the chair and tell you while you were still taking your coat off—“

“I was late,” she says.

We look at each other across four feet of cold concrete.

“I was late,” she says again. “I was bowling, and I slept through my alarm, and I drank your coffee at half past seven and it was still hot. You made it in my pot.”

“I made it in your pot.”

“It’s terrible coffee, Adam.”

“I know, I’ve always hated it.”

“You never said.”

“You never asked.”

That one lands on both of us. I watch it land on her, and I feel it land on me somewhere around the sternum, like walking into a beam in the dark.

“Why didn’t you knock?” she says. “In October, on the eighth, why didn’t you come up the stairs and knock on my door?”

There are a lot of answers. I’ve got them lined up the way I line up answers for investors, in order of persuasiveness: *you were asleep, it was late, you had the plant, I didn’t want to load it on you, it was my mistake to fix*. I could give her any of them and every one would close. Strike that. Every one would be a little bit true.

“Because you were right,” I say. “About Nashville. You told Gordon it would eat us, and it ate us, and every dollar I borrowed went into feeding it. If I’d knocked, I’d have had to stand in your doorway and say *you were right and I was wrong and it’s costing us the company*. I couldn’t. I’d rather borrow nine million dollars against everything I own than say that sentence to you.”

A car comes down the ramp behind me, slow, and its headlights slide across her boots and away before she answers.

“You’d rather owe a bank in Chicago,” she says finally, “than owe me an *told you so*.”

“Yes.”

“I wouldn’t have said it.”

“I know,” I say. “That’s what made it worse.”

She pushes herself off my car and walks past me, close, and stops, and for a second we’re standing shoulder to shoulder facing opposite directions, like two people in a duel who forgot to turn around.

“You voted no on the censure,” she says, not looking at me.

“I did.”

“Ruth’s going to make you pay for that.”

“She already sent the invoice.”

“What did it say?”

“It asked which side I’m on.” I wait, and she waits, both of us looking at different walls of the ramp. “I told her yours. Standing next to a Keurig that needs descaling, so it wasn’t much of a ceremony.”

In profile, the dimple in her left cheek shows for a second, the one she gets from her father.

“Thirty days,” she says, to the concrete in front of her.

“I know.”

“I’m going to find seven point four million dollars.”

“I know you are,” I say.

“I don’t know how yet.” She turns her head, and her eyes are wet and her face is perfectly calm, and the combination is the most frightening thing I’ve seen in my life. “I haven’t said that to you since Nashville. *I don’t know*. You should write it down somewhere.”

Then she walks up the ramp toward level four and her truck, and her boots go up the concrete, one step after another, and she doesn’t look back, and I stand there by my car until I can’t hear them anymore.

My phone buzzes in my pocket, and I take it out.

Are you all right? I saw you leave. I am in the glass room if you want to talk. — S.

I read it twice and look up at the ceiling of the ramp, at the pipes and the fluorescent tubes and a pigeon sitting on a sprinkler head, looking down at me with one orange eye like it’s waiting to see what I’ll do.

The phone goes back in my pocket with Simone unanswered.

Then I take it out again and scroll down to PIP, the photo of her in safety glasses on the roof of the Lindqvist building the night we hung the sign.

I type *I’m sorry* and delete it, because it’s a thing you say after. I type *I voted for you* and delete that too, because it reads like a yard sign.

I think about Odell in his glass box over the empty line in La Vergne. *She doesn’t mind the idiot so much. She minds finding out from the parking lot.* I’m standing in a parking ramp, which is almost funny.

So I'll stop being the parking lot. Whatever I know, she hears it from me first, before I act on it, every time, whatever it costs. Nobody asked me to; it's just the only repair I can think of that doesn't need her to do anything.

Then I type the only thing I can think of that's true and in the right order.

Northgate's number is 312-555-0148. The loan officer is Neil Pruitt. The papers are in the second drawer of my desk at home, left side, under the Nashville lease. The password to my laptop is your mother's maiden name and the year we got married. I won't do anything about any of it without you.

I send that one as it is.

It sits there on the screen, delivered and not read, and I watch it until the screen goes dark.

The pigeon lifts off the sprinkler head above me, beats twice, and goes out the open side of the ramp into the snow.

Chapter 17 — Pip

Simone Achterberg lives on the eleventh floor of a building on Ionia Avenue that used to be a cold-storage warehouse for a meatpacker. There's a plaque in the lobby about it. *Here, from 1911 to 1974, the Valley City Packing Company kept West Michigan supplied in ham.* Now there's a doorman named Felix and a lobby that smells like eucalyptus, and the elevator plays something with a harp in it.

She opens the door in reading glasses and a gray sweatshirt that says MSU ENGINEERING MOM, holding a glass of white wine. She looks me over the way she looked at the gauge on the test rig.

"Pip," she says, and doesn't move out of the doorway.

"Can I come in for a minute?"

"It is nine-forty at night."

"I know what time it is."

She thinks about it, then steps back and opens the door wider.

The condo is one big room with very high ceilings and old brick walls and huge factory windows looking south over the city, all the lights, the Lindqvist building's water tower lit up green for some reason, the arena, the long dark line of the river. It's a beautiful room with almost nothing in it: a couch, a table with two chairs, a bed behind a folding screen. And boxes, eleven of them, against the wall by the kitchen, banker's boxes and moving boxes and one big wardrobe box, all labeled in black marker in her small level printing: KITCHEN MISC., BOOKS (HANNAH'S?), WINTER, PHOTOS. One of them just says DO NOT.

"You haven't unpacked," I say.

"I told you that I had not."

"You said eleven, but I didn't think you meant it."

"I always mean the number." She goes into the kitchen, which is a long steel counter along the brick wall, and takes another wineglass down from a cabinet that has, as far as I can see, four glasses and two plates in it. "Will you have some wine?"

"Yes," I say, "a big one."

She pours it and hands it to me, and we stand there on either side of her steel counter, as Adam and I stand at either end of ours, and I think, *I've been standing across counters from people since the spring before last.*

"I'm not here to fight," I say.

"I didn't think you were, or you would have come in the daytime." She sips her wine and waits. "So why are you here?"

I take my phone out of my coat pocket and open the photo of the whiteboard in the break room at Clyde Park, Irene's square capitals with Darnell's little crane drawn underneath. I set it on the steel counter and slide it across to her.

"I need seven point four million dollars in thirty days," I say, "and I can't do arithmetic on money. I can do it on steel and I can do it on glass. I can tell you how many knees four welders can make in an eleven-hour shift with one of them hungover, but money I can't do, so I need somebody who can."

Simone looks at the phone without picking it up.

"Gordon can do money," she says.

"Gordon sweats when he does money, and I need somebody who does it calm."

"Why me?"

"Because you drove out to the plant to find out why there's no post in the corner. Nobody else did that, not Ruth, not Kurt, not him."

She doesn't answer right away. She turns her wineglass a quarter turn by the stem, and then another quarter, like somebody working a combination lock.

"You are asking me to help you stop the deal I was hired to close," she says.

"Yes," I say, "I am."

"I have a daughter at State. I have a lease on this apartment. I have eleven boxes I have not unpacked, because I did not know whether I would be staying." She looks at the boxes. "If Halvard buys the company, I am the integration lead. That is a good job. It is a very good job. If Halvard does not buy the company, then in nine weeks there may not be a company."

"I know there may not."

"So you would like me to bet against myself."

"I'm asking you to," I say. "That's all it is. If you say no, I'll finish your wine and go."

Something shifts in her face, the way it did in my room in the yard when I said *he's not the only person awake*: her mouth goes thin, and her eyes go to the boxes and come back.

"Nobody has asked me for anything since May," she says. "Do you know that? I have been at that company eight months. People bring me problems. People bring me decks. Your husband brings me numbers at one in the morning and tells me stories about a woman with a poodle in Holland. Nobody has asked me for anything that cost me something to give." She picks up her wine and puts it down without drinking. "I would have liked to be asked by him, but he would never ask me anything that mattered. I'm not his."

"No," I say, "you're not."

"I knew that, and I want you to know I knew it," she says to the counter. "I told him to tell you about Northgate. In October, on the phone, the night he signed, I said, *go upstairs and tell your wife*. I said it twice, and he said he would."

I put my glass down on the steel.

I came here braced for a lot of things, the navy sweater, the ficus, a woman who knew my husband's late-night voice better than I did. I didn't brace for the woman on the other end of that call telling him to hang up and go upstairs.

"Why are you telling me that?" I ask.

"Because you asked me something," Simone says, "so I am telling you something. That is how it works, I think, though it has been a while."

She picks up my phone and studies the whiteboard photo for a full minute. Then she pushes her reading glasses up her nose and goes to the box against the wall that says OFFICE.

"What's in DO NOT?" I say.

"My wedding album," Simone says, digging, "and a waffle iron that was a wedding present. I have not decided which one goes down the chute first."

She comes back with a legal pad and a calculator, an actual calculator with paper tape, and sets them on the counter and sits down on one of the two chairs.

“Sit,” she says, and I sit.

We work until a quarter to two.

She’s so fast. I’ve seen Adam work a room and Gordon work a spreadsheet, and I’ve never seen anybody work a problem the way Simone works it, quietly, in order, no wasted motion, like a surgeon with steady hands who’s done this exact operation a thousand times and is a little bored. She asks me questions and writes down my answers in her small printing and runs the calculator, and the paper tape curls off the end of it onto the counter and down toward the floor.

“Who is your steel mill?” she says.

“Great Lakes Specialty, in Monroe, Gil Chamberlain. I’ve bought from him since the garage, net thirty.”

“Can you get sixty days out of him?”

“I’ve never asked.”

“Then ask,” she says, and writes it down. “If he gives you sixty, you cut the steel before you pay for it, and when the steel is cut, the escrow releases. Your rule.” She runs the tape. “You pay Gil out of the money his own steel let loose.”

I stare at the curl of tape coming off the calculator.

“That is the money before the money,” Simone says, “or some of it. Now, who does your glass?”

“Grand Rapids Glass and Holland Glazing.”

“Same question for both of them.”

“I’ll ask them both tomorrow.”

“Tell each one the other is being asked, and make them compete.” She writes. “Labor. You need a second shift, which means thirty people who can weld the knee.”

“There aren’t thirty people in Michigan who can do that.”

“Then you will have to train them. How long does that take?”

“Six weeks to make a welder I’d let near a knee. Twelve to make one I’d trust.”

“Who trains them?”

“My four knee welders, and Lolo.”

“Lolo already runs your second shift,” Simone says, without looking up. “Does she want to spend her Saturdays teaching thirty strangers to weld?”

“I’ve never asked her that either.”

Simone writes something on the pad and doesn’t read it out to me. “Your four are already welding knees all day.” She taps her pen on the pad. “You need them to train and weld, which is overtime, which is Saturdays.” She runs the tape again and frowns at it. “After the steel and the glass terms, that is your hole, Pip. Two point eight million, not seven point four.”

I look at the two point eight on the tape. It’s still a number I don’t have, but it’s a number, and a number has an edge you can get a grinder on.

Some time after midnight the tape runs out. Simone goes to the box marked WINTER and comes back with a new roll.

“Why is the calculator paper in winter?” I say.

“Because I packed it in October,” she says, threading it, “and I knew I would be doing this kind of arithmetic by February.”

I laugh, and she looks up, pleased, like I’ve passed something.

“And there’s this,” she says a while later, and draws a box at the bottom of the pad, and writes in it in her small printing: *NASH*. Then she sits there with her pen still, looking at the box.

I know what’s in the box. Seven weeks of Nashville and the hole is gone.

“No,” I say.

Simone doesn’t argue or ask why. She looks over her reading glasses at me, and then she draws a single line through the box, neat, a quiet *not now*, and writes a small question mark next to it.

“It’s his,” I say. “It’s the only thing in the company that’s his. He’s got sixty people down there and he hired every one of them, and there’s a girl who learned to read prints. I won’t walk into the first thing he ever built without me and turn the lights off, not to save my plan.”

"I understand," Simone says.

"You think I'm wrong, though."

"I think it is four hundred and twenty thousand dollars a week." She puts the pen down. "And I think you are being kind to him in a way he has not been kind to you. That is not my business, so I will write it down as an open item."

She does, in the margin, in printing so small I'd need a loupe.

When I finally stand up and put my coat on, the tape is three feet long again and curled on the floor like a white tail. Simone tears it off, rolls it, snaps a rubber band around it and hands it to me.

"Give that to the board," she says.

"Thank you," I say, and tuck it in my coat.

"Don't thank me yet. You have twenty-nine days." She walks me to the door. "I am still the integration lead for Project North. I will still be on Kurt's calls. I will tell you what he says, and I will tell him nothing about this." She stops with her hand on the door. "I want it in writing that I asked you not to thank me."

"Simone," I say from the hallway.

"Yes."

"I don't care about the credit. Somebody's going to say this is about whose name is on the patent. Kurt can put his name on the patent and his face on the box. I don't care who they think invented it. I care that there's no post."

She gives me the look my mother gives a priest who's run long.

"I know, Pip, I read the protocol," she says. "*The eye goes to the corner.*"

Downstairs, Felix the doorman is asleep in his chair with his mouth open, and I let myself out into the cold. Ionia Avenue is empty, the snow coming down slow and big now, the soft kind, under the streetlights. My truck is parked on the street with an inch on the windshield and a parking ticket going soft under the wiper.

I stand on the sidewalk and look up at the eleventh floor, where one window is still lit, high up, in the long row of dark factory glass.

There's a text from Adam from this afternoon that I haven't opened. I've been carrying it around since the ramp like a stone in my coat pocket.

I take it out and open it: a phone number, a name, a drawer, left side, under the Nashville lease, and a password.

Your mother's maiden name and the year we got married.

I stand there in the snow on Ionia Avenue reading it over and over until the screen goes dark in my hand.

Chapter 18 — Pip

On Thursday morning, in the dark, I call my husband from the truck in the plant lot and ask him to come to Monroe with me.

I've had the phone in my hand for half an hour, and I've written the sentence four ways in my head, and every one of them sounds like a memo. In the end I just call, and he picks up on the first ring, wide awake, and I say, "I'm driving to Great Lakes Specialty at eight to ask Gil Chamberlain for net sixty on steel, and I want you to come, and I'm telling you before, not after."

There's a pause on the line, long enough for a semi to go by out on Clyde Park.

"Okay," he says, very carefully, like the word might break.

"Don't say okay like that."

"I'm not saying it like anything, I'm saying okay." Then, after another pause: "Can I drive, at least?"

"Absolutely not, it's my truck."

"You drive like a nun."

"I drive like somebody who plans to see seventy."

"I'll bring coffee," he says, and hangs up while I'm still telling him not to.

He's at the plant twenty minutes early with two paper cups, both from the gas station on Clyde Park Avenue, both terrible in an ordinary way. He gets in on the passenger side of my truck and hands me one and buckles his seat belt and looks straight ahead through the windshield, and we drive two hours across the bottom of Michigan in the snow without either of us saying much of anything, and it's the best two hours I've spent with him in years. I don't know what that says about us, and I don't think about it on I-94.

Great Lakes Specialty Steel is a long low building on the water in Monroe, between a power plant and a marina full of boats wrapped in white plastic for the winter like leftovers. Gil Chamberlain meets us in the lobby in a fleece vest and a hard hat with his name on it. He's sixty-one and has sold me every stick of steel in every room I've ever built, starting with the frame stock for Unit 001 in 2014, when I drove down here in my father's Buick with eleven

hundred dollars in cash in an envelope and he looked at me like I was a kid selling candy for a school.

“Pip,” he says, and hugs me, which he’s never done. “I saw the video, and my wife cried. She said, *Gil, that’s the girl with the envelope.*”

“That’s me, the envelope girl.”

“And you must be the husband.” He shakes Adam’s hand, wary. “I’ve heard a lot about you.”

“All of it bad?” says Adam.

“Mostly from the business pages.”

We sit in his office, which has a window onto the rolling mill where a long orange bar of steel goes by on rollers every few minutes, glowing, like a sunset being delivered. Gil offers coffee and we both decline, holding up our gas-station cups. Gil sits behind his desk with his hands folded on his stomach and says, “So what can I do for you,” in the voice of a man who already knows.

I open my mouth with it all ready. The tape from Simone’s calculator is in my coat pocket, rolled up with its rubber band, steel tonnage, weeks, escrow at cut, and I’m going to say it plainly, in order.

Adam puts a hand on my arm, lightly, just two fingers above the wrist.

“Can I?” he says.

He’s asking me, in front of Gil Chamberlain, in Monroe, with steel going by in the window.

“Go ahead,” I say, and sit back.

And he tells Gil the truth.

I keep waiting for the pitch. I know every pitch he’s got; I’ve sat through them at a hundred dinners. I wait for the nose voice, the voice for the poodle lady, and it doesn’t come. He sits forward in his chair with his elbows on his knees and tells Gil Chamberlain, a man he met four minutes ago, that the company is nine weeks from not making payroll. He tells him about Nashville, that it was his idea and his mistake. He tells him there’s a buyer from Minneapolis who’ll fix all of it and probably close the plant in three years, and that his wife has a plan to fix it without the buyer, and the plan

needs Gil to wait sixty days for his money instead of thirty, and if the plan fails, Gil might wait a lot longer than sixty days.

"I'm telling you that part," Adam says, "because you should know it before you decide."

He doesn't look at me when he says that, and he doesn't have to.

Gil sits there with his thumbs going around each other. Outside the window, another bar goes by, orange, glowing, and then another.

"Huh," Gil says finally, to the window.

"I know it's a lot," says Adam.

"Halvard's been buying tube from a mill in Indiana for ten years," Gil says. "Eight thousand rooms of knee frame is the biggest single order I'll write this year, and I'd rather it went through my rolling mill than theirs." He turns his chair to me. "And you paid cash in an envelope in 2014. I remember who pays."

"Huh," says Adam.

Gil unfolds his hands and picks up a pen. "Net sixty, for eighteen months. I want the first four hundred knees' worth of tube on one PO so I can schedule the rolling. And I want a photo of me standing in one of those rooms with no post. My wife'll put it on the fridge."

On the way out, in the lobby, Adam stops in front of a framed photograph on the wall of a man in a fedora standing next to a pile of steel in 1946, and stays there with his hands in his pockets.

"That was good in there," I say.

"Gil said yes because of eight thousand rooms of tube and an envelope from 2014," he says, without looking away from the photo. "I just sat next to the envelope."

"You didn't do the nose voice."

"I'm out of practice," he says, and doesn't smile, and doesn't move away from the man in the fedora for a while.

Holland Glazing calls my phone with net forty-five that afternoon, because they heard Great Lakes gave us sixty and they hate Great Lakes. Grand Rapids Glass matches it by the time we're past Jackson, because

they've been mad at Holland since a softball game in 2011 that nobody will tell me about. Simone texts me a little after that: *Glass matched. Your hole is now 2.3.* And under it, a second text, a minute later: *I am not asking how. I assume Holland still hates Great Lakes.*

I show it to Adam in the truck. He reads it and laughs out loud, and then stops laughing and looks out the window at the snow on I-94.

"She's very good," he says.

"She's the best person in that building."

"I know she is."

"You should have hired her for something besides listening to you after midnight."

He goes a mile without answering, then says "I know" again, quieter.

Back at Clyde Park it's almost six and second shift's been on for three hours. I drop Adam at his car by the fence. He stands there in the snow with his hands in his coat pockets, looking at the room on its cribbing in the yard, the light on inside, the glass corner glowing.

"I'll see you at home," he says.

"Okay."

"Don't say okay like that."

I almost laugh, and then I don't, and I go into the plant.

Lolo's waiting for me at the time clock with her arms crossed.

"Break room," she says, and doesn't wait to see if I follow.

There are four people in the break room: Lolo, Benny, Irene, and Darnell, back from three days off with the baby, holding a paper coffee cup, with the eyes of somebody who hasn't slept since Sunday. There's a sheet of printer paper on the table between them with the Halvard logo at the top.

"Darnell's wife's sister cleans the glass room on four," Lolo says, without being asked. "It was sitting on the table, and it's a draft."

I pick it up. *Project North — Workforce Retention Framework (DRAFT — NOT FOR DISTRIBUTION)*. A retention pool for Clyde Park employees who stay through the transition. Eighteen months of base pay, paid as a lump sum at the end of month eighteen, for anyone who's still there.

I do the arithmetic without meaning to, for Benny, and for Lolo, and for Irene.

“Is it real?” says Lolo.

“It’s a draft.”

“Is it real, hon?”

“Yes, I think Kurt would pay it,” I say.

Lolo nods slowly and takes her glasses off and lets them fall on their beaded chain, and I wait for the look, the one my father used to warn about, and it doesn’t come. She just looks tired.

“Then I want to tell you something straight,” she says. “You’re not going to like it.”

I pull out a chair and sit down across from her.

“You know about my sister in Port Charlotte, and the lanai. I’ve been working a line since I was nineteen years old, Lindqvist, then the cabinet place, then here, forty-four years. My knees are shot and you know about my hands.” She holds one up, and it’s steady, but the knuckles are swollen and gray. “Eighteen months of base. You know what that is to me? That’s Florida, that’s the lanai, that’s me getting out of here before my hands go all the way.”

I open my mouth and nothing comes out of it.

“And your plan,” Lolo says, very gently, “is Saturdays.”

“Lolo—”

“I know what it is, I did the math on the board for you, I’m not stupid. I know it’s a good plan and it keeps the plant open. I know Halvard’s going to close it in three years and put a post in your corner, and I know that’s a sin. But I’m telling you, because you’re your daddy’s girl and he’d want me to tell you straight.” She folds her arms. “If they put it to me, I take the money. I’ll train your second shift, and I’ll work your Saturdays till you get your answer. But if somebody asks me, Lolo, plan or pool, I’m saying pool.”

Benny’s looking at the floor. Irene’s looking at the printout. Darnell’s looking at his coffee like there’s a baby at the bottom of it.

Irene is the one who moves. She picks up the printout and folds it in half and in half again, small and square, and puts it in her shirt pocket.

“My other sister’s in Fort Myers,” she says. “I’d rather work Saturdays than live with her.”

“I’m just listening, boss,” Benny says to the floor. “Somebody in here should.”

“I’ll do Saturdays,” says Darnell, “if somebody comes and holds the baby.”

“Bring her in,” Lolo says. “We’ll teach her to tack.”

“Okay,” I say, and my voice comes out wrong, and I clear my throat. “Thank you, all of you, for telling me straight.”

“Somebody has to,” Lolo says. “You married a man who doesn’t.”

I go out to the room in the yard and sit at my desk with the lights off and the yard light coming in through the glass, white on the snow. I’m still sitting there an hour later when the knock comes, one knuckle, on the glass.

He’s carrying a white paper bag from the Polish deli on Leonard, and I can smell it from the desk, kielbasa and rye bread. He doesn’t hand it to me; he sets it on the corner of the desk and stands there.

“I wasn’t going home,” he says. “I didn’t think you were either.”

“Lolo’s going to vote for Halvard.”

He sits down in the radiator chair without putting his feet up. “She told you that?”

“Straight to my face. She said somebody has to.”

He takes that in, nodding at the floor. “She isn’t wrong about that.”

“She’s not wrong about anything.” I put my head back against the chair and look at the ceiling, cedar, the boards I picked one at a time in a lumberyard in Cedar Springs. “She wants Florida and she’s earned Florida, and I’m asking her for Saturdays.”

“You’re not asking her for Saturdays. You’re asking her to bet on you.”

“Same thing.”

“It’s not the same thing.” He leans forward with his hands between his knees. “Gil bet on you today, for sixty days, and Holland bet on you because they hate Gil. Simone’s betting on you with a calculator at her kitchen

counter. That's what you've got that Kurt doesn't: people will bet on you if you ask them."

"You didn't."

It's out of my mouth too fast to stop, and it hangs there in the cold room.

"No," he says, "I didn't. I bet on me, Nashville, Northgate, all of it. I bet on me, and I didn't ask you, and it's the worst bet I ever made."

In the white light from the yard he looks older than he did in October, gray under the eyes, and his collar's loose.

I want to say something, and I don't know what, and I don't trust anything I'd say, so I get up instead. I come around the desk and stand in front of his chair, and he looks up at me.

"Can I—" I say.

"Yes," he says.

He says it before I finish the sentence.

I've been hearing that sentence in my head for three weeks. *He said yes before I finished the sentence.* In a navy sweater, in my room, with a ficus on my desk. It's been sitting in me ever since, a splinter. And now I'm standing in front of him in the yard in the dark and he's said it to me, the same way, before I got to the end, and the splinter comes out.

I kiss him.

It's not graceful. I'm standing and he's sitting and the chair creaks and his hand comes up and finds the back of my neck, careful, like he's checking a weld, and he tastes like gas-station coffee and cold air, and I forgot. I forgot what he feels like. All that time in the next room and I forgot the exact pressure of his hand, and now my body remembers it all at once, the way your feet remember stairs in a house you grew up in.

When I pull back he's still holding the back of my neck, and his eyes are closed.

"You didn't let me finish the sentence," I say.

He opens his eyes and blinks at me. "What was the end of it?"

"*Can I ask you something.*"

He stares at me, and then he starts to laugh, helplessly, with his forehead against my stomach, and I stand there with my hands in his hair in my office in the yard and let him, and I think, very clearly, like reading a part number off a print: *I love him*. I've been carrying it around in my pocket all this time, and I didn't know what it was until it got lighter.

"Ask me," he says into my sweater.

"Later," I say. "Eat your kielbasa."

Chapter 19 — Adam

My wife and my work wife have taken over the transparency room, and everybody on the fourth floor can watch them do it.

It's the following Wednesday, a week and a day since the board. I'm standing by the coffee station at the end of the design studio with a cup of the office drip, which is worse than gas-station coffee and slightly better than Pip's, watching them through the glass. Pip's at the long white table in her plant jacket with her sleeves pushed up and a mechanical pencil behind her ear. Simone's across from her in a navy sweater with her calculator and its paper tape curling off the edge of the table onto the floor, a long white tongue of it, a week's worth, that nobody's allowed to throw away. Between them there's a whiteboard on an easel with Irene's numbers from the break room copied onto it in Pip's handwriting, and under that a column in Simone's, and they've been there since seven, and every so often one of them says something and the other one writes it down.

The whole floor watches them, sales included. Marketing has stopped pretending to watch their monitors and has turned their chairs. Bridget from accounts payable comes up from three twice a day with a question about invoices she could ask by email, just to walk past the glass.

"It's like a nature documentary," says Tavi, who's appeared at my elbow with a laptop under his arm. He's in his Carhartt indoors now and doesn't take it off anymore. "Two apex predators sharing a kill."

"That's my wife you're talking about, Tavi."

"I know, I meant it nicely." He gives me a sideways look. "Seven thousand two hundred and eight."

"I know, you text me every morning."

"I text everybody, it's the only number I've ever been in charge of." He shifts the laptop to his other arm. "Are you going in there?"

"No."

"You could bring them coffee," Tavi says. "That's the classic way in."

"They have coffee."

“They have Simone’s coffee. I’ve had it. It’s hot water that’s heard about coffee.” He waits. “So why not?”

Because nobody asked me in. Since the ramp I’ve been telling her things before I act on them, eight days of it, small things, a call from Kurt, a question from Gordon, an email from the guy at Northgate, texted to her the minute they happen, and she’s been answering *ok* and *thanks* and once, near midnight, *go to sleep*. She hasn’t asked me into the glass room, though, and at forty I’m finding out that you don’t walk into a room just because you can see through the walls.

“Because it’s their meeting,” I say.

Tavi gives me the face of a twenty-three-year-old who has just watched an adult say something unexpected.

“Huh,” he says, and goes away.

The thing nobody tells you about getting what you want is that it moves the fear to a new place in your chest.

Since the spring before last the fear has lived in one place, payroll, Nashville, the number at the bottom of Gordon’s report on Wednesdays, and I could put my hand on it. Then last Thursday, on I-94 coming home from Monroe in the snow, with my wife driving like a nun and Gil Chamberlain’s net sixty in her coat pocket, I looked over at her and she was humming. Pip doesn’t hum, ever, but she hummed for twenty miles, under her breath, something Polish her mother used to sing, and I sat there in the passenger seat and something turned over under my ribs that scared me worse than payroll.

Because now there’s something to lose that isn’t money.

Late in the morning, Kurt Lindahl calls my cell.

“Adam! How’s my favorite seller?”

“Kurt,” I say, and wait.

“I’m hearing wonderful things, just wonderful. Supplier terms, net sixty from your steel mill, I hear. Very clever, very scrappy.” He says *scrappy* as if he’s admiring a child’s drawing. “I hear your wife and our integration lead are working very closely together.”

Through the glass, Simone's writing something and Pip's laughing at it, actually laughing, with her head back.

"Who'd you hear that from?"

"Oh, furniture's a small world," he says, laughing. "Listen, I just want to say, as a friend: I think it's admirable. I think it's a great story. And I think you should remember that supplier terms don't move a covenant date. Halvard can be patient, and Northgate can't, and you know that."

"I know what Northgate can do."

"I'm only saying it because I care about the outcome, for everybody. And give Simone my best, would you? I'll see her on Thursday's call. I always look forward to Thursday."

"I'll pass that on," I say, and he laughs again like I've told a joke, and hangs up.

I take out my phone and text Pip right there by the coffee station: *Kurt called, knows about Gil's terms, didn't say how, says Northgate can't wait. Sent Simone his best and I didn't like the way he said it.* Through the glass, I watch her pick up her phone off the white table and read it, and frown, and look up, and find me at the coffee station, and hold my eyes for one second across the floor.

Then she nods, once, and goes back to the whiteboard.

That's the whole conversation, and it's the best one I've had at work in months.

Near the end of the day, Neil Pruitt from Northgate calls.

I take it in the stairwell, the iron one that smells like pigeons. Neil is a short, pleasant man from Naperville with a voice that sounds faxed. I met him once, in October, in an office on Wacker Drive with a view of the river where they dye it green on St. Patrick's Day. He told me about his kids' hockey. He had me initial forty-one pages, and I took the last one home and signed it at the kitchen counter at two in the morning.

"Adam, it's Neil, just a courtesy call."

Nobody from a lender has ever called anyone in history out of courtesy.

"Go ahead, Neil," I say.

“We’ve been reviewing the facility in light of the, ah, the developments, the media coverage, the board minutes, which Gordon was kind enough to send, the founder situation. Our credit committee met Monday. They’ve asked me to let you know we’ll be requiring weekly cash reporting going forward, rather than monthly, under section eleven. And they’ve asked me to note that the covenant is a floor, not a date. If the company’s cash falls below six on any reporting date, not just the test date, we have the right to call.”

I sit down on the iron step.

“That’s not how I read section eleven,” I say.

“I understand, but our counsel reads it differently. You’re welcome to have your counsel call our counsel.” There’s a pause, and some paper moves on his end. “Adam, I’ll be honest with you, because I like you. If this company’s cash dips under the floor, I don’t think my committee waits. I think they call. And I think the shares are worth more to us in a sale than in a fight.” He lets that sit. “I’m told Halvard is a very motivated buyer.”

The stairwell is very quiet, and somewhere below me, on three, a door opens and closes.

“Thanks for the courtesy, Neil.”

“Anytime, and say hi to your wife. We all saw the video, and my daughter wants one.”

I sit on the iron step after he hangs up until the motion light over the landing decides I’ve died and goes out.

Here’s the old me: he makes a plan. He calls Diane and gets her on with Northgate’s counsel and fights section eleven for two weeks, and calls Kurt and finds out exactly how motivated, and calls Simone after midnight and runs the numbers, and by the time anybody else finds out, he’s already decided what to do and has a slide for it. Strike that. He has three slides, and a backup deck.

I wave the light back on and get up off the step and go back up to four. I walk across the floor past sales and marketing and the design studio, past the coffee station and the cone somebody still keeps at the bolt plates in the

northwest corner, and I stop outside the glass door of the transparency room, and I knock.

Pip and Simone look up together, like a jury.

Pip studies me through the glass for a second, then gets up and opens the door.

“Can I come in?” I say.

“Yes.”

“I have a bad part.”

She steps back to let me in.

I tell it badly, in the wrong order, with the worst part in the middle, standing at the end of the long white table with my hands in my pockets because I don’t know what else to do with them: weekly reporting, section eleven, *a floor, not a date, I think they call, the shares are worth more to us in a sale*. I forget Neil’s last name halfway through and have to start the sentence over. I say *um*, which I never say, more than once.

Simone writes it all down. Pip doesn’t write anything; she stands by the whiteboard with the pencil behind her ear and her arms crossed, and listens with her eyes on my face.

When I’m done, the only sound in the room is the calculator.

“So it’s not thirty days,” Pip says.

“It’s however many days until the cash dips under six.”

“What does the tape say, Simone?”

Simone’s already running it. “At current burn, with the new supplier terms and nothing else changing, the balance crosses six million in—“ She runs it again. “Twenty-three days. Possibly twenty-one, depending on when the Nashville payroll clears.”

Pip turns to the whiteboard, to Irene’s numbers and Simone’s column and the box at the bottom of Simone’s column that says *NASH*, with a single neat line through it and a question mark. She stands looking at that box long enough for Simone to take her finger off the calculator, and then she turns back to me.

“Thank you for telling me first,” she says.

"I'm bad at it, though."

"You're terrible at it," Pip says. "You said um four times and you forgot the man's name." She uncrosses her arms and holds out a green marker. "Keep doing it. And put it on the board, in your handwriting, under Simone's."

I take the marker and write *NORTHGATE: FLOOR 6, WEEKLY* under Simone's column, and my capitals come out leaning downhill like they're trying to leave the room.

"Your handwriting is terrible," Simone says.

"I'm in sales. We type."

"Every call," Pip says. "Every time one of them calls you, it goes up here with everything else."

Simone hooks the third chair out from under the table with her foot, without looking up from the tape. "Sit down, Adam. Somebody needs to call Grand Rapids Glass about delivery dates and be charming, and neither of us is willing."

I sit down in the third chair and make the call, with the whole fourth floor watching me through the glass.

The dispatcher at Grand Rapids Glass says the earliest she can cut tempered panels in that size is three weeks.

"She needs them in two," I say.

"Everybody needs them in two."

I tell her the worst of it up front, that we're short on cash and long on orders, and that Holland already matched her terms and would love to go first on the glass too. There's a pause on the line.

"Holland," she says, the way you'd name a rash. "I can do two and a half."

Pip, without turning around from the whiteboard, holds up two fingers over her shoulder, like somebody bidding at a church auction.

"Two," I say.

"Fine, two. Tell her she owes me a softball game."

That night I don't go upstairs to the room across the hall.

I stand on the landing at the top of the good stairs, with the ninth step creaking behind me, and look at two doors, mine open, hers shut with light under it.

I've never knocked on that door since Nashville. I've stood here a hundred times in the dark with my hand up and then turned around. I knock now, once, with one knuckle, like I'm at a drive-through.

The light under the door moves, and the door opens. She's in my old Grand Valley sweatshirt and her wool socks, with her hair down and her reading glasses on, holding a pad of graph paper.

"I don't have a bad part," I say. "I just wanted to knock."

She considers me over her reading glasses, holding the graph paper against her chest.

"Come in if you want to," she says.

"I want to."

"Then ask me the whole way through."

"Pip," I say, "can I come in?"

She sets the graph paper on the dresser by the door, face down.

"Yes," she says, and takes my hand, and pulls me in, and closes the door behind us.

Later, much later, lying on my back in her bed with her asleep against my shoulder and her hair in my mouth, I look up at her ceiling in the gray light from the window. There's a water stain up there, over the bed, shaped a bit like Lake Michigan.

Two years across the hall. I never knew she had a lake.

Chapter 20 — Pip

The story goes up on the *Furnishings Weekly* website just after six on Thursday morning, which is a strange hour to publish news about furniture unless you want it to be the first thing a lot of people in Grand Rapids read with their coffee.

HALVARD NEARS DEAL FOR VIRAL BACKYARD-OFFICE MAKER TWODESK, the headline says. Under it, a photo of Kurt Lindahl in a turtleneck at a trade show in Milan, and under that, the article. *Sources close to the transaction. Final approvals expected within weeks. Halvard is expected to consolidate Twodesk manufacturing into its existing North American footprint as part of a broader integration.* And, in the fourth paragraph, the one that matters: *A person familiar with Halvard's plans said the company's Clyde Park facility in Wyoming, Michigan, is likely to close within two years.*

Twenty-four months, when Ruth told the whole board thirty-six months, *in writing, I asked.*

I read it in my truck in the plant lot ahead of the shift bell, twice, and then I lay the phone face down on the dash and sit there with my hands on the wheel while first shift comes in across the lot under the lights: Benny's Silverado, Irene's Malibu, Darnell's minivan with the new baby seat in the back that he showed everybody on Monday like it was a trophy.

I can tell from the way they're walking that they've already read it.

By the time the knee line should be striking its first arc, there's no work on the floor. The machines are on, and the press brake is going *chunk* because Benny turned it on by habit, but the knee line's standing under the yellow curtains with their hoods pushed up on their heads, talking. The glazing table's empty, because Irene's in the break room with Darnell and half of first shift, standing in their coats around the microwave cart where Tavi used to set up his laptop with the dots. Somebody's printed out the article and taped it to the whiteboard by the time clock, right over the count.

ROOMS SOLD SINCE PIP LIBERATED ONE: 7,519.

And under it, in Darnell's handwriting, in red: *DAYS UNTIL THEY CLOSE US: ???*

I stand in the doorway, and every face in the room turns to me.

"Is it true?" says one of the new kids from glazing, a nineteen-year-old named Hector who started in November. "Are they closing us?"

"No, they're not," I say.

"It says it right there in the fourth paragraph."

"It says *a person familiar*."

"So who's the person?"

"Somebody who wants you scared," says Lolo, from the back, by the coffee machine. She's not on shift and she came in anyway, in her bowling jacket with SPARE PARTS on the back, holding a Styrofoam cup in both hands and not looking at me. "Somebody in Minneapolis who wants Pip to fold. That's what that is."

"So it's not true?" Hector says.

Lolo doesn't answer him. She turns her eyes on me instead, and so does everybody else.

"My landlord read it," Irene says, with her arms crossed over her apron. "He texted me while I was still in my socks, asking if I'm renewing in May."

"My wife read it to me out loud in the car," says Darnell, "with the baby in the back."

"The kids are getting texts, boss." That's Benny, from the door, with the press brake still going *chunk* behind him because nobody's turned it off. "There's a cabinet shop in Holland already texting the glazing kids. Twenty-two an hour and a signing bonus."

"I got one," Hector says, and holds up his phone like evidence.

"Don't answer it," I say.

"Why not? Nobody upstairs is answering anything."

"I'm answering you right now."

"You're answering *no*," Hector says. "My mom says no like that when the answer's yes."

“Nobody’s quit yet,” Benny says from the door. “Yet’s a long word, boss.”

Darnell points the red marker at the whiteboard, at the article taped over his count. “Kurt gets a magazine, and we get a printout over the count. Who’s going to say something, Pip? Out loud, where Minneapolis can hear it?”

“Your room got on the news,” Irene says. “Get us on the news.”

I could tell them. I could say: *There’s a deal. I’m the no. I’ve got twenty days, maybe less, to find two point three million dollars, and if I don’t, Northgate calls the loan and takes Adam’s shares and sells them to Halvard, and then I’m not the no anymore.* I could say all of that, and it’s all true.

I haven’t told them any of it in a month. I told Benny *nobody’s selling this plant*, and I told Darnell to erase *stole*, and I decided what they could carry.

“I’m handling it,” I say.

“Handling it how?” says Hector.

“I’m handling it, Hector. Go back to work, all of you. Nobody’s closing this plant.”

Nobody moves for a second. Then Darnell caps the red marker and puts it in the tray, and leaves the question marks up.

“Then say it somewhere besides the break room, boss,” he says, and goes.

They go back to work, slowly, in twos and threes, Hector last, with his phone still in his hand. Lolo stays by the coffee machine with her cup, and when the room’s empty she drinks the rest of her coffee and throws the cup away and comes past me in the doorway.

“I’m handling it,” she says. “That’s what your dad used to say when your mother asked about the furnace.”

“Did he handle it?”

“Every time, and every time she’d have rather known.” She zips her jacket to the chin. “I’m going home to sleep. Text me if you need a training crew.”

My phone buzzes all morning. Adam, first thing: *Saw it, not from us. Kurt’s pressuring, calling Ruth now.* Then, mid-morning, my phone again: *Ruth says not her either, and she’s furious, she thinks Kurt leaked it.* Then: *Want me to come out?* Simone, a little later: *That timeline is not in any*

Halvard document I have seen. It is a lie or it is a new plan. Either way it was placed. I am finding out which.

I don't answer any of them. I'm at the knee line with my hood down, running beads on a training coupon, because when I can't think I weld, and I can't think.

Around noon Irene comes over from glazing and stands at my elbow until I flip my hood up.

"The TV lady called the front office," she says. "They put her through to the floor phone, and I told her you'd call her back. Are you calling her back?"

"I'm welding, Irene."

"You're welding a coupon. Nobody needs that coupon." She picks it up with her gloves, looks at my bead, and sets it down again. "It's a nice bead. Call her back."

Carla Ruiz from Channel 6 calls after lunch, and again an hour later. Then a text lands on my phone: *We're doing the Halvard story on the early news. We'd love the founder's side. We're coming out either way. We'd rather have you than the gate.*

A little after four the live truck pulls into the lot and parks by the fence, right next to my room: a white van with a satellite dish on the roof folded down like a hand, a camera guy, a producer with a headset, and Carla Ruiz, who turns out to be about thirty, with very good hair that doesn't move in the wind and a long red coat that's exactly right for television and wrong for the yard. She gets out and looks at the room on its cribbing in the snow with the light on inside, and her face does what everybody's face does.

"Oh, it's smaller than on TV," she says.

"It's ten by twelve, same as on TV."

"It looks bigger coming out of a building." She shakes my hand, and hers is cold because she didn't keep it in her pocket, and I like her a little for that. "Ms. Sobczak, thank you. We go at five-oh-two, live, ninety seconds. I'll ask you about the report, and you can say anything you want."

"I haven't said I'll do it."

"I know you haven't." She looks past me, to the open rolling door of the plant, where first shift is standing, not working, thirty of them, maybe forty, in their coats and hoods and safety glasses: Benny with his arms folded on his belly, Irene with hers crossed, Darnell, Hector with his hood up. All of them are watching the yard.

"I think they'd like you to," Carla says gently.

I don't answer her. I'm still looking at them.

"Is there anything you won't answer?" she asks.

"Anything about my husband."

"Then I won't ask about your husband," she says, and writes something on her hand with a pen.

While the camera guy runs cable through the snow, Darnell comes out of the rolling door and across the yard, in no hurry, with his hands in his coat pockets. He stops beside me and looks at the van instead of at me.

"You don't have to say anything fancy, boss," he says. "Just say we're not closing."

"I said it in the break room."

"You said it to us, and we already believed you." He jerks his chin at the camera, and at Minneapolis somewhere behind it. "Say it to them."

He walks back to the door and takes his place in it again, next to Irene.

Twenty minutes before air, I'm in the room with the door shut and my phone in my hand.

I should call him. Since the parking ramp he's been telling me everything before he does it, without anybody asking him to, badly, forgetting names, texting me every one of Kurt's calls. He knocked on my door.

I should call him and say: *Channel 6 is in the yard. They're going live at five. I'm going to say something, and here's what I'm going to say.* And he'd say something back, and Simone would say something about numbers, and we'd decide.

And while we decided, forty people would stand in that rolling door in the cold watching a news van, thinking about *likely to close*.

His name is right there on the screen, ADAM, with the photo of him asleep at a rest stop with pretzels on his chest. Out in the yard the producer holds up ten fingers at my glass, and a while later five, and the screen goes dark and I wake it up again.

I'm handling it.

I put the phone in my pocket.

When the producer starts counting, I'm standing in the snow in front of my room in the white blast of the camera light, with the glass corner glowing behind me and Carla Ruiz beside me in her red coat with a microphone. The producer counts down with her fingers, three, two, and behind the camera, at the rolling door, forty people have gone completely quiet.

"I'm here at the Clyde Park plant of Twodesk, the Grand Rapids company whose video of a room being craned out of its own headquarters has been seen by more than eleven million people," Carla says to the lens. "This morning a trade publication reported that Minneapolis furniture giant Halvard is close to acquiring the company, and that this plant could close within two years. With me is Twodesk co-founder Philippa Sobczak, who designed the room you see behind me." She turns to me with the microphone. "Ms. Sobczak, is Twodesk being sold?"

The light is so bright I can't see the rolling door anymore, only the snow coming down through it, big and slow, each flake lit up like a spark from a grinder.

"No," I say, into the light.

"The report says—"

"The report's wrong." It comes out in my floor voice, the one that carries over a press brake. "We're not selling, not to Halvard, not to anybody. We've got seven thousand five hundred people who put money down on a room with no post in the corner, and we're going to build every one of them here, in this building, with these people."

I point behind me without looking, because I don't have to.

"So there's no deal?" Carla says.

“There’s no deal,” I say. “There’s a plant. It’s open. It’s staying open. That’s all I’ve got to say.”

There’s a second where nothing happens. Then, somewhere behind the camera, from the rolling door, somebody whoops, high and loud, like a kid at a ballgame, and then somebody else does, and then they’re clapping, forty people in coats in the snow clapping, and Carla Ruiz is smiling at me with her very good hair not moving, and she turns back to the lens.

“A defiant answer from Philippa Sobczak,” she says. “We’ve reached out to Halvard and to CEO Adam Kerrigan for comment. Back to you, Tom.”

Chapter 21 — Pip

Halvard walks at 8:14 on Friday morning, by email, in four sentences.

Ruth forwards it to me two minutes later with no message, just the email, the way you'd forward a photo of a car accident. I read it in my room in the yard with my coat still on.

In light of yesterday's public statements by a Twodesk founder, Halvard Group has concluded that the conditions for a successful transaction are not present at this time. We are therefore withdrawing from discussions, effective immediately. We wish the Twodesk team every success. We remain admirers of the product.

We remain admirers of the product. Kurt wrote that line himself. I can hear him saying it in a turtleneck, with his hand flat on my glass.

I sit there and wait to feel good. This is what I wanted. It's what I said on television to eleven million people and to forty of my own standing in the snow: *There's no deal*. Now there isn't one. Nobody's putting a post in my corner, and nobody's moving the knee line to Monterrey.

I don't feel good. I get up and check that the space heater's plugged in, because it's the one thing in the room I know how to fix, and it is plugged in, and I sit back down.

Northgate calls Adam a little before ten. I know because Adam texts me ten minutes later, as he's texted me everything since the ramp: *Northgate. Pruitt. Credit committee met at 9. Halvard walking + "public founder dispute" + "material uncertainty". They're invoking §11 early. Cash test is now ten business days out, not March. Friday the 12th, close of business. If we're under 6, they call.*

A minute after that: *I'm sorry. That's all of it. You have everything I have.*

Ten business days. Simone's tape said twenty-three, maybe twenty-one on a bad week. Nothing on that tape ever said ten.

I do the arithmetic at my desk with my coat on, three times, on the back of an invoice. Gil's net sixty starts the day his first trailer of tube hits the dock, which is Thursday, and we cut that same day, and the first escrow releases when the steel's cut, a million and a half. Second shift can't start for six weeks

because I don't have anybody who can weld the knee. And the hole is two point three, and it doesn't care about any of that. It just sits there on the back of the invoice being two point three.

Simone walks into my room at half past ten without knocking.

She's in her navy coat with the black notebook under her arm. She doesn't wipe her boots on my mother's rug. She stands on it with snow melting off them onto the bread bags, and her face is the same as always, level as a manifest, and I know something's wrong because her hands are shaking. Simone's hands don't shake. Simone's hands write in printing so small and straight I once thought it was a font.

"I was on a call with Kurt at seven-thirty this morning," she says. "Before he sent the email. He asked me to stay on after Ruth dropped. He asked me, *Simone, did you know she was going to do that?* I said no. He asked me, *Did you give her our supplier analysis? The cost model? Did you help her build a plan to blow up my deal while you were sitting on my integration calls?*" She stops and closes the notebook. "I said I had not shared any Halvard material. Which is true. I have not."

"I know you haven't, Simone."

"He did not believe me. He said, *Then why does it look exactly like what you would build?*" Her voice stays level while her hands go on shaking. "He said I would never work in this industry in the Midwest again. He has three friends at the two companies I would have gone to next. I know them. They are the kind of men who play golf in Scottsdale."

"Simone, I didn't—"

"You didn't tell me," she says.

It's so quiet in the room I can hear the press brake across the yard, one long *chunk* through the glass.

"I was on a call with Kurt Lindahl for forty minutes on Thursday," Simone says, "lying by omission for you, because you asked me. Because you *asked*. I have not been asked for anything in eight months, and you came to my apartment at nine-forty at night and asked me, and I said yes before I could think about whether I should." She takes a breath. "And then on Thursday you

went on television and decided the whole thing in ninety seconds, and you did not text me. You did not call me. I watched it on my phone in the glass room with Gordon.”

“There wasn’t time—“

“There were twenty minutes. Darnell told me. He said you sat in the room with your phone for twenty minutes.” She looks at the desk, where my phone is lying on the invoice. “You held it in your hand, Pip.”

The phone’s right there between us, and I don’t pick it up now either.

“We had an arrangement,” Simone says quietly. “I would tell you what Kurt said, and I would tell Kurt nothing. I kept my half. I kept it on a call with him this morning while he called me a liar. You kept yours by going on television.”

She lets that sit, then takes a white envelope out of her notebook and puts it on my desk, on top of the invoice with my arithmetic on the back.

“My resignation, effective today. I have already sent it to Ruth and Diane.” She straightens her coat. “I have also sent Gordon the model. All of it, the supplier terms and the escrow schedule and the training plan and the tape. It is in a folder called PIP. You will need it. I do not want anything to happen to the plant because I was angry with you.”

“Simone, please don’t go,” I say.

She stands with one hand on the notebook, and her mouth goes flat and careful, the way it goes when a number she’s checked twice comes out the same both times.

“You are asking me,” she says. “I notice that. I will remember that you did.” She turns to the door. “But I have a daughter at State and eleven boxes I have not unpacked, and this morning I learned that I should probably not unpack them. I would like to go and think about where to take them.”

She opens the door, and the cold comes in around her.

“I liked working with you,” she says, without turning around. “Very much. I do not say that to people.”

Then she’s gone across the yard to the gray Volvo with the ski rack and no skis, and she drives away slowly, between the lines, and doesn’t look back.

A minute later Darnell comes over from the plant with two coffees from the lunch truck in a cardboard tray. He stops in my doorway and watches the Volvo turn onto Clyde Park.

“One of these was hers,” he says. “Black, no lid. She likes to see it.”

“She’s not coming back, Darnell.”

He looks at the second cup like it’s a part that came off a truck with no paperwork. “You mean today, or like at all?”

“I mean at all. She resigned this morning.”

“Huh.” He sets the tray down on my desk, right on the envelope, and I slide the envelope out from under it. “You want to know something stupid? Irene printed you off the TV. She taped you up on the break room door, and Benny drew a cape on you with a Sharpie. It’s a pretty good cape.”

“Take it down, Darnell.”

“I’m not taking it down. Lolo would kill me.” He takes his own cup and leaves hers. “Guys keep coming up to me asking if we won. I keep telling them yeah.”

He waits in the door for me to tell him yeah. I pick up Simone’s coffee instead, because it’s hot and it’s there, and drink it black with no lid, and he nods like that counts as an answer and goes back across the yard to the rolling door.

He’s at the house when I get home at nine.

He’s standing at the counter in his shirtsleeves with his tie off and his hands flat on the quartz, the good one, the one that looks like a river. There’s no food and no coffee. The kitchen’s bright and cold, and there’s a glass of whiskey by his hand that he hasn’t touched, and beside it the Channel 6 clip is playing on his laptop with the sound off. My face in the camera light, the glass corner and the snow, and my finger pointing back at the rolling door.

He doesn’t say hi when I come in.

“Ruth’s calling an emergency board for Monday,” he says. “Del’s flying back from Phoenix. Diane’s been on the phone with Northgate’s counsel since noon, and they’re not budging on section eleven. It’s ten days, Pip.”

“I know it’s ten days.”

“Simone quit.”

“I know. She told me first, this morning, in the yard.”

“She told *you* first.” Something goes across his face and stays there. “Of course she did.”

I put my bag down on a stool and keep my coat on.

“Go ahead,” I say. “Say whatever you’ve been standing here not saying since yesterday at five.”

He doesn’t pretend he doesn’t know what I mean. He turns the laptop a few degrees toward me, so we can both watch me.

“You didn’t call me,” he says.

“No,” I say. “I didn’t call you.”

“For two weeks I’ve told you everything before I did it. Every call, every email, every man from Chicago. I said *um* in front of Simone. I forgot a man’s name. I did it badly and I did it every time.” His voice is very quiet. “And then you went on television and killed a billion-dollar deal and set off a covenant on my shares, and you didn’t text me. I was in the glass room with Gordon. Gordon *cried*, Pip. I found out from Tom.”

“I don’t know who Tom is.”

“The anchor, Pip, the guy you handed it back to, *back to you, Tom.*” He laughs, and it’s no laugh I’ve got catalogued. It’s an ugly sound. “I found out about my own company from Tom Bielski on Channel 6.”

“You want to talk about who found out from whom?” I say.

It comes out of me cold and fast and I can’t stop it. It comes up from the bottom of everything since Nashville.

“I found out about Northgate from Gordon, at a walnut table, in front of Ruth. I found out I was *pending* from a slide. I find out what you’re afraid of through a wall at one in the morning, Adam, when you pick up the phone and tell *her*. Every night for eight months I’ve lain there and listened to you laugh with somebody else. So don’t you stand at that counter and tell me about *before.*”

He says *don’t* twice while I’m saying it, quietly, and I go right over him both times.

“Then why didn’t you call me?”

He’s not shouting. He’s leaning on the counter with both hands like he’ll fall down if he lets go.

“Darnell says you sat in that room with your phone in your hand,” he says. “Why didn’t you call?”

Because forty people were standing in a doorway in the snow with their hands in their pockets. Because I was scared, and because I was handling it.

I don’t say any of it. I stand in my own kitchen in my coat with my keys still in my hand, and he watches me across twelve feet of quartz with the river in it, and his face does something I’ve never seen it do. It opens completely, and what’s behind it is so tired.

“I’d have said yes,” he says, very quietly. “That’s the part I can’t get past. You could’ve called me from the yard and said *I’m going to tell them no*, and I’d have said yes. I’d have driven out and stood next to you in the snow. You didn’t need to do it by yourself.”

That’s the one. It goes in under my ribs and stays there.

Because it never crossed my mind. All that time with the phone in my hand, and not once did I picture him saying yes. I pictured him pitching me, stalling me, calling Simone. I didn’t picture him standing next to me in the snow. I don’t know yet what that says about him. I know what it says about me.

I can’t stand in a kitchen with somebody who’d have said yes.

“I need you to go,” I say.

He closes his eyes. “Where am I supposed to go, Pip?”

I don’t have an answer. I’ve got nothing in my hands but my keys and nothing in my head but ten days and Simone’s white envelope and *I’d have said yes*. What comes out of my mouth is the last thing I want to say, the worst thing, his own words in his own voice.

“You barely use it,” I say.

He opens his eyes. He knows what I mean. The room, ten by twelve, up on cribbing in a yard on Clyde Park Avenue with the light on.

He takes his coat off the hook by the door, the hook I drilled into the brick in 2019. He doesn't pack a bag. He takes his keys and his phone and leaves the whiskey where it is, and he stops in the back door with his hand on the frame, the way he stopped in the door of my room in the yard on the first morning with the snow blowing in behind him.

He stands there with his hand on the frame and keeps his mouth shut, and so do I.

Then he goes, and the door shuts, and I stand in the kitchen and listen to his car back down the drive.

On the counter, the laptop plays my face again, silent. My finger points behind me at nothing.

Chapter 22 — Adam

I sit in my car outside the gate at Clyde Park for two hours and ten minutes with the engine running, waiting for second shift to go home.

I don't want anybody to see me. I don't want to walk across that yard in front of forty people who stood in a doorway yesterday and clapped for my wife while I found out from Tom Bielski. So I park across the street in the lot of the Reformed church with the sign that says *GOD ANSWERS KNEE-MAIL*, turn off the headlights, and stare at the plant through the windshield like a man on a stakeout of his own life.

At half past eleven the rolling door comes down, and the cars start leaving: Lolo's Buick, Darnell's minivan, a dozen pickups. Just before midnight the plant goes dark except for the exit signs and the yard light by the fence, which stays on all night, white, over the room.

At five to twelve I text her, because telling her first is what I do now. *I'm going to sleep in the room in the yard. I'll be out before first shift. I'm telling you so you don't hear it from Benny.* I send it before I can make it better. Three minutes later, with the gate code half punched in, I send her the other one, about the end of the fight, which I've been writing in my head since I backed down the drive. The code is Pip's birthday. The gate rolls back on its track with a long iron complaint.

I've had a key to the room since 2018, a brass key with a dab of red nail polish on the bow that Pip put there so I'd stop trying it in the wrong locks. I haven't used it since the all-hands. Stan's old deadbolt turns hard, as it always did, and then gives.

The heater's on low. It smells like cedar and primer and the soap she uses, Ivory, the plain kind.

I don't turn on the desk lamp. The yard light coming in at the corner is enough: her desk and her chair, the vise with a weld sample still in it, sawn clean, and a stack of graph paper face down, squared to the corner of the desk.

I don't sit in my own chair by the radiator. I sit in hers, and I couldn't tell you why.

It's the wrong height for me. She sets it low so her feet are flat on the floor, the way her father taught her to stand at a bench. I sit there with my knees up like a kid at a grown-up's desk and look out past where the post would be, at the yard and the fence and the maples on Clyde Park standing up black against the orange sky.

I'd have said yes.

I said that to her three hours ago across the counter, with the whiskey I didn't drink beside my hand. It was true. I watched it go into her like I'd thrown it, and she went still. I didn't mean it as a weapon. It landed like one anyway, because of everything it landed on top of: eight months of a phone ringing on my side of a wall.

I sit in her chair till one. Then I get the moving blanket off the shelf by the door, the quilted gray one Darnell keeps there to wrap the glass when they set a unit, and I lie down on my mother-in-law's braided rug with my coat for a pillow and the blanket over me.

I don't sleep. Somewhere around three I start thinking about the wall. Two layers of 1890s plaster and a closet full of her winter coats. Every night I picked up the phone on my side of it, she was lying on hers. I knew the wall was thin. I've known since the winter we moved in, when I could hear her radiator knock from my desk. I called anyway, and I laughed, and I told myself it was work.

Lying on her floor in the dark, I go looking for a version of Nashville and everything after it where that's anybody's fault but mine. I don't find one.

Just shy of five I get up and fold the moving blanket and put it back on the shelf, corners square, the way my mother folded towels. I put her chair back at her height, as close as I can get it. I let myself out and lock the deadbolt, and I'm across the street in the church lot before Benny's Silverado comes down Clyde Park with its one bad headlight.

Saturday the plant's closed. I spend the day at a Panera in Wyoming with my laptop, answering Ruth and Diane and Gordon, telling all three of them I'm working from home. The girl at the register gives me a free cookie because I look like somebody who needs one.

Saturday night I'm back in the church lot at half past eleven. I go in at midnight and lie down on the floor, and around two I actually sleep and dream about a green thermos going cold.

Sunday morning at ten I'm sitting in her chair with the real light coming in gray at the corner, and I call Simone. All my calls to Simone happened in the dark.

She picks up on the fourth ring. "Adam," she says, the way she reads a line item off a report, and waits.

"Is this a bad time, Simone?"

"I'm in a U-Haul parking lot on Twenty-Eighth Street, pricing trucks," Simone says. "There is a man here who has asked me three times whether my husband will be doing the driving. So yes, it is a bad time, but go ahead."

"So you're really leaving Grand Rapids?"

"Pricing is not leaving. Pricing is information." There's traffic behind her, and a man somewhere shouting about a hitch. "What do you want, Adam?"

"I want to stop calling you at one in the morning," I say.

The line goes quiet long enough that I check the screen in case she's gone.

"Okay," Simone says, and nothing else.

"I mean it, and it isn't anything you did. You picked up, you always picked up, and I'm the one who called. For eight months I called you about the things I was afraid of, because you were awake and you had the numbers and you didn't look at me any way at all. And I called it work. Some of it was work. But some of it was me not going upstairs. I should have been knocking on my wife's door. I used you so I didn't have to, and I'm sorry. I'm stopping."

The quiet this time lasts long enough for the man in the lot to stop shouting about his hitch.

"You are telling me this," Simone says slowly, "at ten in the morning on a Sunday, before you stop."

"Yes, that's the whole idea."

“Huh,” Simone says, and in eight months I’ve never heard her make that sound. “Well, thank you for telling me. I would have noticed eventually, around one-fifteen.”

I almost laugh, and then I hear her breathe in.

“Do you know why I always picked up?” she says.

I’ve got an answer ready, because I always have one. “Because you’re the best operator I ever hired,” I say, “and you were up.”

“No.” Her voice doesn’t change. “I picked up because you were the only person in that building who called me about anything that was not a shipment. And you called me because nothing rode on what I said back. I was not married to you. I did not own a third of anything. You could tell me the truth about a number in the middle of the night and it cost you nothing, because whatever I said, you would still go home to the same house.” A truck door slams somewhere near her. “Do you know what that is like? To be the person a man can say anything to, because nothing she says can change anything?”

I start to tell her it changed plenty, that her model saved us twice, that hers were the only numbers I trusted. It’s a good answer, with a proof in it and an ask at the end.

“Do not reframe it,” Simone says. “I have watched you do that to Ruth for eight months. It works on Ruth.”

So I don’t. I sit in Pip’s chair with my knees up and let her question stay her question.

“No,” I say. “I never thought about it from your end. I’m sorry about that too.”

“Thank you.” She lets out a breath that sounds like she’s been holding it since October. “That one I will keep.”

“There’s another thing,” I say. “Kurt. He’s telling people you leaked his model. He’s poisoning you with Brightline and Haverhill. I want to call them today and tell them the truth. That you never gave Pip a single Halvard number, that you were the most professional person in the building, that Kurt’s a sore—“

She says my name once, flat, as if she’s turning down a vendor, and I stop.

“Do not decide that for me,” Simone says. “Ask me.”

Outside, a crow lands on the fence, looks at the room, and decides against it.

“Simone, can I call Brightline and Haverhill and tell them the truth about you?”

“Yes, you can, and thank you. Use the word *exemplary*. Dave Haverhill likes words like that. He thinks they’re expensive.” She waits a moment. “Where are you calling me from?”

“I’m in the room. Hers, in the yard. I’ve been sleeping here since Friday, on the floor, under Darnell’s moving blanket.”

Simone lets a truck back up behind her, beeping, and only then answers.

“You should go home,” she says.

“She’s the one who asked me to go, Simone. I’m doing what I’m told.”

“Then you are home,” Simone says. “You barely used it.”

She hangs up first, which she’s never done in eight months, and I sit there with the phone in my hand and the crow on the fence, and I laugh until my eyes hurt.

When I stop, I look at the inside of the door, where the light’s better now. The pencil on the raw birch, three lines in two hands, twelve years old.

1. Nobody decides alone.

I know what I’m going to do. I’ve known since about four this morning, on the floor. It’s going to cost me everything I put on the table in October. I’m as sure of it as I am of a number I’ve checked three times.

But I won’t do it yet.

First I’m going to tell her.

Chapter 23 — Pip

On Monday, day one of ten, I try to fix it by myself, and by four in the afternoon I've learned what every bank in West Michigan sounds like when it's being kind.

West River Bank, where we've had our operating account since 2015, sounds like Curtis, who went to Catholic Central with my brother Marek and who says *I'm going to be honest with you, Pip* four times in eleven minutes before telling me that a two-point-three-million-dollar bridge to a company with an active lender dispute and no acquirer isn't something his committee will touch in ten days, or ten weeks, or, honestly, Pip, at all.

Lakeshore Community Credit Union sounds like Fran, who saw the video.

"Is it true you're a member?" she says. "Personally? Somebody here said you were a member."

"Since 1996, Fran. I opened it with my First Communion money."

"Oh, honey," Fran says, and I can hear exactly how the rest of the call is going to go, and it goes that way. Fran's sorry, and then Fran's so sorry, and then she asks if I'd sign a photo for her nephew.

A dentist in Rockford who bought the first Corner we ever sold to a stranger, in 2015, and who's sent me a Christmas card every year since with a photo of himself painting watercolors in it, sounds like somebody backing very carefully out of a room. He's so proud of me. He's going to send a check for five hundred dollars, personally, no paperwork, because he believes in me.

"Dr. Vander Molen, please don't," I say. "Keep it. Buy paint."

"I have plenty of paint, Philippa. I have more paint than sense." He sends it anyway. It arrives on Thursday, and I keep it on my desk under the vise.

By four o'clock I've called nine people. I've written their names down on the back of an invoice in a column, and next to each one I've written a number, and the numbers are zero, zero, zero, zero, *maybe in March*, zero, zero, \$500 (*Dr. Vander Molen, watercolors*), zero.

I've got Simone's model open on my laptop in a folder called PIP. I've got Irene's numbers on the whiteboard in the break room and Gil Chamberlain's

steel coming on Thursday. I've got two point three million dollars of hole and nine days to fill it and nobody to fill it with.

Around ten after four it comes to me that I've sat at my desk in the yard all day without once looking at his chair.

It's been moved an inch, maybe two. It's angled the wrong way, toward the glass instead of the desk, like somebody sat in it and looked out. And my chair, which I keep set low so my feet are flat on the floor, the way my father taught me, has been raised and put back down. I can tell, because the lever's at a different notch. Somebody's put it back to almost exactly where I had it, almost, as careful as a guest in a house where he's not sure he's welcome.

The moving blanket on the shelf by the door is folded with the corners square. Darnell doesn't fold the corners square. Darnell folds it in a sort of lump and calls it folded.

I sit there with my hands in my lap, looking at the blanket.

I don't need to call Benny and ask, because he told me. Friday night, just before midnight, two texts in a row. I read them standing in the dark kitchen with the laptop still playing, and I've read them maybe forty times since.

I'm going to sleep in the room in the yard. I'll be out before first shift. I'm telling you so you don't hear it from Benny.

And under it, three minutes later:

I'm sorry for what I said at the end. Not because it wasn't true. Because I said it to hurt you. That was the wrong reason to tell you a true thing.

He said he'd be gone before Benny. I don't call Benny to check, and I don't walk the yard looking for tire tracks. I just look at the blanket, and then I put my chair back down one more notch, to where it was.

I don't text him back. I wouldn't know what to put in it. I'm the one who told him to go, and he went where I sent him, and folded the blanket.

At six o'clock I drive to my parents' house.

They live on the West Side on Garfield Avenue in the same house I grew up in, a narrow two-story with green asbestos siding and a statue of the Virgin in a half-buried bathtub in the front yard, painted blue, with a little string of Christmas lights around her that my father leaves up till Easter because he

says she likes them. The garage where we built Unit 001 is still out back, with a new roof. My father keeps his welder in it. He still welds on Saturdays, small things: boot scrapers, a fence gate for the neighbor, a bird feeder shaped like the basilica.

My mother's at Bingo. My father's at the kitchen table in his undershirt, doing the crossword in pen.

"She's at Bingo," he says, when I come in. "There's gołąbki in the oven. Don't touch the plum ones, they're for the priest."

"I'm not hungry, Tato."

He looks up at me over his reading glasses and keeps looking. Then he puts down the pen and gets up, slowly, one hand on the table, and gets a plate out of the cupboard and puts two gołąbki on it from the oven with a fork and sets it in front of me, and sits back down, and picks up his pen.

"Eat," he says.

So I eat, and they're very good. They're always very good. My mother's been making them the same way since 1971, and she'll tell you it's the rice, but it's the cabbage, she blanches it twice.

My father does the crossword while I eat. The clock over the stove ticks, the teapot one that's been running eight minutes fast since the Clinton administration.

"I did something stupid," I say.

"I saw. On Channel 6." He writes a word in. "You looked good. Very strong. Like your mother at a parish council."

"I didn't tell him first, Tato."

"Who didn't you tell?"

"Adam."

My father lays the pen down crosswise on the crossword, which is what he does instead of clearing his throat.

"I didn't tell anybody first," I say. "I didn't tell Adam, I didn't tell Simone, I didn't tell the crew. I had my phone in my hand and I put it in my pocket. And now the deal's dead and the bank's calling the loan in nine days and Simone quit and I told him to leave." I put the fork down. "He said he'd have

said yes, Tato. If I'd called. He'd have driven out and stood next to me. And I never even pictured it."

My father squares the pen against the edge of the newspaper and looks at it instead of me.

"Your rule," he says. "On the door."

"Nobody decides alone."

"You know what I meant by that? In the garage?"

"You meant the thermostat, Tato. You told me."

"I told you the joke." He nods at the wall where the thermostat is, under the Last Supper. "Forty-six years, your mother and me and that thing. You know who won?"

"Mama, because Mama always wins."

"Nobody won." He smiles, a little. "Your mother and me, we never agreed about anything. Not the thermostat, not the car, not your brother Joe joining the fire department, not you quitting Ferris State to build sheds in my garage with a boy from Kalamazoo." He taps the table with one finger. "But every time she was going to turn that thermostat, she said, *Stanley, I'm turning it to sixty-two*. Every single time, and then she turned it. And I'd get up and turn it back to sixty-eight, and I'd say, *Halina, I'm turning it back*."

"That's the whole thing? You just told each other?"

"Every time, Pipsqueak, forty-six years." He picks the pen back up. "Then we'd fight about it. Your mother likes sixty-two. She's wrong."

I sit there at the kitchen table on Garfield Avenue with my mother's gołąbki going cold on the plate and the teapot clock ticking eight minutes fast, and I take my phone out and scroll up through his texts. Past *I'm sorry. That's all of it*. Past *Northgate. Pruitt*. Up through two weeks of them to level three of the ramp, a phone number and a drawer and a password. My thumb gets tired before I reach the top.

And I went on television.

"Eat your gołąbki," my father says, and fills in another word.

At eight-thirty I'm standing in the eleventh-floor hallway of a building on Ionia Avenue that used to keep West Michigan supplied in ham, knocking on Simone Achterberg's door.

She opens it in the MSU ENGINEERING MOM sweatshirt with a roll of packing tape in her hand. Behind her, the boxes have multiplied. There are fourteen now, three new ones open in the middle of the floor and half full, and a roll of bubble wrap, and her lighthouse print in its frame leaning against the couch with a moving blanket over it.

"Pip," she says, and doesn't move out of the doorway.

"I'm sorry," I say.

I say it in the doorway, before she can ask me in, before I can plan it. I say it the way Adam said it to Gil Chamberlain in Monroe, with the worst of it in the first sentence.

"We had an arrangement, and you kept your half of it on the phone with Kurt while he called you a liar. I broke mine and left you there to answer for it. I'm sorry."

Simone stands in the doorway with the packing tape and turns the roll once around her finger, then again.

"Come in," she says finally. "Mind the bubble wrap."

I come in and mind the bubble wrap. She doesn't offer me wine this time. She puts the tape down on top of a box marked KITCHEN, MISC and leans against the steel counter with her arms crossed.

"I accept your apology," she says. "I do not accept many apologies. Most people apologize so that you will make them feel better. You did not do that. You just said it."

"I've been practicing on bankers all day. They're a tough room."

"I can tell. Your husband called me yesterday." She watches my face. "At ten in the morning. On a Sunday. He told me he was going to stop calling me at night, and he told me before he stopped." Her mouth gives up a quarter inch on one side, which on Simone is a grin. "Then he asked me if he could call Dave Haverhill and tell him I was exemplary. He asked, Pip. He used the word *can*."

“Did you let him?”

“Yes. I have an interview in Chicago on Thursday.” She looks at the lighthouse under its blanket. “I am not coming back. Let me be precise about why. I am not angry anymore. But I was the one he called in the dark, and as long as I am in that building, that is still a little bit true. You two should have the building.”

I pick the tape up off the KITCHEN box, because my hands want something to do, and start closing the half-full box nearest me.

“You may tape,” Simone says. “You may not label. You print like a welder.”

“I print like an engineer.”

“You print like an engineer who welds.” She lets me finish anyway, and she watches every strip go down.

I tape the box shut and stand there between the others with nothing left in my hands. *Thank you* feels wrong. She asked me not to say it, the last time, and I don’t think she’s changed her mind.

“Is there anything—” I start.

“Yes.” She unfolds her arms and goes to a box marked OFFICE, open on the floor, and takes out a folder. It’s green, which on Simone is practically a party hat. “There is a state fund for skilled-trades training at manufacturers with fewer than five hundred employees. It reimburses wages paid to trainees during certified training hours, and you qualify for the knee. I applied for you on Friday afternoon, after I resigned, between the bank and the bubble wrap. I put your name on it. You have to sign it by Wednesday.”

She hands me the folder. I open it. It’s the application, forty pages, filled out in her small level printing, every line. At the top of the first page, where it says *Program Contact*, she’s written *Philippa Sobczak, Co-Founder*.

At the bottom, in the box that says *Estimated Reimbursement*, she’s written six hundred and twelve thousand dollars.

“Simone, this is six hundred thousand dollars.”

“Six hundred and twelve. That takes you to one point seven,” Simone says. “You will not get one point seven from a bank in nine days. I know every bank in this state. You will have to get it from people.”

“Which people?”

She looks at me over her reading glasses the way she looked at the gauge on the test rig the first day, like I’m reading two percent high.

“I think you know which people,” she says. “I think you have been avoiding a box at the bottom of my column with a line through it. And I think there is a building full of people on Clyde Park Avenue who stood in a doorway in the snow and clapped for you, and who you still have not asked for anything.”

I hold the green folder against my chest. Fourteen cartons and a lighthouse under a moving blanket, and a woman in a sweatshirt who filled out forty pages for me in her small level printing after she’d already quit.

“How do I ask any of them? How do you ask people for something after you’ve spent so long deciding for them?”

Chapter 24 — Adam

Monday night a little after ten, sitting in Pip's chair in the room in the yard with the heater ticking, I write her a text and send it.

Tomorrow I'm driving to Chicago to see Northgate. I'm going to tell them the cash crisis was mine, Nashville, all of it. I'm going to sign a personal guarantee on top of the pledge, so if the company misses the test, my shares go first and everything else I own goes after them. In exchange I'm going to ask them to measure the covenant on the test date only, not every week, and to give the company first right to buy my shares if they call them, so they can't go to Halvard. I'm telling you before, not after. I'll be back tomorrow night.

It's read a minute later.

Nothing comes for nine minutes. I sit there with the phone face up on her desk on top of her graph paper and watch the three dots come up and go away and come back. I can picture her doing it, at the counter or on the couch in the front room where the wall is thicker, typing something and deleting it, then typing it again. She doesn't type long messages. She types like she tack-welds: short, and on to the next one.

Then it comes, two letters, *OK*, and that's all.

I don't know what kind of *OK* it is. Pip's got as many kinds of *OK* as her mother has kinds of pierogi, her brother Marek says, and you only find out which one you got when you bite into it.

A minute after that, a second one comes in.

Drive safe.

I set the phone down on the graph paper and put my hand over my eyes.

The emergency board was at two that afternoon. I'd sat at the far end of the walnut, across from her, the way I always do now. Ruth had wanted to call Kurt back, not to restart the deal but to *reopen a dialogue*. She'd said it in the public-radio voice. Kurt would come back, she said, at a lower number, seven hundred maybe. It was still a life-changing number, and it was a floor under all of us, under Northgate, under the crew, under her fund's firefighters in Toledo. *Pip*, she said, *I'm asking you to let me make one call.*

And Pip said, very quietly, "No."

And I said, a half-second after her, “No.”

Ruth had looked from one of us to the other, two people at opposite ends of a slab of walnut who hadn’t spoken to each other in three days, saying the same word in the same voice. Her eyebrows went up and stayed there, and she put her tablet down flat on the table.

“Well,” she said. “At least you’re aligned.”

I drive to Chicago on Tuesday at five in the morning in snow that turns to rain at Benton Harbor and back to snow at the Indiana line. I don’t listen to anything. I usually listen to podcasts about leadership, men with good microphones explaining how they built things, and I leave them off. I want to hear myself think, and what I get is the wipers and the trucks going by, and every few miles, her voice saying *drive safe*.

Diane calls at seven, just past Benton Harbor. I emailed her the two pages at midnight.

“Adam, you can’t do this,” she says, with no hello. “This is insane. This is an unlimited personal guarantee. Do you know what unlimited means? It’s the opposite of limited.”

“That’s why you got it at midnight, Diane, and not after.”

“After *what*? After you hand a bank in Chicago your car keys?” I can hear her kitchen behind her, a kid asking for something, a cupboard. “Fine. If you’re going to do something insane, you’re going to do it in the right language. Section two is garbage. Pull over at the next exit and I’ll read you section two.”

I pull over at a Speedway in Bridgman and she reads me section two, and fixes it, and then section four, while a man in a Carhartt jacket fills a pickup with diesel two feet from my window and looks at me in my suit like I’m lost.

“There,” Diane says, when section four’s done. “Now it’s insane in proper English. Drive safe.”

That’s two people this morning telling me to drive safe, and only one of them is a lawyer billing me for it.

Northgate Capital has the thirty-first floor of a black glass building on Wacker Drive, across the river from the Merchandise Mart. The river’s gray

today and full of ice. They're not dyeing it green for another six weeks. Neil Pruitt meets me at the elevator in a gray suit with a pin on his lapel shaped like a hockey stick. He shakes my hand with genuine warmth, a man glad to see a borrower he's going to have to hurt.

"Adam, you drove? In this weather?"

"I wanted to think."

"Well, I hope you thought of something." He laughs nervously. "Margaret's joining us, Margaret Oyelaran. She chairs credit committee. She doesn't usually come to these, but she wanted to see you."

Margaret Oyelaran is about sixty, Nigerian by way of Evanston, in a camel suit and glasses on a chain, with a legal pad in front of her and a fountain pen she doesn't uncap for the first ten minutes. We sit in a conference room with a view of the river. Neil offers coffee. I say no, and Margaret says nothing at all. Neil pours himself a cup anyway and never touches it, and by the end of the meeting it's grown a skin. She looks at me the way Simone looks at a spreadsheet she thinks is lying to her, patiently, waiting for the line that gives it away.

"Mr. Kerrigan," she says. "Neil tells me you asked for this meeting. You have counsel?"

"My counsel's on the phone in Grand Rapids, if you want her. She already fixed section two."

"You came without counsel in the room."

"I came to sign something, and I wanted to be in the room when I did."

Margaret uncaps the pen.

I don't give them the history. They have Gordon's reports; they can read. I tell them one thing they can't get from a spreadsheet: that Nashville was my idea, over my co-founder's objection, and the nine million went into it. That's all I say about it. Margaret watches me say it without blinking.

When I'm done, the room stays quiet long enough for a barge to go by on the river below, pushing ice.

"Why come in person?" Margaret says.

“Because I’m about to ask you to let me owe you more,” I say, “and that’s not a thing you ask for in an email.”

“More,” Margaret repeats, as if she’s tasting the word. “And what do you want for it, Mr. Kerrigan?”

I take the papers out of my bag. I spent an hour last night on the floor of her room with my laptop, writing it out like a letter instead of a deck, and Diane fixed the language at a gas station in Bridgman. Two pages. I slide them across the table.

“I’m offering a personal guarantee,” I say. “On top of the pledge. Unlimited. If the company misses the test on the twelfth and you call the loan, you take my shares first, and then you can come after everything else I own. My accounts, my car, my half of anything I’ve got. I won’t contest section eleven. I won’t fight you on the reading. I’ll sign it today.”

Neil makes a small sound, as if he’s bitten his tongue.

“In exchange,” I say, “two things. You measure the covenant on the twelfth, once, and not every week or on any other reporting date. And if you call the loan and take my shares, the company gets a right of first refusal to buy them back at your price within ninety days, before you sell them to anybody else. Anybody, including Minneapolis.”

Margaret reads the two pages all the way through, and then she reads them again, slower. Her pen doesn’t move.

“Your wife,” she says without looking up. “The co-founder. Does she know you’re here?”

“Yes, ma’am, she does.”

“Does she know what you’re offering?”

“Yes. I told her last night.”

“What did she say?”

“She said *OK*.”

Margaret looks up at me over her glasses, and one of her eyebrows goes up a sixteenth of an inch.

“And then?”

“Then she said *drive safe*.”

Margaret Oyelaran puts the cap back on her fountain pen. She sets it down on the legal pad, parallel to the edge. She looks out the window at the barge and the ice and the Merchandise Mart, and then she turns to Neil.

"Neil," she says. "How many borrowers in twenty-two years have come into this room and asked to owe us more?"

Neil thinks about it seriously.

"None that I can think of," he says.

"None." She turns back to me. "Mr. Kerrigan, this doesn't help you very much. Your shares are worth a great deal more than anything else you own. If the company fails, a personal guarantee from a man whose net worth is mostly in that company is a gesture."

"I know it is."

"Then why make it?"

"Because it's all I've got that's mine," I say. "Everything else was hers too. Or the crew's. Or the company's. This is just me. I don't have anything else to put on the table that I didn't take from somebody without asking."

Nobody in the room moves.

"The test date only," Margaret says finally. "Measured once, on the twelfth. I can do that. The right of first refusal, I can do that too, with a ninety-day window, at our price. Neil will paper it this afternoon." She uncaps the pen again and makes a note. "I'm not doing it because of your guarantee. I want that on the record. Your guarantee is a gesture."

"Then why are you doing it?"

"Because Gordon's report says your first escrow release, one point five million dollars, lands on Thursday, when your steel is cut. A lender who calls a loan the week its collateral starts producing cash is a lender who deserves what happens next." She caps the pen. "And because my committee would rather lend to a company where the founders say *no* to the same man in the same voice. Neil sent me the minutes from yesterday. Ruth Baskin's note at the bottom." Margaret almost smiles. "*At least they're aligned.*"

I sign a little after three-thirty with Neil's pen, which says NORTHGATE on the side and skips on every capital letter. Forty-one pages in October; nine

today. Neil walks me to the elevator. He keeps patting me on the shoulder like I've had a death in the family, which in a way I have. It's me, the man who had a plan for everything and a slide for the plan.

"Say hi to your wife," he says at the elevator. "And good luck with the knees."

I drive back in the dark. The snow's stopped. Michigan comes up out of Indiana flat and black and starry, and I don't turn on the radio, and somewhere around Paw Paw I look down and I'm doing eighty-five and humming. I don't know the song. It's something Polish. I've heard it through a wall.

I get to Clyde Park at 10:40 and text her from the church lot with the engine running.

Signed. Test date only, Friday the 12th. First refusal if they call. My shares go first. Everything else after.

I sit there while the dots come and go.

OK, she writes. Then: You're in the room?

I'm going in now. I'll be out before Benny.

The dots come and go, and then nothing, and then the dots again.

There's a blanket on the shelf, she writes. The good one. Not Darnell's. I brought it from home.

I read it three times in the dark car. Then I drive across the street and punch in her birthday, and the gate rolls back, and I cross the yard in the dark to the room with the light on.

On the shelf, on top of Darnell's blanket, sits her grandmother's afghan, every color of yarn Goodwill had in 1981, folded with the corners square.

Chapter 25 — Pip

I don't call Northgate.

That's the first thing I do on Wednesday morning: not call. I'm sitting at the counter at six with the moka pot going *blup* on the stove and my phone face up next to my mug, and Neil Pruitt's number is right there in the text from the parking ramp, and I could call it. I could call and say *this is Philippa Sobczak, I'm the wife, tell me exactly what he signed*. I could ask Diane to send me the nine pages. I could check up on my own husband.

I don't, because he told me what he was going to do, and then he did it, and then he told me he'd done it. That's my mother and the thermostat, every time for forty-six years. If I call to check, I'm saying it isn't enough.

It's enough, and it's so much more than enough I can't look at it straight on. *My shares go first. Everything else after*. I read it again standing at the stove, and I have to turn the burner off and hold onto the edge of the counter for a minute, the river one, the one he wanted.

Then I drink my coffee and go to work.

Wednesday I sign Simone's forty pages for the state at the kitchen table on Garfield Avenue, with my father watching over his reading glasses like a notary.

"You read it?" he says.

"Simone read it, Tato, and Simone wrote it."

"Read it anyway, Philippa." He slides the pen back across the oilcloth to me. "You don't sign what you didn't read. You don't need a door for that one. It's plain sense."

So I read all forty pages while my mother irons in the next room and says so through the doorway every few minutes, at nothing, and then I sign.

Thursday morning Gil Chamberlain's first trailer of tube comes in at six-forty, two hours early, because Gil's driver left Monroe at four to beat the snow. The knee line cuts steel for the first four hundred units by noon. Gordon calls at three, out of breath, from the stairwell where he takes calls he's afraid to have in the glass room.

“It released, Pip,” he says, without hello. “The escrow, the first tranche, one point five two. It’s in the operating account. It’s actually *there*. I can see it on the screen.”

“That’s good, Gordon. That’s really good.”

“I’ve been in finance for twenty-eight years, and I’ve never had a number do what it said it would on the day it said it would.” He breathes for a second. “My father would’ve liked your rule.”

“Your father was an accountant for the church.”

“That’s what I mean,” Gordon says, and hangs up, and I’m fairly sure the stairwell’s getting the rest of it.

By Thursday afternoon the math looks like this. I write it on the whiteboard in the break room myself, in my own handwriting, under Darnell’s count, *ROOMS SOLD SINCE PIP LIBERATED ONE: 7,804:*

HOLE: 2.3

STATE GRANT: -0.61

= 1.7

Under that, in a box:

SATURDAYS × 12 WKS + 2ND SHIFT TRAINING (KNEE) = FASTER CUT = FASTER ESCROW

CREW EQUITY: 5% OF CO. FROM PIP’S SHARES → TRUST → EVERYONE ON THE FLOOR

Under that, a smaller box, with nothing in it. I don’t write *NASH* in it. I don’t write anything in it. I just draw the box and leave it empty and step back with the marker still uncapped in my hand, and Lolo comes in for second shift and stands next to me and reads it too.

“Five percent of the company,” she says.

“From my third, Lolo, out of my own end.”

“That’s a lot of company, hon.”

“It’s a lot of Saturdays.”

She keeps reading the board. “You going to ask them?”

“Saturday at six, at shift change, with everybody on the floor from both shifts, and I’m going to put it to them.”

“Ask, or tell?”

“I’m going to ask, Lolo,” I say. “It’s a real vote, and if they say no, I don’t have a plan.”

Lolo nods slowly at the board. “I’m going to vote no, hon, like I told you.”

“I know you are, Lolo.”

“I’m going to stand up and say why.”

“I want you to stand up and say why.”

She looks at me sideways for a while. Then she reaches over and squeezes my arm, once, hard, the way she used to squeeze my father’s arm at Christmas when he did his impression of her, and goes off to punch in.

I stay and look at the empty box until the marker dries out in my hand.

At nine o’clock Thursday night I walk across the yard in the dark to my own room and knock on the glass with one knuckle.

The light’s on inside, and he’s at my desk with his laptop and Simone’s model open on the screen and a legal pad covered in his handwriting, which is terrible, big and slanted and full of arrows, a play drawn on a bar napkin. He looks up and finds me through the glass.

He gets up and opens the door. “Hi,” he says, and holds it.

“Hi. Can I come in, or is this a bad time?”

“It’s your room, Pip. You don’t have to ask.”

“I know it’s my room,” I say. “You’re in it, so I’m asking.”

He steps back out of the doorway. “Then yes, come in.”

I come in, and it’s warm, and it smells like cedar and the afghan, which is folded on the shelf, and like him, the soap he’s used since 2013 and something under it that’s just him, the way the inside of a truck smells like whoever drives it. There’s a sleeping bag rolled up in the corner under my desk, a toothbrush in a coffee mug on the windowsill, and two clean shirts on hangers on the coat hook by the door, the hook I screwed into the cedar in 2014, which has never held a shirt in its life.

“You moved in,” I say.

“I’m camping, which is different.”

“You’ve got a toothbrush in a mug.”

"I've got a toothbrush," he agrees.

"Who ironed those?" I nod at the shirts.

"Nobody. They're from the cleaner on Clyde Park, by the Wendy's. The woman at the counter thinks I'm in witness protection, and I haven't corrected her."

I sit down in the radiator chair, his chair, and he lets it go by. He sits down in my chair, at my desk, set at my height, and his knees come up, and we face each other across the corner of the desk in the light from the lamp.

"I'm putting it to the crew on Saturday at six," I say. "I'm telling you before I do it."

"I know. Lolo told me on her dinner break."

"Lolo came out here to tell you?"

"Lolo came by on her dinner break with a bowling ball. She said she was going to show me how to hold it." He rubs his face with both hands. "She talked the whole half hour, mostly about Florida. She's going to vote no."

"She told me that too."

"She told me you told her you wanted her to say why."

"I do want that," I say.

He sits with that, with his knees up and his hands hanging between them. "That's a good thing to want, Pip."

"Don't say that to her, she'll want it in writing."

That gets most of a smile out of him, and then it goes.

We sit there while the heater ticks. Outside, the yard light hums, and the snow's coming down again, slow and big, the soft kind.

And then, before I can think about it, before I can plan anything, he gets up out of my chair and comes around the desk. He doesn't stand over me. He gets down on the floor, on my mother's braided rug, on his knees, like a man about to fix the radiator, except he's facing me and not the radiator.

"I'm sorry," he says.

My hands are flat on my knees, and I keep them there.

"I'm sorry about Nashville. I'm sorry about the slide. I'm sorry I stood up in front of three hundred people and decided our life without you and then

kept talking because I was in the middle of a pitch. I'm sorry about the room. *You barely use it.* I said that to you in front of the whole floor, and I said it like a fact on a slide, and I knew what the room was. I was at the wedding. I made the speech." His voice doesn't break. It just gets very quiet, every word set down one at a time, like Simone's. "I'm sorry about Northgate. I'm sorry I didn't knock. I'm sorry I called her at one in the morning and told her the things I should have told you. I'm sorry about what I said at the counter. I'm sorry I knew you that well and used it."

He stops, still on his knees on the rug.

"And the calls," he says. "I told her they were work, and I told myself. Some were. Most of them were me sitting in the easiest room in my life, where nothing I said cost anything, and I liked it there, Pip. I liked talking to her more than I liked climbing the stairs. I knew what it was by the second month, and I kept dialing."

"You knew," I say.

"I knew, and that's mine."

"I'm not asking you for anything," he says, "and I'm not pitching. What you do with it is yours. I don't have a slide. I just wanted you to hear it in one place, all of it, before Saturday, in case Saturday goes wrong. Please. Please just know I know."

The room's so quiet I can hear the snow landing on the roof.

I've been waiting for this longer than I'd ever admit, and I didn't know it until he's on the floor in front of me saying it. I always thought when it came it would feel like winning. What it feels like is when you take a weld you've been holding with a clamp for an hour and finally open the clamp, and the two pieces stay together, and your hand doesn't know what to do now that it's not squeezing.

I don't say *I forgive you*. I don't know if I do yet. I leave it on the rug between us where he put it.

I ask him something instead. It's the thing I've wanted to ask since the elevator doors opened on four, with the ficus on my desk.

"Why did you give her the room?"

He doesn't answer right away. He looks past me at the door, at the three lines in pencil, and I watch him decide to tell me the true version and not the one he's practised.

"Because I couldn't walk past it," he says. "We got married in it. And then I stopped going in, after Nashville, and every time I came off the elevator it was sitting there in the corner with the lights off, and it was proof. Of what I'd done. Of what we'd turned into. So when Simone asked for a door that closes, I said yes before she finished, because then it wouldn't be dark anymore. Somebody would be in it. I'd walk past and the light would be on, and I could pretend that meant something." He swallows. "I told you you barely used it. I barely could look at it. I gave it away so I'd stop having to."

The room goes away. Not dark. Just away, as a room goes when you stand up too fast.

I'm crying. I didn't know I was going to. It comes up out of me with no sound at all, my face just wet, both hands flat on my knees, the way I sat at the walnut table with the receipts between them. I don't wipe it, and he doesn't reach for me. He stays on the rug on his knees and lets me.

"You gave away the room where we got married," I say, when I can, "so you wouldn't have to look at it."

"Yes."

"To a woman you called at one in the morning."

"Yes."

He doesn't add anything to either one. He doesn't explain, or soften it, or tell me she's a good person, which she is. He just kneels there on my mother's braided rug in a shirt he's worn two days, with his hair sticking up in the back where he slept on it on my floor, and lets both of those sit in the room with us, ugly and true and his.

When I can talk again, I say the only practical thing I can find.

"Get up off my mother's rug. You'll wreck your knees."

He laughs once, through his nose, and wipes his eyes with the heel of his hand, and doesn't get up yet.

"It's a good rug," he says.

Chapter 26 — Adam

On Friday morning at six, sitting in Pip's chair in the room in the yard with my knees up and the afghan around my shoulders, I call Odell Haynes in La Vergne, Tennessee.

He picks up on the first ring, because Odell gets up at four-thirty every day of his life, Christmas included, and says the hour before anybody else is awake is the only hour a plant manager owns.

"Boss," he says. "You're up early."

"I've been up since about four."

"That's not early, that's insomnia." I hear a coffee maker going in the background, and a dog. "What can I do for you?"

I've been awake since about two, on the floor under the afghan, looking at the cedar ceiling.

"Odell," I say, "I'm going to tell you something before I do it, and then I'm going to ask you something. Is that all right?"

There's a pause, and in the background the coffee maker stops.

"Go ahead," Odell says.

"Tomorrow morning at six, Pip's putting a plan to the crew at Clyde Park, both shifts, a vote. It's the plan that keeps the company alive without Halvard, and it's a good plan, and it's got a hole in it, and the hole's about a million seven. She's filling it with Saturdays: twelve weeks of six-day weeks, and five percent of the company from her own shares to the crew for doing it." I take a breath. "There's another way to fill the hole. She left it off the board on purpose, because it's mine."

Odell lets that sit. He's known since the day I sat in his glass box and he told me what happens on a Friday.

"I'm going to stand up tomorrow in front of her crew," I say, "and disagree with her. I'm going to say don't take their Saturdays. Close Nashville."

The dog barks once in the background, somewhere in Murfreesboro.

"I'm not deciding it," I say. "The crew decides tomorrow, and Pip decides if she'll take it. But if it goes that way, you'll know first, and you won't hear it in a parking lot."

There's nothing on the line but Odell breathing, and the dog's tags jingling somewhere near the phone.

"Okay," he says finally. "What's the question?"

"What do you think?"

That's the whole question. I picked the site and the architect and the consultant from Detroit and the color of the floor epoxy, and I gave a speech on a scissor lift, and in fourteen months I didn't ask the man who runs the place whether it should be there.

Odell laughs, long and tired, the laugh of somebody who has been up since four-thirty for thirty years.

"I think about time, boss," he says. "I think it should've been in October. I think you knew it in October." The coffee maker starts again. "But you're asking, so here's the rest: Kiana, Terrell, Lynette on paint, Darius, the big kid on framing. They're good, the best I ever had. You tell your wife if she needs thirty people to learn the knee, she could do worse than sixty people who already know how to build her rooms, just the wrong way."

I sit there in her chair with the phone against my ear. "They'd move?"

"Some would, and Kiana would. She told me last week, she said, *Mr. Haynes, if they ever close us, I'm going to Michigan to learn the one with no post*. She said it as a joke, and she wasn't joking." He pauses. "You want me to ask them?"

"Yes," I say. "Ask them tonight, please."

"Please," Odell says, turning the word over like he's checking the bottom for a price tag.

"I'm trying it out this week."

"Well, try it faster," Odell says. "I've got a dog to walk."

I hang up and sit with the phone in my hand, looking out the glass corner at the yard going from black to gray, the maples on Clyde Park coming up out of the dark one branch at a time. Just before seven, Benny's Silverado comes down the street with its one bad headlight and turns in at the gate.

I'm still in the room. I said I'd be out before Benny, and I've been out before Benny every morning for a week.

He parks by the dumpsters and gets out and stands there with his lunch cooler, looking across the yard at the room with the light on and me in it, in Pip's chair with an afghan around my shoulders like an old woman at a bus stop.

He doesn't come over. He lifts his chin at me, once, the way Irene lifts hers, and goes into the plant.

I take the afghan off and fold it with the corners square.

At ten I'm in the glass room on four with Gordon and the model, and I can't concentrate, and Gordon can tell. He keeps glancing at me over his laptop and then back at the screen, as if the spreadsheet might tell on me.

"You're going to do it," he says finally.

I keep my eyes on the spreadsheet and say, "Do what?"

"Nashville, tomorrow." He wipes his palms on his cardigan, one and then the other. "I ran it last night, after Simone's model. I put Nashville in the empty box at the bottom, Pip's empty box. Two levers. Stop the line Monday and you don't spend a week of Nashville, four hundred and twenty thousand, before the test on Friday. And the forty finished Lites sitting in their yard, the campground people in Gatlinburg have been asking about them since November; that's the rest of the hole over twelve weeks. You're above six million on the twelfth by about one week of Nashville. Without a single Saturday. Saturdays make the twelve weeks faster. You wouldn't need them for Friday."

"I know. I ran it at three this morning on a legal pad, and my version was uglier."

"I didn't tell her. I thought—" He stops and looks down at the laptop. "I thought you should."

"I'm going to tell her tonight, at the house." I close the laptop lid on my side. "And Gordon, don't tell anybody else. Not Ruth, not the board, nobody, until she's heard it from me."

"Who would I tell?" He looks genuinely wounded. "Ruth's going to send you a fruit basket when she hears, you know. She's been asking you to close it since August."

“Then Ruth can hear it Monday with everybody in La Vergne, and she can send the basket to Odell.”

Gordon nods slowly, the way he nods at a column that finally reconciles. Then he does a thing I’ve never seen Gordon Pyle do in six years: he reaches across the table and puts his hand on my arm for about a second, as if my arm might be hot.

“My father,” he says, “used to say that the hardest number in any budget is the one you put in yourself.”

“Your father did the books for a church, Gordon.”

“He was very wise about money,” Gordon says. “He was terrible at everything else.”

At seven-thirty that night I drive to the house on College Avenue, which I haven’t seen in a week.

Her truck’s in the drive and the kitchen light’s on. I park on the street, because the drive feels like a thing you’re asked into. I walk up the front steps instead of going round to the back door, and stand on the porch under the light in the cold, and I ring my own doorbell.

I hear her come down the hall: the good stairs, the ninth one, then the floorboards in the front hall that we never fixed. The porch light goes brighter and the door opens.

She’s in my Grand Valley sweatshirt with her hair down, holding a dish towel.

“You rang the doorbell,” she says.

“I don’t live here right now.”

“You have a key.”

“I know, and I’m not using it.” I stand there with my hands in my coat pockets. “I have a before.”

She studies me from the doorway, then steps back. “Come in, it’s cold.”

“I’d like to say it out here, if that’s all right, because it’s short.”

She folds the dish towel over her arm, slowly, and leans on the door frame, and waits.

“Tomorrow at the vote,” I say, “I’m going to stand up in front of your crew and disagree with you. I’m going to tell them to keep their Saturdays and close my plant instead.”

Nothing moves in her face. It’s the face she gives a building inspector, and I’ve learned there’s everything behind it, held still so it doesn’t spill. My breath goes up in a cloud between us in the porch light.

“You left it off the board for me,” I say. “Gordon told me, and the whiteboard told me. I saw the box with the line through it. You left Nashville off because it’s the only thing in the company that’s mine, and you didn’t want to be the one who turned the lights off. That’s the kindest thing anybody’s done for me in years, and it’s the wrong decision. I wanted you to hear it from me tonight, on your own porch, so you’re not alone with it when I say it tomorrow.”

Pip turns the towel over on her arm and doesn’t answer right away.

“Why in front of the crew?” she says. “Why not just tell me now, and I’ll change the board, and we do it my way?”

“Because then you’d be right about Nashville in private again, and I’d be wrong in private again, and nobody would ever have to hear me say it.” I take my hands out of my pockets. “It’s my plant, so it should be my mistake to end, out loud, in front of the people whose Saturdays it’s saving. And you should get to say no to me in front of them, if you want to.”

Down the hall behind her, the kitchen radiator knocks twice, and she says, “Okay.”

“Okay meaning yes, or okay meaning go away?”

“Okay meaning I heard you. I’m not saying yes.” She unfolds the dish towel and folds it again, the other way. “You told me first, and I’ll decide tomorrow, in the room, with everybody. That’s what I’m putting to them. I can’t ask them to decide in front of me if I’ve already decided in my kitchen.”

“That’s fairer than I was.”

“It’s not fair, it’s just how it is.” She looks past me at the street, at my car parked at the curb instead of in the drive. “You parked on the street.”

“The drive felt like a thing you get asked into.”

Her nose wrinkles, once, which means she's decided not to laugh at something.

"Have you eaten?" she says.

"I had a cruller around ten."

"A cruller isn't dinner, Adam." She goes back down the hall without closing the door, and I stand on my own porch and listen to the freezer open and shut, and she comes back with a foil package the size of a brick and puts it in my hands. It's cold and heavy and it crackles. "My mother sent forty. She thinks you're living in a shed."

"I am living in a shed."

"Don't tell her that or she'll send forty more."

"There's no stove in the shed."

"Then you'll eat them cold, the way my uncles do at a wake." She steps back inside, one hand on the door. "Go back to the room and sleep, you look terrible."

"I've been sleeping on your floor."

"I know, you've got a sleeping bag and a toothbrush and two shirts on my coat hook. The shirts are wrinkled, Adam. Tomorrow you're standing up in front of a hundred and forty people who iron for church."

"Then I'll iron them tonight."

"You don't know how to iron."

"Then I'll be wrinkled," I say, "and right."

She stands in the half-open door a while longer, with the porch light on her face and the hall light behind her.

"Six a.m.," she says. "Don't be late."

Chapter 27 — Pip

Near midnight on Friday, second shift goes home, and I'm sitting in the break room at Clyde Park under the fluorescent lights with a cup of vending-machine hot chocolate and the whiteboard.

At shift change this is the loudest room in the building, lockers banging, the microwave going, Benny telling a story about a deer. Now it's empty, the chairs pushed in crooked, a Marge's box on the counter with one cruller in it that nobody had the nerve to take. The only sound is the vending machine humming and the clock over the door, which has run four minutes slow for as long as I've worked here.

Darnell's the last one out. He stops in the door with his coat half on, frowns at the board, and comes back in.

"Hang on, I didn't do the count," he says.

He uncaps the red marker, wipes out yesterday's number, writes the new one in his blocky capitals and stands back to check it the way he checks a pallet tag.

ROOMS SOLD SINCE PIP LIBERATED ONE: 7,912.

"A hundred and eight since yesterday," he says, and reads down the rest of the board, the numbers I wrote Thursday and the box under them. "You want me to roll this out on the floor tomorrow, so everybody can see it?"

"Five-thirty," I say, "if you can."

"Nevaeh's teething, so I'll be up at four anyway. Nobody in my house sleeps." He caps the marker and puts it back on the tray, and then he points at the empty box with his chin. "What goes in there?"

"I don't know yet, Darnell."

"Then I'll bring an eraser," he says, and goes.

The rest of the board is as I left it Thursday: the hole, the grant, the Saturdays, the five percent.

And under that is the box, a square I drew in blue marker on Thursday afternoon and didn't put anything in. I've been staring at it for an hour.

Lolo comes in ten minutes later with her coat on and her bowling bag in her hand, because the Spare Parts have a makeup match at midnight against the Bedpans. She sees me at the table and stops in the door.

“Hon,” she says, “you sleep here now too? Is this a family thing?”

“I’m thinking, Lolo, that’s all.”

“Thinking’s for the daytime. At night it’s called worrying.” Her eyes go from me to the board and back.

“He’s going to stand up tomorrow and tell them to close Nashville instead,” I say.

“I know, hon. Everybody knows.” She sets the bowling bag down on the floor, very carefully, and pulls out a chair across from me and sits in it sideways, with one arm over the back. “Adam texted Gordon from your curb that he’d told you. Ten minutes later Gordon’s in line at the Meijer pharmacy and Darnell’s wife’s sister is behind him, and he’d been holding it in since ten this morning, so he told her. She told Darnell’s wife, Darnell’s wife told me, and I’d guess Benny and Irene and half the Bedpans by now.”

“Darnell was just here doing the count, and he didn’t say a word.”

“Darnell’s wife hasn’t told Darnell. She tells him things in the morning, when he’s too tired to argue.” Lolo squints at the board. “Gordon waited till you’d heard, though. You have to give him that. He does what he’s told to the letter, and not one letter past it.”

“He rang the doorbell,” I say. “Adam did.”

“The doorbell,” Lolo says, and makes the noise, the ketchup-on-pierogi noise. “Eleven years that man’s had a key.” She looks back at the board. “Nashville, then,” she says, like it’s a split she’s been left with. “And the five percent goes where?”

“Still to the crew, if I still want it to.”

“Do you want it to?”

“Yes,” I say, and I don’t have to think about it.

Lolo nods slowly and studies the empty box. “So what are you going to do, hon?”

I put the hot chocolate down. It's gone cold, though that machine's been making hot chocolate the temperature of a bath since 2017. Lolo takes the last cruller out of the Marge's box like it's owed to her, tears it in two and puts the bigger half in front of me on a napkin.

"I don't know," I say. "If I take it, sixty people in Tennessee lose their jobs over a box I drew. If I don't, I'm asking all of you for twelve weeks of Saturdays I might not need." I pull the napkin closer. "What would you do?"

Lolo chews her half of the cruller. Then she brushes the sugar off her fingers, one palm against the other, slowly, and I wait for whatever she's going to say that I'll need, because since I was a kid on a bucket by the welders, Lolo's always had it.

"No," she says, and folds her arms on the back of the chair.

"What do you mean, no?"

"No, I'm not telling you. You don't get my advice tomorrow, hon, you get my vote, and my vote's no, I told you that. I'm voting for Florida."

"Okay, but hypothetically," I say, "if it were Darnell sitting here asking ____"

"Hypothetically, I'd tell Darnell to go home to his baby." She puts one hand flat on the table between us, next to the napkin. "I love you, and you know I love you. I've known you since you had braces and a stick welder you held upside down. But I'm not your dad, and I'm not your priest, and I'm not your husband. I'm a second-shift lead who wants a lanai. If I sit here and tell you what to do, then tomorrow when I stand up and vote against you, everybody's going to think I'm voting against my own advice, and you're going to think I'm the one who decided. You've had enough goddamn people deciding for you, him with his slides and you with yourself." She takes her hand back. "I'm going to stand up tomorrow and say *Pip, I want the pool, here's why*, with everybody listening, the way you asked me to. That's what I can give you, and that's all of it."

The vending machine hums. Her phone goes off in her coat pocket and she reads the screen at arm's length.

“Dolores,” she says. “They’re starting without me. She wants to know if she can bowl anchor.” She types with one finger, taking her time over it, and puts the phone away. “I said over my dead body. And I’m calling Marge at four for crullers, and you can’t stop me. A crew votes better with sugar in it.”

It’s right, all of it, and I know it the way you know a square joint when you run your thumb down it, no lip, no gap. She wants Florida, and tomorrow, in front of everybody, she’s going to ask for it out loud.

“Okay,” I say, and I eat my half of the cruller.

Lolo picks up her bowling bag and goes out, and the door swings shut behind her on its slow closer. Her boots go off across the dark plant, past the press brake, and then there’s the side door, and her Buick in the lot coughing twice before it catches.

I sit there until the hot chocolate grows a skin.

Then I take out my phone. Lolo won’t tell me what to do, so I do the one thing I can do before morning.

Tomorrow, say it, I write to Adam. Nashville. Whatever you’re going to say. I won’t cut you off in front of them. I’m telling you tonight so you don’t stand there wondering.

It’s read before I put the phone down. The dots come once, and go, and come back.

Okay, he writes. And then: Thank you for telling me. And then, a minute later: Gordon told the Meijer pharmacy. I’m sorry. I said not until you’d heard.

He waited until I’d heard, I write back. Lolo’s giving him credit for it.

Don’t tell him. He’ll have it framed.

Then I get up, take the blue marker off the tray under the whiteboard and uncap it. I stand in front of the empty box with the marker in my hand and think about writing something in it: *NASH*, or *NO*, or a question mark, neat, in the corner, as Simone would.

I don’t write anything, and I put the cap back on.

Tomorrow I'll stand in front of this board with a hundred and forty people and my husband in a wrinkled shirt, and somebody's going to write in that box, and for once I don't know who.

Then I take the cap back off, and leave the marker on the tray, uncapped, where anyone can reach it.

Chapter 28 — Pip

Just before six on Saturday morning there are a hundred and forty-one people standing on the floor of the Clyde Park plant, and none of them are working, and the only machine running is the coffee urn.

Darnell rolled the whiteboard out of the break room at five-thirty. It's on its wheeled stand in the open space between the knee line and the glazing table, where we stage finished walls before they go to the roof cassette line, the one patch of floor big enough to hold everybody, and there's a new eraser on the tray, still in its plastic. "Brought it," Darnell says when he catches me looking, and taps it with one finger.

Both shifts are here. First shift came in early and second shift never went home, or went home and came back. They're standing in a ragged half-circle in their coats and hoods and safety glasses, holding paper cups, some of them in their church clothes underneath their Carhartts because it's Saturday and half of them have a baptism or a funeral or a kid's hockey game after this. It smells like coffee and cold air and the sawdust that never quite leaves the roof line, and Marge's crullers, eleven boxes of them on a pallet by the time clock, because Lolo called Marge at four and Marge opened early.

I'm standing next to the whiteboard with the blue marker in my hand, and I didn't sleep.

Tavi's at the edge of the crowd in his Carhartt with his phone out. He sees me looking and looks down at the phone, and then he puts it in his pocket, both hands, like he's putting away something hot.

Gordon's here, though I didn't ask him. He's standing by the coffee urn in his cardigan holding his laptop flat against his chest, sweating already though it's forty-eight degrees in here. He catches my eye and lifts one hand off the laptop, half a wave, half a kid about to be called on in class.

And at the back, by the time clock, under the old schoolhouse clock that runs four minutes slow, there's my husband.

He's in a white shirt, and it's wrinkled, so wrinkled it looks like he slept in it, which he did, on the floor of my room under my grandmother's afghan. There's no tie and no jacket, and his hair's wet from the shower in the locker

room, which he's never used in nine years, and which smells like Lava soap and nickel. He's standing by himself with his hands at his sides, which he never does. Adam stands in rooms with his hands doing things: holding a coffee, holding a clicker, holding a man's elbow.

He finds me across a hundred and forty heads, and he doesn't smile. He nods, once.

The schoolhouse clock says 5:56, which means it's six.

"Okay," I say, and it goes quiet in waves, from the front to the back, people shushing people, Benny saying *hey, hey* to the kids from glazing, until it's so quiet I can hear the coffee urn ticking as it heats.

"I'm going to tell you the worst of it," I say. "Then I'm going to put something to you, and you're going to decide it, not me."

Nobody moves.

"The company's almost out of money," I say. "The company, not the plant; you made four hundred and fifty knees last quarter and every one of them's perfect, Irene checked." Somebody laughs, a short nervous laugh. Irene doesn't. "In October we almost missed a payroll, and Adam borrowed nine million dollars against his own shares so you'd get paid on a Friday and never find out."

A murmur goes through the floor. I keep my eyes off the back and keep going.

"Then I went on Channel 6 and told Minneapolis no, and I didn't tell any of you first." I look at the floor for a second, the concrete, the old paint lines from when this was a cabinet plant, worn almost to nothing. "Benny, I told you *nobody's selling this plant* in January, and I didn't know if that was true. I decided what you could carry, and I'm sorry. That's the worst of it."

The floor's very quiet. Benny's got his arms crossed over his Carhartt, and he nods once, slowly, as if he's signing for a part that came back from a supplier with a defect and a note.

"Here's what's true now," I say, and I turn to the board. "We've got seven thousand nine hundred people who put money down on a room with no post in the corner. That money's in a bank in Cleveland, and every time we cut steel

for one of them, ten percent comes loose. Gil Chamberlain in Monroe gave us sixty days on steel. The glass houses gave us forty-five, and the state's paying for us to train a second shift on the knee. Simone did that, before she left." I tap the numbers. "We've got a hole of one point seven million dollars, and we've got six days. Next Friday a bank in Chicago looks at our cash, and if we're under six million, they take Adam's shares and the whole thing starts over without us."

I put the marker on the line that says *SATURDAYS* × 12 WKS.

"So here's what I'm putting to you: twelve weeks of six-day weeks, training a second shift on the knee while you're still welding it. Faster cuts, faster escrow, out of the hole. And for it, five percent of this company, out of my own shares, into a trust that belongs to everybody standing on this floor, a piece of the room."

For a second nobody says anything, and then, from the left, by the glazing table, a hand goes up.

It's Hector, the nineteen-year-old from glazing, in a Detroit Lions hoodie under his coat.

"What's five percent of a unicorn?" he says.

"About as much as you'd get from a unicorn," says Benny, before I can answer, and people laugh, and it breaks something loose.

They ask questions, a lot of them. Darnell asks if the paint booth can run two shifts without a new filter, and I say no, and he says he figured, and writes something on his hand.

Irene doesn't raise her hand. She just talks, same as across the glazing table. "Holland's at five weeks on the big lites. You run twelve weeks of Saturdays, we're out of glass in week four."

"Grand Rapids Glass will do three weeks if we pay for the truck."

"Then pay for the truck," Irene says, and nods, and that's her question done.

A woman from the roof line in a Griffins toque puts her hand halfway up. "Are the Saturdays paid?" she says.

"They're paid at straight time," I say.

“Straight time,” she says back to me, in a voice that tells me exactly what she thinks of straight time on a Saturday, and the people around her laugh the way you laugh in a dentist’s chair. “My boy’s got hockey at seven on Saturdays. Who drives him, you?”

“If you can’t do a Saturday, I need to know it today,” I say, “and not in week six, when I’ve got a frame on the jig and nobody to weld it.”

She thinks about that, and nods, and puts her hand back in her pocket, and the man next to her, who I’m fairly sure is the hockey player’s father, studies the ceiling like there’s a leak in it.

From the back somebody calls, “And if it doesn’t work?”

“Then I don’t know,” I say. In nine years I haven’t said that to this crew, and it comes out easier than I thought it would.

I look along the half-circle and say, “Anybody else?”

Lolo stands up.

She’s been sitting on an upturned five-gallon bucket at the front, the way I used to sit by my father’s welder, in her bowling jacket, SPARE PARTS across the back in iron-on letters that have given up. She stands slowly, one hand on her knee, takes her glasses off and lets them fall on their chain.

“Pip,” she says, “I’m a no.”

The floor goes completely still.

“Minneapolis is gone, I know. The pool went with it. But you all heard her: if this doesn’t work, a bank in Chicago gets his shares, and a bank sells to whoever’s got a checkbook, and maybe Minneapolis comes back with one.” She looks around at everybody, slowly, the whole half-circle. “I’d rather bet on a checkbook than on twelve weeks of my knees. I’m sixty-three. That’s not a speech, that’s arithmetic. I’ll train your new people either way. But my hand’s going up for no, and I wanted her to see it go up from right here, not hear about it from Benny.”

“I wouldn’t have told her,” says Benny.

“You’d have told her before lunch,” says Lolo, and sits back down on her bucket.

Nobody says anything. Lolo looks at the board instead of at me, and I want to say something to her, but there isn't anything to say that isn't *thank you*, and she'd hate it, so I keep my mouth shut.

"Is there anybody else who wants to talk?"

At the back, by the time clock, a hand goes up.

It goes up slowly, the way a kid's hand goes up in school when he isn't sure he's allowed, and a hundred and forty people turn around to look.

"Can I?" Adam says.

"Go ahead," I say, over all their heads.

He doesn't come up to the front. He stays where he is, at the back, under the schoolhouse clock, in his wrinkled shirt, so that everybody has to turn around to look at him, and he doesn't move to make that easier. He puts his hands in his pockets, then takes them out again.

"I disagree with her," he says.

Something goes through the floor, boots shifting on the concrete, a thermos lid squeaking.

"Not about the plan; the plan's the best thing anybody's done in this company since she drew the knee on a napkin. I disagree about the Saturdays." He's talking to me, not to them. "That box at the bottom has an answer, and it isn't on the board because the answer's mine." He takes a breath. "Close Nashville."

Somebody near the front says *oh*.

"Nashville loses four hundred and twenty thousand dollars a week," Adam says. "Gordon sends me the number every Friday."

"It's true," Gordon says from the coffee urn, too loud, and then, quieter, to the people turning to look at him, "I ran it three times."

"Course you did, Gordon," Lolo says from her bucket, and Gordon goes red down into his cardigan.

"Here's one you haven't heard," Adam says. "There are forty finished rooms in the yard in La Vergne right now, under blue tarps, with a post in every corner. Nobody's bought one since November. There's a camera on that

yard, and I've had it on my phone since Christmas. When I can't sleep, I sit up and look at them. Then I go back to bed and let the line build another one."

Nobody laughs at that. Irene takes her eyes off the board and puts them on him, and keeps them there.

"If we stop the Nashville line Monday, the box is full, and you don't need Saturdays to make the test," he says. "If you want to work Saturdays, work them, at time and a half, like it says on the wall. But you shouldn't have to work them to pay for my mistake."

"It's sixty jobs," I say.

It comes out of me before I've planned it, loud enough for the back row, like a weld spitting.

"I know it's sixty jobs," he says, and he doesn't look away.

"There's a girl down there who learned to read prints at a Wendy's."

"Her name's Kiana, and Odell called her last night. Twenty-three of them said they'd move up here to learn the knee, if you'll train them, and Kiana was the first one."

"You can't just decide that—"

"I'm not deciding it. They are." He opens a hand at the floor, at all of them. "And so are you." Then he turns to the room. "She told me it was wrong," he says, plainly, to all of them. "She said it to Gordon the night before I announced it, and Gordon said it to me, and I went ahead the next morning anyway. She was right, and you should hear me say it."

"You didn't have to say it here."

"Yes," he says, "I did."

In front of a hundred and forty people, at six in the morning, across the whole floor of the plant, my husband and I are arguing, and nobody's stepping in, and nobody's leaving. We haven't had a fight in front of anybody since the all-hands. We went into separate rooms and filed things. This one's out loud, with everybody listening, and he isn't pitching and I'm not handling it, and my hand is steady on the marker.

"If we close Nashville," I say slowly, "the five percent still goes to the trust."

“It should go anyway,” he says. “They should’ve had it from the start.”

“And Saturdays are voluntary, at time and a half.”

“Time and a half,” he says.

“And whoever comes up from Tennessee gets trained on the knee and gets a place on second shift.”

“If you’ll train them,” he says.

“I’m not training them,” I say, “Lolo is.”

From her bucket, without turning around, Lolo says, “Not for free I’m not.”

The whole floor laughs. It goes through them like a wind through a field, and some of the tension goes with it, and Adam stands at the back with his hands at his sides, laughing too, short and surprised at himself.

I turn back to the board.

The box is empty and the blue marker’s in my hand, and every eye in the building is on the back of my neck.

He’s the CEO. He could’ve called Odell yesterday and pulled the plug and sent a memo. He told me on the porch, in the cold, and then he came here and said it out loud, and then he stopped talking and left the box where it is.

I uncap the marker and write in the box, four letters, in capitals, in my handwriting.

NASH.

Then I turn around to face them.

“I’m taking it,” I say. “His amendment.” I put the cap on the marker. “That’s my decision, and if you hate it, hate me for it, not him. So here’s the plan, with the amendment. Nashville’s line stops Monday. Saturdays are voluntary, time and a half. Second shift trains on the knee, and anybody from Tennessee who wants to come is welcome. Five percent of the company from my shares goes into a trust for everybody on this floor. We build every one of those rooms here, with no post. That’s what we’re voting on.”

A hundred and forty-one faces look back at me: Irene, Darnell, who named his daughter after heaven backwards, Hector in his Lions hoodie, Benny, Lolo on her bucket.

“All in favor,” I say.

The hands go up in ones and twos, like the first knees coming off the line in the morning, slow, every one of them checked. Irene’s is first, flat palm, no hesitation. Then Darnell’s, and then Tavi’s, way at the back, both hands, until he looks around and puts one down. The woman from the roof line who said *straight time* puts hers up, and Hector, and then more, then a lot, rising up out of the coats and hoods across the whole floor, quiet, no cheering, just hands.

Darnell counts, walking the half-circle with his lips moving and his finger pointing, as if he’s counting pallets, and nobody puts a hand down while he does it, and the coffee urn ticks, and the schoolhouse clock moves a minute.

“Opposed,” I say.

Lolo’s hand goes up from her bucket, straight up, firm. She doesn’t look at me.

Benny’s goes up too, and he shrugs at me across the floor. “I don’t like change, boss, it’s nothing personal,” he says.

“I know it isn’t, Benny.”

More hands go up, more than I’d like: old-timers from Lindqvist, who’ve seen plants close and plants saved and don’t trust either one. Darnell counts them too.

He goes to the whiteboard and takes the marker out of my hand without asking, which is the most Darnell thing he’s ever done, and under the box with *NASH* in it, he writes the tally in his blocky numbers.

YES: 97

NO: 41

ABSTAIN: 3

He caps the marker and hands it back to me.

A hundred and forty-one people stand on the concrete in the cold and read the numbers. Irene reads them twice. Somebody near the back blows on their coffee. Lolo, on her bucket, looks at the forty-one and then at me, and nods once, and goes back to her coffee.

Then Benny uncrosses his arms, walks over to the press brake, and turns it on. The hydraulics hum up, and he looks back over his shoulder at everybody.

“Well,” he says. “We got knees to make.”

Chapter 29 — Pip

He goes to Nashville on Sunday morning, and he tells me a day ahead.

He tells me Saturday at noon, in the yard, standing by the room while the knee line runs behind us for the first voluntary Saturday in the history of the company. Sixty-eight people stayed. I counted them on my fingers against my leg, though I didn't mean to; I count things when I'm afraid of what they mean.

"Odell's bringing them in Monday morning at shift start," Adam says. "He offered to tell them himself, with me beside him."

"What did you say?"

"I said it's my plant, so I'll tell them, and he can stand next to me." He stops and works out the rest, the way he works through a term sheet. "Then they ask me whatever they want, as long as they want, and I answer it."

"You talked for four minutes this morning in front of a hundred and forty people."

"Three minutes forty, Gordon timed it." He looks at the plant, at the open rolling door, at the yellow curtains on the knee line glowing with the arcs behind them.

"Can I hear it?" I say. "If they don't mind."

"I'll ask them first." He puts his hands in his coat pockets. "I'll be back Monday night, late. I'll text you when I land."

"Text me when you take off, too."

"Both ends of the flight," he says.

He flies out of Grand Rapids early on Sunday morning. From the gate he texts me a photo of a de-icing truck spraying a regional jet orange, and under it: *Boarding. Didn't sleep. Odell says bring a tie. I don't own a tie that isn't for a pitch.*

I text back: *Wear the wrinkled shirt.*

On Monday morning, the eighth, the morning Nashville's line stops, I'm at the plant at five-thirty, and I don't go to my bench or to the room. I stand in the break room with a cup of vending-machine hot chocolate gone lukewarm, looking at the whiteboard. Darnell's tally is still up, YES: 97, NO: 41,

ABSTAIN: 3, and above it his count: *ROOMS SOLD SINCE PIP LIBERATED ONE*: 8,206.

Benny comes in at six with his lunch cooler, and Irene behind him with her thermos.

"Is it today, down in Tennessee?" Benny says.

"Eight o'clock our time," I say. "Seven theirs."

Irene unscrews her thermos lid and pours without looking. "Where are twenty-three people going to live? You can't put twenty-three people from Tennessee in that room in the yard. Your husband barely fits."

"I don't know yet."

Benny sets his cooler on the counter. "My cousin's got two duplexes off Clyde Park, empty since October. He complains about it every Wigilia, right through the fish."

"Would he rent to them?"

"He'd rent to a raccoon if it paid first and last." Benny opens the cooler and looks into it like there might be a better lunch in there today. "I'll call him. He owes me for a transmission."

He calls right there from the counter, and I get one side of it, mostly Polish, mostly swearing, and when he hangs up he says, "Two duplexes, sixteen beds, and he wants a reference from you. Gordon can get the rest a rate at the motel on Twenty-Eighth Street."

"From me?"

"He says he don't rent to Tennesseans without a priest or a Sobczak vouching."

At two minutes to eight my phone rings, and it's Adam.

"They said yes," he says, low. "Kiana said let your wife listen, then nobody can tell her it went different." I hear boots on concrete behind him, a lot of them, and a forklift backing up. "I'm putting you in my shirt pocket."

I set the phone face up on the counter and turn it all the way up. Benny and Irene lean in on either side of me. There's rustling, then Odell's voice, farther off: "All right, everybody. The boss."

“Good morning,” Adam says. He sounds close and very tired. “The line stops today. This is the last shift in this building, and it’s my decision and my fault. It isn’t Odell’s, and it isn’t yours. You built what I asked you to build, and you built it right, and I asked for the wrong thing. I’m going to stand here and answer whatever you ask me until you run out.”

For a second there’s nothing but the skylights humming. Then a woman’s voice, young, near the front.

“Mr. Kerrigan. Did you know in October?”

“Yes, Kiana,” Adam says.

Irene, beside me, puts her thermos down.

“Then why’d we keep building them?”

“Because closing it meant standing up somewhere and saying I was wrong,” he says, “and I didn’t want to. That’s the whole reason. There isn’t a better one.”

A man’s voice, farther back: “What happens to the forty in the yard?”

“Gordon’s selling them to a campground in Gatlinburg. You’ll see them from the interstate.”

“The ones who go up to Michigan,” Kiana says. “Who trains us?”

“A woman named Lolo, who voted against all of this. She’ll be the hardest boss you ever had, and she doesn’t like me much.”

Somebody down there laughs, and then more of them, and Benny laughs at the counter too, into his collar.

It goes on for most of an hour. Benny goes out once to start the press brake and comes back. Irene’s coffee goes cold in the lid. I don’t take the phone off the counter, and Adam doesn’t stop answering, even the ones he has to answer with *I don’t know, I’ll find out today and call you myself*.

When it’s over, a photo comes from a number I don’t know: the floor in La Vergne, the long white skylights, sixty people in gray T-shirts in a half-circle, and Adam at the front in the wrinkled shirt with one hand open, talking, and Odell beside him with his hands behind his back. *Mr. Haynes asked me to send you this. He’s doing ok. — Kiana*

Benny reads it over my shoulder. “He looks like he’s at a wake,” he says. “Good. That’s the right face for it.”

At noon Gordon texts me, which he has never done: *Ruth sent a fruit basket. To Odell, per Adam. Odell wants to know what a persimmon is for.* I send back a photo of the box on the whiteboard with *NASH* in it, and a while later Gordon sends a thumbs-up, which I’d guess took him ten minutes to find.

Adam lands near eleven on Monday night and texts me from the jet bridge: *Landed. Going to the room.*

I read it standing in the kitchen at my end of the counter. I hold the phone a while with my thumb over the keys, and then I type: *Come home.*

While the dots are going, I take the chipped Polish Falcons mug down from the cupboard over his coffee maker, wash it, and set it by my keys so I won’t forget it in the morning.

The dots come and go, and come and go again.

Tomorrow, he writes. At seven, in the room, if you’ll be there.

I stand at the counter with the phone. He wants it done where it stopped, in the room, at seven, out loud.

OK, I write. Then, a second later: I’ll be there at five to.

On Tuesday morning, in the dark, I’m in my room in the yard at Clyde Park with the heater on and the moka pot going on a hot plate I brought from home. I’m standing at my desk because I can’t sit. I’ve wiped the desk twice already, and refolded the afghan, which didn’t need it, and pushed the radiator chair an inch toward the heat and then back. The sleeping bag’s gone from under the desk, and the toothbrush from the windowsill, and the two wrinkled shirts from the coat hook. He took them all Sunday morning on his way to the airport, and he told me he would.

The afghan’s still on the shelf, corners square.

The yard’s black and first shift isn’t in yet. The maples along Clyde Park are still only shapes.

At five to seven, headlights come down Clyde Park Avenue and, instead of going on to the church lot, turn in at the gate. The code beeps, my birthday,

and the gate rolls back on its track, and the car crosses the yard and stops by the fence, and the headlights go off.

He doesn't knock, and he doesn't come to the door. He stands outside the glass corner in his long gray coat with a paper cup in one hand, the brass eagle on the sleeve, and he waits where I can see him, in the yard light. He stands where the post would be if there were a post.

I go to the door and open it, and the cold comes in.

"Hi," I say, and he says it back.

"It's six fifty-six," I tell him.

"I know, I'm early." He lifts the paper cup an inch. "I didn't bring yours, I figured you'd made it."

"I made it in my pot, and it's terrible."

"I know it is," he says. "I'd like some of it anyway."

I stand in the door of my room with one hand on the brass pull my father turned on his lathe in 2014, and there's my husband standing in the snow in the yard of my plant, early, with one coffee, waiting to be asked.

"Adam," I say, "do you want to come in?"

He waits for the whole sentence, every word of it, and then he says, "Yes."

He comes in, takes his coat off and hangs it on the hook by the door, where the shirts were. He sits down in the radiator chair and puts his feet up, crossed at the ankle, his good shoes with the salt lines, and the chair makes its creak, and the room settles a quarter inch. I pour the moka-pot coffee into the second mug, the one I brought from home too, the chipped one from the Polish Falcons fish fry, and hand it to him, and he holds it in both hands and drinks it and makes a face like a man drinking a tire.

"God, that's terrible," he says.

"You've always hated my coffee."

"I've always hated it," he agrees, and drinks some more.

I sit down at my desk, in my chair, set low, at my height, my feet flat on the floor. We sit there with the heater ticking and the yard going gray outside the glass, him with his feet on the radiator and me at the desk, and neither of us

says anything for a while. The light comes up, and the first car turns in at the gate, Benny's Silverado with its one bad headlight.

"Okay," I say, "what are we doing today?"

He goes still over the mug.

That was his line, *Okay, boss, what are we doing today?* Every morning for six years he'd come in just before seven and put his feet up and say that, and I'd tell him the whole day, and he'd listen, and argue, and then go out and sell it.

I've just said it to him.

He's quiet. His face does something I don't have catalogued, and I leave it that way and let it be new.

"I'd like to go home," he says. "Tonight, if you'll have me. I'd like to sleep in our room, not the one across the hall. I'd like to fix the room with the ladder, finally, or at least take the ladder out of it so it's just a room. I'd like to be out here at five to seven, every working day I'm in town, in this chair, and then drive downtown and do my job, which is selling what you build, honestly, out loud." He sets the mug on the radiator. "And I'd like you to tell me, every morning, at seven, what you're going to do before you do it. And I'll tell you, even if we don't agree, especially if we don't, like your mother and the thermostat."

"Who told you about my mother and the thermostat?"

"Your father, on Sunday. He called me while I was at the gate in Grand Rapids." He almost smiles. "He's never called me in eleven years. He said, *Kerrigan, it's Stan. Sit down, I've got a story about a thermostat.* And then he did, for twenty minutes, and I almost missed the flight."

I put my hand over my mouth.

"He said to tell you he's turning it to sixty-eight," Adam says, "and your mother doesn't know yet."

The laugh comes up out of me from all the way down, from the bottom of everything since Nashville, and I put my head down on the desk the way I did the night of the bowling hat, and laugh until I can't breathe, and he laughs too, and somewhere out in the yard Benny's slamming the door of his Silverado

and looking at the room with the lights on and both of us in it, and I don't care, I don't care at all who sees.

When I lift my head he's still in the chair, and he hasn't moved toward me. He's waiting.

"Home, the ladder, seven o'clock, all of it?"

"All of it, and you can say no to any of it. The ladder room's a big ask. There's a desk in there under the tax returns that I'm going to have to look at, and it's a very ugly desk."

"I know, I built it."

He blinks at me over the mug. "You built my old desk?"

"In the garage in 2014, out of a door from the Habitat ReStore and two sawhorses I welded. You've had it in the ladder room for six years under a pile of tax returns. You didn't know I built it?"

"I thought you bought it at a yard sale."

"You thought I bought you a desk at a yard sale."

"It looked like a yard-sale desk, Pip."

"It's a *door*, Adam, it's still got the hinge holes."

"I know that *now*," he says.

I get up and come around the desk, and he tracks me the whole way. I stand in front of his chair, and he tips his head back to see me, and doesn't reach, and doesn't say anything. He's gotten so good at waiting. It's the hardest thing I've seen him learn.

"Yes," I say, "to all of it, home and seven o'clock and the ladder." I put my hand on his face, cold from the yard. "I'm telling you before."

"Before what?"

"Before this," I say, and I ask him with my eyes, and he nods, once, very small, and I kiss him.

Three weeks ago, in the dark, I'd forgotten what he felt like, and now I remember all of it. It's the second bead on a joint you already know will hold, when you're running it because the work is good and your hands know where to go. His hand comes up to the back of my neck. The mug falls off the

radiator and doesn't break, because it's from the Polish Falcons, and those mugs have survived worse.

When I pull back, there's coffee on the floor and on my mother's rug. Neither of us looks at it.

"I love you," he says into my hair, quietly, and then he stops talking.

"I know," I say, with my mouth against his temple. "I love you too, and you still have to iron the shirts."

He laughs against my neck.

Out in the yard the knee line's coming on, and through the open rolling door the arcs start up under the yellow curtains, one, then another, the long crackle of the first beads of the day. The press brake goes *chunk*.

Benny's still standing by his truck in the snow with his lunch cooler in his hand, and he catches me looking at him through the glass.

He lifts his chin, once, and goes in to work.

Chapter 30 — Pip

On Friday, the day the bank in Chicago counts our money, my husband comes through the door of my room at five to seven with snow on his shoulders and an espresso in a paper cup, and the first thing he says is, “I’m going to call Kurt Lindahl this morning.”

I’m at my desk with the moka pot going on the hot plate, and I lift my head.

“Good morning to you too,” I say.

“Good morning. I’m going to call Kurt Lindahl.” He hangs his coat on the hook by the door, sits down in the radiator chair and puts his feet up, crossed at the ankle, his good shoes with the salt lines. The chair creaks and the room settles. It’s the fourth morning, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, Friday, and four is not a lot of mornings, and I find I’m counting them anyway.

I pour the moka pot into the Polish Falcons mug, which survived Tuesday, and hand it across to him. He drinks it and makes the face.

“God,” he says. “Every time.”

“You could stop drinking it.”

“No,” he says, “I can’t,” and drinks more, and I let that go by without picking it up, because it’s seven in the morning and some things are better left on the bench where you can see them.

“Why are you calling Kurt?”

“About the knee.” He sets the mug on the radiator. “Not the company. There’s no deal. Halvard’s got a line in Holland that puts posts in corners on their good rooms because nobody there can weld a moment frame. I want to offer to license the knee to them, for the high end. Welded here, by Lolo’s second shift, every frame stamped *Clyde Park* on the steel where nobody sees it. They sell it under their name, and we get paid for every one.” He tilts the mug at me. “I think he’ll say yes. He’s an admirer of the product.”

I sit there with my own coffee going cold in my hands.

“That’s a terrible idea,” I say.

“I know it is.”

“He’ll try to steal the weld schedule.”

“He’ll try, and he won’t get it.”

“Lolo will hate it.”

“Lolo hates everything until she’s training it.”

“I don’t agree with you, Adam.”

“I know. That’s why I’m telling you now and not calling him till nine.” He folds his hands on his stomach. “You can say no. Or you can say no and I call him anyway, and you tell me I was wrong at seven on Monday.”

Out the glass corner the yard’s going gray, and the maples on Clyde Park are coming up out of the dark. Benny’s Silverado isn’t in yet; it’s early, even for Benny.

“Call him at ten,” I say. “Not nine. I want to talk to Irene about glass first, and you don’t say the word *knee* to a man in a turtleneck until the weld schedule’s in the safe at my mother’s house, behind the pierogi.”

“Ten,” he says, and nods.

“And if he asks for the schedule, you hang up.”

“I hang up on him.”

“You don’t do the nose voice.”

“I’ve lost it, Pip. Gordon says I sound like a man reading a weather report.”

“Good,” I say. “Weather’s honest.”

He laughs, the real one, short, into the mug. When the mug’s empty he gets up and takes his coat off the hook. “Gordon and I are in the glass room all day. Neil said they’ll measure at close of business and call by five. I’ll text you when I know.”

“Text me before you know.”

“How do I text you before I know?”

“Text me when you’re scared,” I say. “That’s before.”

He stands in the door with one hand on my father’s brass pull a second longer than he needs to.

“Okay,” he says, and goes out across the yard to his car, and I don’t watch him go, I go back to the vise, but I hear the gate roll back and close, and I’d know the sound of his car out of every car in Michigan.

The radiator chair is pushed back at an angle where he got up out of it. I leave it.

The day is a Friday in a plant.

Irene and I spend an hour at the glazing table with the Holland quote and the Grand Rapids Glass quote side by side, and she runs one finger down the Holland one and stops on page three.

“Freight,” she says. “They hid it in the fuel surcharge. Eleven hundred a truck.”

I call Holland and tell them about it, and they take it off, because Holland would rather eat a freight charge than lose to Grand Rapids. Darnell comes in at eight with his eyes half shut and a photo of Nevaeh asleep on his chest that he shows to everybody on the knee line, one at a time, as if he’s passing a collection plate.

“Four hours,” he tells me when it’s my turn. “Four hours straight, in a row. I don’t even know what to do with my hands.”

At ten my phone rings on the glazing table, and it’s Adam. “I’m dialing him now,” he says. “Do you want to be on it? I’ll tell him you’re there.”

“Put me on.” I set it on speaker between Irene’s two quotes.

Then Kurt Lindahl, warm as a sauna. “Adam. Good to hear your voice.”

“Kurt, Pip’s on the line.”

“Philippa. What a pleasure.”

Adam lays it out in four sentences. Kurt says, “Let me think about it,” in a voice that means yes, and then, “In the meantime, if you could send over the weld schedule, just so our engineers can—“

“No,” Adam says, and hangs up, and the line goes dead between the quotes.

A minute later, the phone buzzes on the table: *Scared. Gordon has refreshed the bank portal so many times it asked him if he’s a robot.*

I write back: *Tell him to stop refreshing. It’s a bank. It doesn’t know he’s there.*

Lolo comes in early for second shift at noon to set up the training bay at the far end of the knee line, where twenty-three people from La Vergne,

Tennessee, are going to start on Monday. Twenty-two of them have found places to live, between the two duplexes Benny's cousin owns off Clyde Park, now that he's discovered he's a landlord with a heart, and the motel on Twenty-Eighth Street where Gordon got a rate. The twenty-third is Kiana, who's bringing Jaylen, and who texted Lolo on Wednesday to ask if Michigan has tornadoes, and Lolo texted back *only the one in the yard, hon*, which I think she's very proud of.

"You're really going to train them," I say, standing in the training bay with Lolo while she sets out coupons on the bench in a row like place settings.

"Time and a half," she says.

"You voted no."

"I voted no, and I lost. That's what voting is, hon. You lose, you show up Monday." She squares a coupon to the edge of the bench with one finger. "Eighteen months. That's what I told Kiana. I'm giving that girl eighteen months to make me unnecessary, and then I'm going to Florida whether you're rich or not."

"That's fair."

"It's not fair," Lolo says. "It's just how it is." Then she squints at me. "Where'd I hear that?"

"Don't."

"You say it in your sleep now. Benny heard you say it to the vending machine."

On her way out of the bay she stops at the whiteboard in the break room, uncaps the red marker, and writes under the vote, *LOLO: 18 MOS. THEN FLORIDA*, and underlines *FLORIDA* twice so nobody can say they weren't told.

Mid-afternoon my phone buzzes on the bench, a number with a 312 area code.

Haverhill offered. I start March 1. I have rented a truck for the 27th, which I priced, and I will unpack all fourteen boxes in Chicago. I have a door that closes there. It does not have a corner. I find I do not miss the corner.

And under it:

Also. The “two years” in Furnishings Weekly was Halvard’s own comms team. Gordon forwarded me the thread on Monday; I had been copied on it in January and never opened it. It was a new plan, written the day after Kurt stood in your yard. I thought you should know who the person familiar was. — S.

I stand there at the bench and read it twice.

Thank you, I start to type, and then I delete it, because she asked me not to, once, in writing.

I’m glad you know who it was, I write instead. I’m glad you have a door.

The answer comes back a minute later.

Tell him the shirt is wrong. Tavi sent me a photo. The crease is on the wrong side of the sleeve.

Near five my phone rings, and it isn’t Adam. It’s Gordon.

“Pip,” he says, and he’s in the stairwell, because I can hear the pigeons. “Pip. Adam’s still on with Neil, so he told me to call you.” He takes a breath. “Six point four one at close. The escrow from eight days of cuts, Gil’s terms, and a week of Nashville we didn’t spend. Neil just called. We’re over the floor by four hundred and ten thousand dollars.” He laughs, a little wildly. “One week of Nashville, Pip. Almost to the dollar.”

I sit down on the stool at my bench.

“Gordon,” I say.

“I know,” he says. “I know. I’m going to go sit in my car for a while.”

He hangs up. I sit there on the stool with the phone in my hand. Across the floor the knee line is running under the yellow curtains, four arcs going, the long crackle of the beads. The press brake goes *chunk*. Somebody’s radio is playing Bob Seger, because it’s always Bob Seger at five o’clock on a Friday in West Michigan; it’s a law.

My phone buzzes again, and it’s Adam: *Gordon called you?*

He called me, I write.

Okay. Then, a second later: I’m going to sit in the car with Gordon for a while.

I go out to the break room. Darnell's there, getting his coat on, with his lunch cooler and the photo of Nevaeh as his phone background. Benny's there with a cruller from a box somebody left on the counter, and a couple of the kids from glazing, and Tavi at the microwave cart with his laptop open on the dashboard that still shows the dots.

Every one of them stops what they're doing.

"We're over," I say. "The bank. Four hundred and ten thousand over."

Nobody says anything for a second. Then Darnell takes his coat back off, goes to the whiteboard, uncaps the green marker, and under the vote, under Lolo's eighteen months, under the count, he writes in his blocky capitals: *FEB 12 — OVER*. He caps the marker and stands back and studies it with his hands on his hips.

"That's going to stay up there," he says. "Nobody erase that."

"Nobody's erasing it," says Benny, with his mouth full.

Tavi doesn't say anything. He looks at his laptop, at the map of orange dots, and then he closes it, gently, and for once he doesn't tell anybody the number.

Second shift comes on at three and goes off at eleven-thirty, and somewhere in between I go back out to the room in the yard, because it's mine and I like it there. I sit at my desk with the lamp on and do nothing at all, and the building stays up. Out the glass corner, the yard light makes its white circle on the snow. The rolling door is up and the knee line is lit, and through it Lolo's at the far end in the training bay, alone, setting out one more coupon on the bench, and then standing there over the row of them with her hands in her jacket pockets.

The phone buzzes once more, and it's Adam. *Out of the car, Gordon's okay. I'm going home, are you?*

Soon, I write. By eleven.

I'll leave the light on in the kitchen.

I set the phone face up on the desk and sit back in my chair, set low, my feet flat on the floor.

His chair is still where he left it this morning, pushed back from the radiator at an angle.

I don't straighten it. He'll want it at five to seven.

A Note to Readers

Thank you for reading *My CEO Husband Gave Her My Corner Office*.

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Thank you for spending your time with Pip and Adam, and with a room ten by twelve with no post in the corner.

Shawn J Dean